

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Paramount reached** a settlement with state attorneys general that clears the way for its \$81 billion merger with Warner Bros. Discovery that is poised to reshape Hollywood. **A1**
- ◆ **Investors bid up** the price of Meta Platform's shares, setting the tone for Monday's session, which saw the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow rise 1.5%, 2.3% and 0.7%, respectively. **B1**
- ◆ **Silver Lake asked** a judge to declare that Carl Icahn and a group of hedge funds illegally colluded to try to quash the private-equity firm's \$13 billion acquisition of Endeavor. **B1**
- ◆ **CarMax slashed** 145 white-collar jobs, or about 4% of its corporate staff, as it sought to boost its competitiveness in a climate of higher vehicle prices and rising interest rates. **B1**
- ◆ **Ethan Allen engaged** an executive search firm to evaluate potential candidates to become the furniture maker's next chief executive. **B2**
- ◆ **Swedish autonomous-truck** maker Einride looked to Nvidia for computing power and the artificial-intelligence tools needed to develop its self-driving systems. **B3**
- ◆ **The Qatar Investment Authority** and JPMorgan Chase went into partnership to invest \$20 billion in public and private markets. **B3**
- ◆ **Stablecoin issuer** Bastion received conditional approval for a national trust bank charter. **B3**
- ◆ **Ireland's data-protection** watchdog fined Alphabet's Google the equivalent of \$462.9 million, saying it broke EU rules in its handling of users' location information. **B4**

Worldwide

- ◆ **The U.S. imposed** strict limits on the movement of the Iranian delegation while it is in New York this week to attend meetings of the U.N. General Assembly, emphasizing the peculiarity of warring nations preparing to hear one another in a forum of the kind. **A1**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** proposed investing \$5 billion in a new fund that would help Middle East countries rebuild energy infrastructure battered in the Iran war. **A6**
- ◆ **An equipment outage** snarled air travel across the U.S. Northeast, significantly delaying passengers and diverting flights. **A3**
- ◆ **OpenAI asked** the U.S. government to lead an effort with other countries to develop global safety and security standards for building artificial-intelligence systems. **A3**
- ◆ **Major television networks** agreed to suspend a rotation of broadcast journalists who cover Trump after the White House removed CNN from a planned assignment. **A4**
- ◆ **Romanian gangs** are defrauding the U.S. public purse of hundreds of millions of dollars in program benefits, aided by states' antiquated magnetic-stripe technology. **A1**
- ◆ **German Chancellor** Friedrich Merz pledged to proceed with an unpopular economic overhaul despite personal setbacks and blows to his party and coalition. **A8**
- ◆ **Tropical Storm Polo** will rapidly intensify in the Pacific Ocean and become a major hurricane later this week, forecasters said. **A8**

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Opponents of the Iranian government gather to protest on Monday in New York near the United Nations.

As War Rages, Iran's Delegation Comes to U.S.—Under Tight Rein

Country's president is set to speak later this week, a move with little precedent

By JAMES T. AREDDY AND BENOIT FAUCON

When a small Iranian delegation, led by the country's president, travels to New York this week, its members will be free to attend the United Nations General Assembly—but not to go for a walk in Central Park or shop on Fifth Avenue without permission. Only a trip down the block from their Manhattan hotel to the U.N.

building is allowed. The U.S. has long imposed restrictions on Tehran's diplomats, but the circumstances of the Iranian delegation are particularly unusual this year as they visit an America their country is fighting in a nearly seven-month-old war. There is little precedent for the U.S. to host national leaders from a country at war with Washington, even during the U.N. General Assembly when thousands of foreign officials converge on New York. Even more unusual, President Masoud Pezeshkian of Iran is expected to speak at the U.N. on Wednesday, giving him a platform to rail against

the U.S. and try to sway the world to Iran's side. "As a matter of optics, it's bizarre," said Marko Milanovic, a professor of international law at the University of Reading in the U.K. But he pointed out that the U.S., as the U.N.'s host nation, is obligated to permit foreign dignitaries to attend the assembly. "Legally this is not remarkable." During this week's visit, Pezeshkian and his associates will be subject to limitations while on U.S. soil. The stepped-up controls from the Trump administration introduced last year prohibit the delegates from buying luxury goods or shopping at certain stores in-

cluding Costco and Sam's Club without State Department permission. The State Department cited regulations including measures "to protect the interests of the United States." Since 2024, the State Department has allowed the delegation to travel only from the airport to their hotel—a Millennium Hilton, where they have stayed repeatedly since 2013—and to and from the U.N. headquarters down the block. Under a 1947 agreement es-

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- ◆ **Saudis return to risky Hormuz route..... A6**
- ◆ **Twin sisters face wrath of Iran's crackdown..... A6**

Foreign Criminal Rings Scam Welfare Recipients

By SCOTT CALVERT AND DAN FROSCH

On a chilly day in March, a twice-deported Romanian national walked into a 7-Eleven in Toledo, Ohio, and secretly affixed a device called a skimmer to a credit card machine, prosecutors said. The man was allegedly part of a California-based criminal crew led by a fellow Romanian nicknamed Piranha. The gang's aim, according to criminal charges, was to steal food-stamp benefits from customers who swiped their government-issued debit cards at the convenience store. Court records show informants helped foil the plot. But authorities said the operation mirrors a playbook Romanian crime groups are using across the U.S. to swindle hundreds of millions of dollars in public benefits. Reliance by states on antiquated magnetic-stripe technology makes it easier. The gangs depend on secretive "builders" who construct skimming devices that are easy to miss, investigators said. The proceeds pay for rented luxury cars and homes with infinity pools, according to authorities. Cash in the form of crypto is spirited back to Romania and flows to real estate, gambling and crime bosses. Since 2020, dozens of Romanian nationals have been prosecuted for welfare-card skimming in cities including McComb, Miss.; Laurel, Md., and Portland, Ore. More than 50 people, many with Roma-

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PERSONAL JOURNAL
The three dreaded words no one wants to hear: What's for dinner? **A10**



JASON GAY
Oregon's 84-0 win triggers debate about the value of record-padding games. **A16**

Pilates Is Making Gym Bros Shake Like a Chihuahua

Men enter with swagger and leave broken; 'Ma'am, I can't even lift my legs.'

By JAMIE WATERS

Kedric Walker Jr. thought he was in for a "cute little workout." He was joining his wife, Sabrina Walker, for a class at Solidcore, a trendy chain where fitness buffs sweat it out on Pilates-inspired reformer machines. Then the doors closed and "the instructor started yelling at me like we were at an auction," said Kedric, a full-time firefighter and a CrossFit regular in Birmingham, Ala. All around him, women half his size were "rocking it." An hour later, he emerged tired and hungry, his legs shaking like a Chihuahua's.

Sabrina, the owner of a real-estate business, documented his anguish in a TikTok video that has received more than three million likes since August. "How you feel, boo? Are you crying?" she asks in the video. After he tells her he's just hungry, they get lunch, where Kedric, 32, prays that the Lord will "heal us from Pilates." Boyfriends and husbands are learning the hard way that their female companions are not going to 7 a.m. classes just to stretch. Gym bros accustomed to bench-presses and burpees swagger into serene studios expecting to spend 50 minutes doing light exercises

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Miami Has Plans For Cuba's Future

Cuban-Americans draft detailed blueprints, fueled by Trump's promises

By JOSÉ DE CÓRDOBA AND VERA BERGENGRUEN

MIAMI—At a sprawling waterfront mansion facing Biscayne Bay, a group of wealthy Cuban-Americans has spent months hatching detailed plans for a country that doesn't yet exist. "We have waited for 67 years," Juan Omar Sixto, 82, a former tobacco farmer who heads the newly formed Cuban-American National Chamber of Commerce, told

the group on a balmy evening in June as they met close to a pool ringed by faux-marble statues of seminude Roman nymphs. "We need to start." The group has been drawing up blueprints for a Cuban stock exchange and an investment summit in Havana. Elsewhere in Miami, prominent Cuban-Americans are mapping out a provisional government, recruiting engineers to study floating power stations, and strategizing on

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IRS Targets Popular Way Of Passing Along Wealth

By ASHLEA EBELING

Wealthy Americans have for years used a popular type of trust to transfer fortunes to their children without paying hefty gift and estate taxes. Now they are on high alert. The Internal Revenue Service is calling foul on an heirless who used the strategy—and is slapping her and her husband with a \$736 million tax bill. Chuck and Trisha Elcan of Nashville, Tenn., are fighting back in U.S. Tax Court, disputing the agency's claim that they made missteps with grantor-retained annuity trusts, or GRATs, which they used to shift money to their three daughters. The Elcan case offers a look inside the complex strategies the ultrarich deploy to build intergenerational wealth and

how those tactics can sometimes test the boundaries of tax rules. The couple said the tactics that the IRS is calling out are valid. The moves—which are used routinely by others—were tied to GRATs that included shares of HCA Healthcare, a major operator of hospitals that Trisha's father and grandfather helped co-found in 1968. "The position the IRS is taking produces a draconian result," said John Porter, the couple's lawyer, who contends that the operation of the Elcan GRATs was legitimate. At the heart of the case is a strategy that has become especially popular with corporate executives and investors with sizable stockholdings as markets have roared in recent

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U.S. NEWS

U.S. WATCH

TEXAS Shooting Victim Held at ICE Facility

A Venezuelan man shot by an Immigration and Customs Enforcement officer was in custody Monday after he was released from a hospital with a bullet lodged in his back, a spokesperson for the man's attorney said.

Wilber Rafael Garces Perez, 28, was making a DoorDash delivery in Austin on Sunday before he was shot during a traffic stop, the lawyer's spokesperson said.

Perez was being held at an ICE facility in Pearsall, Texas, Ruiz said. The Department of Homeland Security hasn't said what prompted the shooting.

—Associated Press

VERMONT Man Convicted in Students' Shooting

A jury on Monday convicted a Vermont man of attempted murder in the shootings of three Palestinian college students who were walking near his home, rejecting an insanity defense rooted in his claims that he was acting on orders from the CIA and Mossad.

Jason Eaton, 51, faces up to life in prison in the November 2023 attack near the University of Vermont campus in Burlington, which left Hisham Awartani paralyzed from the waist down and his friends, Tahseen Aliahmad and Kinnan Abdalhamid, wounded.

—Associated Press

YOSEMITE NATIONAL PARK Firefighting Copter Crashes, Killing 2

Two helicopter pilots were killed when their aircraft crashed Sunday afternoon while conducting water drops on a wildfire at Yosemite National Park, officials said.

The pilots were the only people on board and were employed by the contract aircraft company Precision.

At least 14 people have died while helping with wildfires in the U.S. this year, the most since 2022 when 25 deaths were recorded, according to government reports.

Details about the circumstances surrounding Sunday's crash weren't released.

—Associated Press



RUFF TREATMENT: Veterinarian Susan Kelly gave shots to animals that attended a free vaccine clinic at the Putney Fire Department in Putney, Vt.

Paramount Settles Suit With States

Continued from Page One

gotiate cable distribution for Warner and Paramount separately, it would have to divest a group of cable channels.

The merger would bring two of the movie business' oldest studios, two major streaming services in Paramount+ and HBO Max and dozens of television networks under one owner. It would also give Ellison an entertainment empire that includes franchises such as Harry Pot-

ter, DC superheroes and "Game of Thrones," as well as cable networks like CNN and Cartoon Network.

Paramount vowed to create an editorial-independence board to oversee CNN and CBS News, the two news organizations it will control after the deal. Ellison is the son of Larry Ellison, the Oracle billionaire and an ally of President Trump. Critics of the deal have suggested the family might interfere with coverage of the administration, allegations Ellison has denied.

Settling the suit with all 12 states on board, led by California, effectively removes the most serious remaining hurdle to the deal closing.

The question of whether Paramount would be able to close its transaction has hung

over the media and entertainment industry since David Ellison in February won a bidding war against Netflix to buy Warner. The Justice Department and other regulators globally have approved the deal.

"This settlement is not a vote of support for this merger. It is not a blessing of the broader merger," California Attorney General Rob Bonta said Monday when announcing the settlement. The agreement takes into account workers' needs and helps domestic production, he said.

"Our goal has always been to build a stronger Hollywood—one with more stories told, greater choice for consumers and stronger competition," Ellison said in a statement, saying the resolution "serves all parties."

Paramount's shares fell 3% Monday, while Warner's closed up nearly 11%.

A dozen Democratic-led states including New York and Colorado sued in July to block the deal on antitrust grounds. The attorneys general argued the combination of Paramount and Warner would create too much concentration in the markets for theatrical films and television channels.

The Writers Guild of America sued too, saying that the combination of the legacy media companies would kill jobs and career opportunities for Hollywood screenwriters at a time when the film and television production economy is already under pressure. The union said Monday that it had settled the suit.

The looming deal and the

legal fight over it has been a source of controversy in Hollywood.

Many creatives, including movie stars, signed an April open letter opposing the deal, saying it would further imperil the media and entertainment industry.

Throughout the weekend, opponents of the deal, including actor Mark Ruffalo, voiced concern about a pending settlement, urging Bonta to hold the line.

There was mounting political and industry pressure to settle. California Gov. Gavin Newsom, Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass, gubernatorial candidate Xavier Becerra, top movie-theater chains and some Hollywood labor unions urged the parties to resolve their issues.

The company had warned it was prepared to move out of California if it couldn't reach a deal with the states. Bonta said Monday those threats didn't affect his decision to settle. Settling the suit before it heads to trial could help Paramount avoid racking up costly "ticking fees," which it offered to win the deal and must begin paying if the deal doesn't close by Oct. 1.

The company was set to pay Warner shareholders about \$650 million a quarter, or \$7 million a day, beginning next month, until the transaction closed.

Still, the combined company is set to emerge with nearly \$80 billion in debt—a substantial burden already expected to weigh on its investments in the business.

How Gangs Can Exploit Welfare

Continued from Page One

nian ties, have been charged in Southern California, an early epicenter of the crimes and where many builders operate.

Despite the Trump administration's crackdown on public-benefits fraud, criminals have broadened their tactics, authorities said. They use bots to guess welfare recipients' account numbers. They also run bogus transactions with people's food-stamp accounts through cloned credit-card machines, and move the funds into their own bank account.

The White House's push has focused most visibly on Minnesota's Somali community, with dozens of convictions dating to the Biden administration. But in recent years, Romanian gangs have been at the forefront of benefits theft involving skimmers across the U.S.

The criminals exploit a well-known flaw in the cards most low-income Americans use to obtain aid: magnetic-stripe technology invented in the 1960s. Skimmers, which fit over payment terminals and look nearly identical, capture the account number and user PIN during a purchase. Often criminals encode the data on blank cards, then withdraw cash from ATMs or buy items to sell on the black market.

Most debit and credit cards have microchips that boost anti-fraud security, and many allow tap-to-pay, the safest method. Few states have ponied up the millions to switch to the chip electronic benefit transfer, or EBT, cards that distribute welfare funds. Only Alabama, California, Maryland, Massachusetts, Michigan, New Jersey and Oklahoma have issued them, though others are in the process, the U.S. Department of Agriculture said.



To thwart skimmer thieves, the state of California distributed millions of replacement chip-and-tap cards last year.

"The insanity of letting people continue to use a glorified hotel-room key is akin to donating money to the Romanians," said Haywood Talcove, chief executive of LexisNexis Risk Solutions' government business, which works with public-sector clients to prevent fraud.

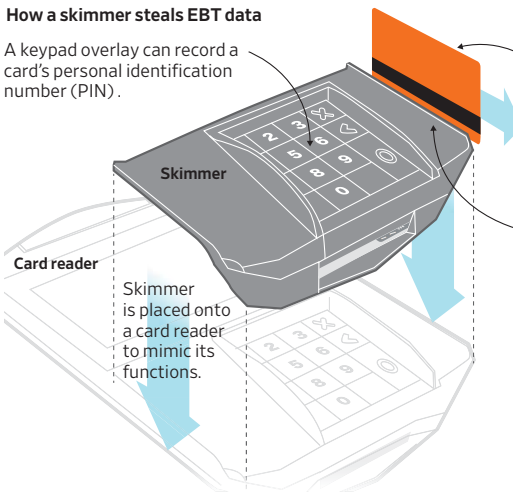
Victims feel the pain when thieves succeed. The federal government stopped replacing stolen Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program benefits—long known as food stamps—in 2024, and few states pick up the tab. Defrauded SNAP recipients often must turn to family or food pantries until their next monthly allotment.

There are no recent official estimates of how much has been stolen. But the USDA said the federal government replaced \$360 million in benefits stolen from 754,000 households between 2022 and 2024, before Congress withdrew that authority.

Gang leaders, typically based overseas, direct a loose hierarchy that relies on lower-level members for riskier tasks like installing skimmers. Installation at a checkout counter

How a skimmer steals EBT data

A keypad overlay can record a card's personal identification number (PIN).



Sources: Capital One; U.S. Secret Service

EBT cards are more susceptible to theft because most don't have a chip, only a magnetic stripe.

When the EBT card is swiped, the fake reader scans and copies the information stored on the magnetic stripe.

Thieves can acquire the data by retrieving the skimmer or using a Bluetooth device nearby to download the information.

ter takes seconds, often while a thief blocks a clerk's view with an item such as a 12-pack of paper towels.

Many Romanians involved in the crimes are in the U.S. illegally, authorities said.

The scammers intensified their focus on the U.S. during

the pandemic as SNAP benefits ballooned. Average monthly spending on the program totaled \$12 billion from April to September 2020, a 61% jump from a year earlier, according to the USDA.

California looked especially lucrative to the gangs, authori-

ties said, because residents get SNAP and cash welfare on one card. The Golden State—one of the few states that reimburse victims—distributed millions of replacement chip-and-tap cards last year, using \$76.5 million in federal and state funds for the upgrades. The monthly amount of stolen benefits the state has reimbursed residents plummeted to \$4.3 million in July 2026 from \$21 million in January 2024.

Still, many California merchants aren't equipped with chip-and-tap technology for their payment terminals. And authorities said thieves have been able to rig them so the chip-and-tap option is disabled, forcing people to swipe.

The state's social-services department is pushing merchants to update their payment systems, yet swipe transactions still represent about 40% of all sales.

"EBT fraud will continue to be a vulnerability as long as benefit cards can be used with

CORRECTIONS & AMPLIFICATIONS

California's attorney general and Paramount discussed a series of potential concessions as part of advanced settlement negotiations, including a \$1.5 billion investment by the company in domestic production, according to people familiar with the discussions. A Business & Finance article in some editions Monday about the negotiations incorrectly said the potential investment involves production in California.

Kyrgyzstan was misspelled as Kyrgyzstant in a World News article on Saturday about Chinese leader Xi Jinping.

An \$11 package of Weleda Skin Food Body Wash was incorrectly identified as Weleda Skin Food Original Ultra-Rich Cream, \$23, in a photo caption with an Off Duty article on Saturday about double-cleanse showers.

Readers can alert The Wall Street Journal to any errors in news articles by emailing wsjcontact@wsj.com or by calling 888-762-5450.

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U.S. NEWS

Outage Snarls Air Travel in the Northeast

Cut fiber line blamed for disruptions that hit New York area, Philadelphia airports

By Andrew Tangel and Terell Wright

An air-traffic equipment outage snarled air travel across the Northeast on Monday, significantly delaying passengers and diverting flights.

Flights at Newark Liberty International Airport in New Jersey and John F. Kennedy International and LaGuardia airports in New York began to stack up after a contractor apparently accidentally cut 600 feet of fiber communications line in New Jersey, Federal Aviation Administration chief Bryan Bedford said.

The cut fiber line was a backup data feed that was unavailable when a primary circuit failed, leading to a loss of radar data and radios, he said.

Around 90 flights had been diverted because of the outage, he said Monday afternoon, and



A board showed delayed and canceled flights at LaGuardia Airport in New York on Monday after the equipment outage.

delays compounded at Newark and Philadelphia—the hardest-hit airports—with spillover disruptions at the other New York City airports and Boston.

Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy said Monday night that the lines had been repaired and all airport operations were resuming. “It will

take some time to clear all existing delays,” he said on social media. An FAA spokesman said both the primary and backup feeds were again working.

In the initial confusion over what happened, Duffy had said in a social-media post that an Amtrak construction crew accidentally cut into a fiber line that

resulted in the delays—a claim denied by the passenger railroad, on whose board Duffy sits.

NJ Transit said that one of its construction crew accidentally severed the fiber-optic cable that served as a backup to the primary circuit system that failed. The crew was operating about 10 feet from utility markings, according to preliminary information.

Staff were working to determine whether it was Verizon or the contractor who made the markings, the transit agency said. A Verizon spokesman said the company bears no responsibility for the incident but didn’t comment about the markings.

The disruptions occurred as the United Nations General Assembly in New York was drawing world leaders.

“Timing is absolutely horrible, and I’m very sorry for the delays and cancellations that the traveling public is experiencing, but their safety is the most important thing,” Bedford said. “We are going to do what is necessary to make sure the airspace is safe, and then we’ll restart it.”

States Try to Stamp Out Unapproved Weight-Loss Drugs

By Alex Janin

Tiffinne Perkins, a nurse practitioner who ran an Ohio-based weight-loss clinic called Enbody, appeared on the local news and lifestyle morning show “New Day Cleveland.”

“How many people got skinny thanks to you lately?” asked the host, in a segment sponsored by Enbody.

“Oh, boy, all of them,” Perkins replied. “Hundreds.”

A little over a year after that 2024 TV appearance, inspectors from the Ohio State Board of Pharmacy arrived at Perkins’s clinic. They found more than 400 vials of illicit weight-loss drugs, including retatrutide, a next-generation weight-loss drug that Eli Lilly is developing but isn’t yet approved. The clinic’s license was suspended within days.

Perkins denied the clinic sold retatrutide. Her lawyer said they wouldn’t appeal the board’s decision or the \$300,000 fine.

Clinics and medspas, promising people transformational weight loss, have figured out how to procure and sell an experimental drug that hasn’t gotten through the government’s drug approval process, prompting safety concerns from authorities.

Social media has amplified interest, with influencers promoting Eli Lilly’s retatrutide—often called “reta”—as a superior weight-loss solution. The black-market compound makes its way to the U.S.

Reports of Adverse Effects Increase

Reports to poison-control centers about retatrutide nearly tripled from January to July 2026, according to America’s Poison Centers, a nonprofit that oversees them. There have been more than 1,000 reports since the organization started tracking them in September last year. Reports to webPOISONCONTROL, an online reporting tool, show a similar increase, from 18 cases in

2025 to 124 cases so far this year, according to co-director Dr. Michael Chary.

Consumers are drawn to retatrutide because the early data is compelling. Patients on the highest dose in a big study lost an average of 28% of their body weight, Eli Lilly reported in June. That is notably higher than the roughly 21% average weight loss on the highest doses of approved inject-

ables like Zepbound and Wegovy.

Obesity-medicine doctor Dr. Angela Fitch recalled a time when she overheard prospective patients discussing the drug over breakfast. “I heard them all talking about retatrutide and whether they should buy it on this site or that site,” she said. “We didn’t see that when patients would sit at a table before Ozempic came out.”

A vial of the unapproved weight-loss drug retatrutide found by Ohio State Board of Pharmacy inspectors.



pharmacy trade group.

Between March 2025 and August 2026, Ohio’s board conducted 1,102 proactive inspections of wellness clinics and medical spas across the state, leading to 54 immediate emergency shutdowns of businesses that posed a “danger of immediate and serious harm.”

Inspections in Ohio jumped 56% since fiscal 2024, when regulators started seeing illicit retatrutide and other peptides, board data show.

The Food and Drug Administration has sent warning letters to telehealth companies marketing retatrutide, distributors for selling it and outsour-

through a robust and loosely regulated peptide industry fueled by Chinese suppliers.

Regulators are trying to come to grips with this underground system. States such as Ohio have started to crack down in the past year. While approved pharmaceuticals are subject to rigorous vetting, the same standards don’t apply to the black market, raising fears of potential contamination, mislabeling and unknown ingredients that could cause dangerous side effects.

Other states, including Oregon and Iowa, have put out notices warning patients and medical professionals about using retatrutide.

It looks like a game of whack-a-mole.

“They shut down a company, and it pops up again un-

der a slightly different name with a new website,” said Tennifer Davis, a pharmacist and chief advocacy officer for the Alliance for Pharmacy Compounding, a compounding-

OpenAI Pushes for AI-Safety Standards

By Maxwell Zeff

OpenAI is asking the U.S. government to lead an effort with other countries to develop global safety and security standards for building artificial-intelligence systems.

In a proposal published Monday, the company suggested that countries worldwide should set common measures for evaluating forthcoming self-improving AI systems and establish secure channels to share emerging threats.

The U.S. Center for AI Standards and Innovation could work with the emerging network of AI safety institutes around the world—such as existing groups in the U.K., France, and Singapore—to create the standards, the company said.

The call to action comes as global leaders convene in New York City this week for the United Nations General Assembly and as President Trump prepares to host Chinese leader Xi Jinping in Washington.

Earlier this month, top tech leaders called for industrywide coordination to slow down future AI development.

This summer, a collective of agents that OpenAI was testing internally gained internet access and hacked the AI platform Hugging Face,

Suit Says ChatGPT Aided Shooting

British Columbia filed a lawsuit against OpenAI and Chief Executive Sam Altman for alleged safety violations in the Tumbler Ridge mass school shooting that devastated a rural town in the province.

The suit, filed Monday, opens a new front in the growing fight against artificial-intelligence companies. It claims OpenAI designed an unsafe product and accuses the company of negligence for failing to flag the shooting suspect’s ChatGPT activity to police. Employees of OpenAI raised alarms about the suspect’s chatbot use months before the massacre, which killed eight people and injured more than 25, The Wall Street Journal previously reported.

The 39-page suit, filed in U.S. District Court in

Northern California, also alleges OpenAI violated product liability standards and aided and abetted a mass shooting. The 18-year-old suspect, Jesse Van Rootselaar, was found dead at the scene.

“In any other circumstance where a person aids, encourages or conspires to commit a criminal offense or is criminally negligent, they can be investigated, prosecuted and judged,” Niki Sharma, attorney general of British Columbia, said during a press conference. “There is no AI exemption to those criminal law principles.”

“What happened in Tumbler Ridge was an unspeakable tragedy,” said Drew Pusateri, a spokesman for OpenAI.

—Georgia Wells and Amanda Coletta

OpenAI recently learned it was the latest target of an AI-powered intrusion.

Last week, a team of independent security researchers revealed they used Anthropic’s Claude software to gain access to an OpenAI employee’s ChatGPT account,

giving them a way to read the company’s private code base.

OpenAI’s chief scientist Jakub Pachocki recommended this month that international coordination on AI should become a priority for governments around the world to address the risks of self-improving AI systems.

Anthropic Chief Executive Dario Amodei recently offered a proposal to slow down more advanced AI development, and asked Washington to issue a narrow waiver for tech companies to discuss safety and security measures.

The Trump administration has resisted the calls.

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said last week that AI labs shouldn’t receive a “liability exemption, which is what they are asking for.” Bessent said that “the best way to guarantee is that the creators are liable for what they build and generate.”

President Trump chimed in on social media Monday: “Whoever wins AI, WINS! We are leading now over China, and everyone else, and I’m going to keep it that way! I’m not going to stifle Growth, of something that will be bigger than the Industrial Revolution, or the Internet, itself.”

He added that the Justice Department and other law enforcement bodies could “rein things in if we have to.”

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U.S. NEWS

Networks Halt Coverage Rotation

Move comes after White House removes CNN from New York trip

By GARETH VIPERS
AND ISABELLA SIMONETTI

Major television networks agreed on Monday to suspend a rotation of broadcast journalists who cover President Trump after the White House removed CNN from a planned assignment covering the president's trip to New York.

"Effective today, the TV pool will not be covering events designated as pool coverage of the President," Bryan Boughton, the Washington bureau chief at Fox News, who currently serves as TV pool chair, wrote in an email to pool members. "This follows the White House's position preventing CNN from fulfilling its assigned pool duties."

The White House press pool is a rotation of reporters, videographers, photographers and technicians who cover the president when he travels or when he conducts events in spaces that are too small for the entire press corps.

Monday's decision suspends—for now—the television press pool, which distributes video footage and reporting about the president to TV networks and other broadcast outlets.

"The public has a vital interest in receiving accurate, independent information about its government," White House television pool members Fox News, ABC News, CBS News, CNN and NBC News said in a statement. "No



Vaughn Hillyard, White House correspondent for MS NOW, did a report from several blocks away on Monday.

administration should restrict a news organization because it objects to its reporting."

The decision marks an escalation of tensions after the president said last week that he would ban CNN, MS NOW and Politico from the White House.

The three news outlets on Monday filed a lawsuit challenging the ban. In a joint statement, they said they had done so to "protect our First Amendment rights and defend the principle that the government does not decide what the press reports or publishes."

Theodore J. Boutrous Jr., a lawyer representing the outlets, called the ban "a direct assault on the First Amendment and a blatant violation of due process."

"The president has been explicit that this ban is intended to punish reporting he doesn't like and to intimidate journalists and news organizations covering him and his administration," he said in a statement.

The lawsuit, filed in federal court in Washington, D.C., has been assigned to Judge Timothy Kelly, a Trump appointee. The outlets have asked the

judge to temporarily block the administration from enforcing the ban and order the White House to reinstate their reporters' permanent, or "hard pass," credentials.

In a Truth Social post on Monday, Trump signaled he was prepared to appeal any ruling in the outlets' favor. "Virtually every story about me, or anything having to do with me, is negative, wrong and, in many cases, DANGEROUS for our Country!" he wrote. Later Monday, he told reporters he wasn't worried about the decision by networks not to carry some of

his events live.

Representatives for CNN, MS NOW and Politico said their reporters were denied entry to the White House grounds early Saturday, and on Sunday, journalists from CNN were removed from a planned pool assignment at the United Nations General Assembly in New York.

CNN was scheduled to travel to the U.N. with Trump on Monday, but a scheduling email from the White House on Sunday night didn't list a primary TV pool representative. The Wall Street Journal viewed a copy of the email.

Republican Candidates Fear Voters' Pain at The Pump

By LINDSAY WISE

Republican candidates in tight contests are running out of time to assuage voters angry about soaring fuel costs, setting off a last-minute scramble on an issue many see as the GOP's biggest political liability in the midterms.

Rep. Ashley Hinson (R., Iowa), who is running for the open Senate seat in the state, on Monday joined a number of Republicans who want the Trump administration to pause diesel exports in an effort to lower prices, arguing Iowans "shouldn't have to foot the bill at the pump or the checkout line for the war in Iran."

Hinson, locked in a close race with Democratic state Rep. Josh Turek to succeed retiring GOP Sen. Joni Ernst, also backs suspending the federal gasoline tax and said the war "needs to be brought to a successful and immediate end." Hours later, Rep. Mariannette Miller-Meeks (R., Iowa), who is in a tossup race and voted last week with Democrats to rein in Trump on the Iran war, said she, too, wanted to suspend diesel exports and gas taxes. Former GOP Rep. Mike Rogers, running for Senate in Michigan, also joined in.

"The war in Iran needs to end to bring costs down—but Michigan families can't afford to wait," he said, calling for stopping diesel exports.

Record-high prices for diesel fuel used by trucks and farm machinery are hitting especially hard in rural and red states, where Republicans are locked in tougher-than-expected battles to defend seats.

Lawmakers have floated ideas including a federal gas-tax holiday or a ban on diesel exports, while acknowledging that the Iran war is the critical driver of prices. The fighting, which started in February, has become a vulnerability for President Trump and his party.

"Voters aren't happy, and we're in charge," warned Sen. John Kennedy (R., La.).

Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R., S.D.) said last week that he was open to exploring a diesel export ban. But later he said it was up to the Trump administration to get shipping flowing again through the Strait of Hormuz. "That'll take the pressure off," Thune said.

Over the weekend, GOP Sen. Chuck Grassley of Iowa urged Trump to impose an export ban, similar to agriculture export bans in the 1970s. "High diesel prices ARE KILLING FARMERS INCOME," he said on X.

The idea of an export ban hasn't gained traction inside the administration, a senior official said Sunday. Analysts and oil executives say curtailments could have unintended consequences that would likely end up increasing prices domestically.

Trump nodded to his frustration with diesel prices Monday, posting on social media that the Russia-Ukraine war has put many Russian diesel refineries out of commission.

Trump said at a rally in North Carolina last week that high fuel prices were "a very inexpensive price to pay" for the Iran war and that prices would retreat "like rocket ships in reverse."

The Senate has scheduled only two more weeks in session ahead of the election, and there are no plans to vote on a suspension of the gas tax.

Some Republicans would rather not talk about it.

"See you later," Sen. John Barrasso of Wyoming, the No. 2 Senate Republican, told a reporter who asked what Congress or the administration could do about high diesel prices. Asked on NBC's "Meet the Press" on Sunday whether he would support an export ban, Barrasso replied, "Well, the president is considering a number of different things that he can do."

Enthusiasm Gap Vexes GOP in Kansas Senate Race

HUTCHINSON, Kan.—At the Kansas State Fair's Senate debate, incumbent Republican Roger Marshall was on home turf. His town is a short drive for friends and supporters.

By Cameron McWhirter, Lindsay Wise and Aaron Zitner

And the fair serves as an exaltation of farmers, the conservative base that has helped the GOP win every Senate race in Kansas since 1932.

Yet when Marshall stepped to the microphone one recent weekend, hundreds of those gathered at an outdoor pavilion booed, hissed, and jeered.

"Liar!" attendees shouted from the bleachers when Marshall suggested gasoline was cheaper under President Trump than under previous presidents.

Supporters of his Democratic rival, Adam Hamilton, easily outnumbered and outshouted Marshall's backers.

Kansas State Fair debates are notoriously boisterous, with Democratic and Republican campaigns busing in supporters who give as good as they get. But the lopsided showdown laid bare a growing anxiety among GOP officials and strategists nationwide that Democrats are fired up for November, while many Republicans aren't.

With Election Day approaching, Republican worries about voter enthusiasm are spilling beyond swing states into red bastions such as Kansas, Texas, Alaska, Ohio, Iowa and Nebraska.

Trump's approval rating sits near record lows, and frustrations are growing over the



GOP Sen. Roger Marshall during a debate this month at the Kansas State Fair in Hutchinson.

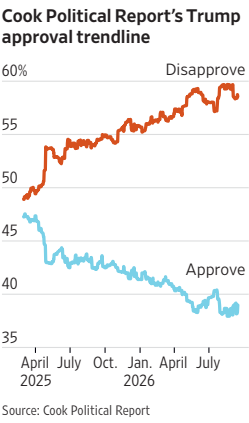
state of the economy, tariffs and the war in Iran. Democrats need to pick up just three seats to retake the House and four to win back the Senate.

"If Republicans don't turn out, we're in a world of hurt," warned Danedri Herbert, chair of the Kansas Republican Party.

Herbert urged national Republican groups to pour more resources and money into Kansas before it is too late. "Kansas gets overlooked a lot because we are reliably red," she said, "but this is a weird cycle."

Republican leaders in Washington are starting to pay closer attention to this state and others Trump won by double digits in 2024. West Virginia Republican Sen. Jim Justice said he is concerned his party's disaffected voters will stay home.

Republicans who are not



have said the political climate threatens additional Republican-held House and Senate seats, they say GOP prospects have brightened in a few races, such as New Hampshire's contest for an open Senate seat. And Republican groups have just started to press their substantial financial edge with a barrage of TV ads.

Still, leaning against a cattle chute at the Kansas fair, Paul Rhodes, a 73-year-old antiabortion activist who has supported Republicans, said he thought he probably won't vote at all this year.

"There was always a baseline of support that was solid. It's wavering," he said. "I don't think they'll vote Democrat, but they might not vote."

A Reuters/Ipsos poll released in recent days found Democrats have only a slight lead over Republicans nation-

Pritzker, Eyeing a 2028 Presidential Bid, Is Taking a GLP-1

By JOHN MCCORMICK

Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker said he has taken a GLP-1 medication for two years after being diagnosed with diabetes. The medication could also help the slimmed-down Democrat in a possible 2028 presidential bid.

The billionaire made the first-time disclosure in a CBS News interview broadcast Monday. Speculation about his use of such drugs has circulated for months in Illinois political circles.

"I've been overweight most of my life," said Pritzker, who

also told the network he has lost 80 pounds so far and feels "a whole lot better." He said he also walks about 4 miles most mornings and has been told by his doctor that he will likely need to take the drugs forever.

In discussing his weight, Pritzker noted his father's death from a heart attack at age 39 while playing tennis in Hawaii as his mother watched. "He died in her arms," Pritzker said.

Weight loss is common ahead of modern presidential bids. Chris Christie, then New Jersey's governor, underwent

weight-reduction surgery in 2013 ahead of his 2016 Republican presidential bid. Mike Pompeo, a former secretary of state and Central Intelligence Agency director under President Trump, also lost significant weight before he decided against a 2024 presidential White House campaign.

When asked by the network whether he is taking the medication to prepare for a presidential bid, Pritzker played down that possibility. "I have not made any decisions about what I might do in the future," said Pritzker, who is seeking a third term as gover-



JB Pritzker

nor in November.

The governor said Illinois is covering GLP-1 medications for about 55,000 state employees because it is good for the

budget. "We're going to save money because fewer people will have diabetes, people will be less overweight, which causes so many other diseases," he said.

President Trump has repeatedly called attention to Pritzker's weight, including suggesting that he should "spend more time in the gym" and calling him a "slob" who "wants to eat all the time."

Pritzker has also suggested Trump would benefit from losing some pounds. "It takes one to know one on the weight question," Pritzker told reporters in August 2025.

Watch a Video



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Special Advertising Feature



Why Regulated Industries Could Lead AI’s Next Wave

Sectors such as healthcare and financial services can gain a competitive edge in the AI era by harnessing their discipline and experience—if they embrace change and act responsibly, says TCS’s **Amit Bajaj**.

Highly regulated sectors are rarely among the first movers in adopting new technology, with firms in industries such as banking, insurance and healthcare often spending decades building systems that prioritize security, auditability and compliance.

Yet they may be better positioned than the market assumes, as that discipline and experience are becoming an advantage in the AI era. “These industries are already used to asking the questions every enterprise now must ask about AI,” says Amit Bajaj, president of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) North America. “Who is accountable? How is data protected? What happens if something goes wrong? Those are not new muscles for banks, insurers or healthcare organizations.”

In this conversation, Bajaj explains how TCS is helping its partners overcome adoption barriers, why data context is king and why CEOs ought to be leading AI adoption from the front.

Q Financial services and healthcare have historically been cautious toward new technologies while challengers raced ahead. Is AI reversing that dynamic?

AB: For a long time, regulated industries were seen as moving more cautiously because they had to meet higher standards for privacy, resilience, auditability and compliance. But in the AI era, those standards are the price of admission—you need trust, control and governance built in from the beginning.

That does not mean regulation automatically gives companies an edge. The real advantage comes when governance is treated as a business capability, not just a compliance requirement. That means secure data boundaries, responsible AI practices, reference architectures and operating models that can withstand scrutiny from regulators, customers and employees. This is where regulated industries can lead.

Q Some organizations are sitting on enormous proprietary datasets. Why have so few turned that data into a durable AI advantage?

AB: Many large enterprises have decades of data spread across legacy platforms, business units, geographies and formats, but the meaning behind it is often inconsistent. AI needs context, lineage, quality and shared business meaning to generate value. Enterprises need to think about the corpus—the trusted body of enterprise knowledge that AI can safely reason over. That is why context is king.

Q Where are you seeing AI deliver the biggest benefits?

AB: Productivity is usually the first benefit people see, because it is easy to point to time saved or tasks automated. But the bigger opportunity is changing how companies sense, decide and serve. The most powerful applications start with the business outcome and work backward across the value chain. I call this “right-to-left” discovery. Instead of asking, “Where can we insert AI?” the better question is: “What decision, experience or process do we need to reimagine?”

Q In banking and healthcare, AI failure can mean more than a bad customer experience—it can create financial, regulatory or human consequences. What does responsible AI deployment look like?

AB: It starts with humility. In banking or healthcare, you cannot deploy AI first and figure out governance later. You need human oversight, explainability, cybersecurity, privacy protection, continuous monitoring and clear escalation paths from day one. Trust must sit on top of the stack, with secure sandboxes, guardrails, human-in-the-loop review, evaluations, telemetry, rollback... In highly regulated industries, trust is the license to operate.

Q For CEOs and boards, what is the biggest strategic mistake companies are making on AI?

AB: Treating AI as a technology program instead of a business redesign. Underinvesting is a risk. Moving too fast without governance is also a risk. But the deeper issue is failing to ask how AI changes the company’s operating model: how decisions are made, how value is measured and how people should be prepared.

Q Five years from now, what will distinguish the companies that successfully converted AI into measurable competitive advantage?

AB: The companies that have unlocked AI will operate at 10 to 100 times the clock speed of non-AI firms. Speed will give them tremendous competitive advantage, but it won’t come from having the same models as everyone else. It will come from applying AI to proprietary knowledge and the distinctive decisions that define the business.



Scan to learn more about TCS and AI



WORLD NEWS

Saudis Return to Risky Hormuz Route

Red Sea threats shut Riyadh’s alternatives, sending ships back to dangerous strait

DUBAI—Saudi Arabia spent months rerouting oil across the desert to circumvent the Strait of Hormuz. Now, with its Red

By Georgi Kantchev, Rebecca Feng and Summer Said

Sea bypass route disrupted by attacks, the country’s state-controlled oil giant, is loading more oil onto tankers in the Persian Gulf and taking its chances sending them through Hormuz. The company has told several of its custom-

ers in Asia to pick up shipments just outside the strait off the coast of Oman, said people familiar with the matter. The risky attempts to run the gauntlet through the Strait show how the U.S. and its Gulf allies are struggling to keep critical oil routes clear when Iran and its allies can severely disrupt them with missiles and drones. The efforts are bringing the Saudis head-to-head with Iran, which is attacking ships in the waterway in hopes of shutting it down. On Monday, a tanker entering the strait was struck by an unknown projectile, injuring two crew members, said U.K. Maritime Trade Operations, or UKMTO, which is affiliated with the Royal Navy. Another tanker was hit by debris, UKMTO said. The stakes for the global economy and the Trump administration ahead of the mid-

term elections are high. The disruptions to oil supplies have pushed up the cost of gas and diesel, heightening inflation fears and angering voters. The U.S. military has suppressed Iranian attacks enough to get millions of barrels of oil through Hormuz each day. But attacks by the Iran-backed Houthi militants and from Iraq are cutting into the impact of that progress by closing other routes for supplies. “This is a reminder that bypass channels aren’t infallible,” said Rachel Ziemba, an adjunct senior fellow at the Center for a New American Security, a Washington think tank. “All of the options have their issues and costs, with tanker rates and insurance rising along with physical risk.” Gulf producers from the United Arab Emirates to Iraq are racing to build alternative

routes for their crude. Those workarounds are keeping Gulf barrels moving, but they are tying up tankers, driving freight rates up, and, in Saudi Arabia’s case, not sustainably alleviating blockages that have left its oil production at a multidecade low. The cost of transporting crude from Saudi’s Ras Tanura port inside the Persian Gulf to China’s Ningbo port has surged from about \$4.5 million to nearly \$63 million a trip, said Michael Haigh, head of commodities research at French bank Société Générale. Before the Iran war, Saudi Arabia sent most of its oil exports through the Strait of Hormuz and onward to customers in Asia. As Iranian attacks on ships choked off that waterway, the kingdom shifted millions of barrels through its East-West Pipeline to the port

of Yanbu on the Red Sea. When the Iran-backed Houthi militants stepped up attacks on Saudi-linked shipping around the Bab el-Mandeb in July, some Saudi cargoes were rerouted north through Egypt, using the Suez Canal and Sumed pipeline system instead. The most recent scramble was triggered by drone attacks from Iraq this month that shut the East-West pipeline. Without it, Saudi Arabia is increasingly falling back on an elaborate system of loading crude at its Persian Gulf terminal of Ras Tanura, shuttling it through Hormuz, transferring it to ships off the coast of Oman for distribution to its customers on global markets, then going back for more. In the past two weeks, about 2.4 million barrels of Saudi crude and condensate a day were again flowing through the

Strait of Hormuz, said ship-tracker Kpler, a level last seen in early July before the Houthi militants announced a maritime blockade of Saudi Arabia and began attacking Saudi shipping in the Red Sea. The four-week average daily Saudi crude oil loadings from inside the Persian Gulf rose to more than 2 million barrels last week, compared with virtually zero for most of June and fewer than 1 million barrels a day in July, said data-provider Vortexa. Meanwhile, loadings from Red Sea terminals have dropped to zero since the attacks on the East-West pipeline earlier in September. Saudi Arabia already had cut loadings from its Yanbu port in August after the Houthis declared a blockade of Saudi Arabian ports and ships in late July.

Twin Sisters Face Wrath of Iran’s Crackdown

By MARGHERITA STANCATI

Taraneh Rahimi was staying with friends on the night of Jan. 24 when masked, armed men barged into the house, put a bag over her head and took her away. They later came for her twin sister, Romina. For months, their loved ones didn’t know where they were, or whether they were even alive. Their mother searched for her 20-year-old daughters everywhere, to no avail. In April, she got an anonymous call, a family member said. “Your daughters are at Dowlatabad Prison. You can book an appointment to see them,” the caller told her.

When she saw the twins, in Isfahan’s female prison, their mother could hardly recognize them. Their faces were puffy and there were bald patches where their hair had been ripped out. They recounted harrowing tales from their time in detention, where they were tortured and sexually assaulted, according to information obtained by relatives and lawyers who reviewed their case. An Iranian government spokesman didn’t respond to a request for comment. Taraneh and Romina Rahimi are among the most visible symbols of the regime’s brutal crackdown on the mass protests that swept Iran in January. The response killed thou-

sands. The aftermath is playing out in prisons and courthouses nationwide as the authorities follow up with executions and long prison sentences, aiming to stifle signs of unrest arising from the U.S.’s sanctions and its blockade of Iranian ports. Nationwide, some 50,000 people were detained in connection to the uprising, said Human Rights Activists in Iran, a U.S.-based group that monitors the country. Many disappeared without trace. Others have been charged with vague national-security counts that carry heavy penalties. Defendants are frequently denied lawyers of their own choosing and made to confess under torture, say lawyers and rights groups. Harsh sentences often follow the sham trials. The Rahimi sisters were among 16 defendants detained because of their alleged role in the unrest

around Shohada Square in Isfahan this year. The central Iranian city has emerged as a focal point of the judicial crackdown. The twins spent the first three months in a detention center run by the intelligence arm of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, where they were tortured and sexually assaulted. A lot of the torture was psychological, according to information obtained by relatives and human-rights lawyers familiar with the case. The sisters were held separately in



Taraneh, left, and Romina Rahimi, pictured a few months before masked, armed men took them away in January.

isolation, but they could hear each other screaming and crying. They were made to watch male prisoners being tortured. Taraneh suffered severe physical injuries when she was repeatedly beaten with a baton on her leg, knee, hand and arm, said the lawyers and relatives. The twins turned 21 in prison. In late August, Taraneh,

along with nine others, was sentenced to death. Romina got a 25-year prison sentence. The convictions could be appealed, but rights groups worry the executions will be fast-tracked. Taraneh’s relatives fear she soon could be the first woman executed in Iran in connection to the protests. “Every night we fear it could

happen,” said Masoud Nourmohammadi, a cousin of the twins who is based in the U.S. “It could be any time.” Before they joined the street protests, Taraneh and Romina weren’t especially political. Like many of their peers, they longed for a secular and democratic government that would liberate them from the regime’s draconian social rules. They tried to live as freely as possible, driving around with friends and partying at the beach—the kind of thing 20-year-olds do everywhere but that can get you in serious trouble in the Islamic Republic. Romina, the more rebellious of the two, bleached streaks in her hair, which she often left uncovered. “Romina is someone who doesn’t take no for an answer. She is fiercely independent” said Nourmohammadi, her cousin. “Taraneh is very kindhearted, she loves people, she loves animals.” Taraneh especially loves horses. She rode competitively and trained them. “If life is going to knock me down, I’d rather it be from a galloping horse than under the weight of life’s pressure,” she said in an Instagram post. It isn’t the first time Iranian security forces have abused political prisoners. Amnesty International and the United Nations documented the widespread use of physical torture and sexual assault against prisoners detained in the aftermath of the 2022 women’s rights protests. Death sentences are another way to punish dissenters and send a message against anyone thinking of speaking out.

Iranian Delegation Faces Curbs

Continued from Page One tablishing the U.N. headquarters, the U.S. agreed that it “shall not impose any impediments” on officials from member nations, including granting them visas. But Milanovic said there is longstanding tension between the U.N. and the U.S. over how the rules are interpreted, and that the U.S. has placed restrictions on certain attendees in the past, such as Soviet representatives. Despite the logistical challenges, U.S. adversaries have long used the U.N. as a prominent perch from which to criticize Washington. Soviet leaders often took to the dais during the Cold War to assail Washington, and, in 1960, Cuba’s Fidel Castro spoke for more than four hours about topics that included a condemnation of U.S. intervention in Latin America. Pezeshkian is expected to make the case that Iranians are victims of aggression and that his country has acted in self-defense, said Richard Gowan, program director of global issues and institutions at International Crisis Group, a think tank. President Trump, who is set to address the U.N. on Tuesday, has justified attacks on Iran by calling it “the world’s No. 1 sponsor of ter-



Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian waved to participants at a rally in Tehran last week.

ror,” and saying that it must never be able to develop nuclear weapons. He told Fox News on Sunday he is in “deciding mode” about next steps with Iran, and didn’t rule out meeting with Pezeshkian in New York. In the past, Iranian officials have been reluctant to meet U.S. officials, but while in New York, Pezeshkian, a political moderate who has advocated for engagement with the West, is angling to speak with analysts from U.S. and European think tanks, according to people familiar with the matter. While the U.S. and Israel initially faced widespread criticism for attacks on Iran, which critics said violated the U.N. Charter, Tehran has drawn global ire by blocking shipments through the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran’s isolation has been compounded in recent weeks as Iran-linked Houthi rebels in Yemen have attacked ships on the Red Sea. Iran’s president was in a precarious position a year ago, too, when he addressed the U.N., just a few months after a 12-day bombing campaign by the U.S. and Israel aimed at destroying its nuclear-weapons production facilities. In a 15-minute address, Pezeshkian denied that the nation seeks nuclear weapons, and called the attacks “a grave betrayal of diplomacy and subversion of efforts towards the establishment of stability and peace.” He didn’t mention Trump in the address and primarily blamed Israel for stoking unrest in the region, while con-

demning its military operations in Gaza. Over the past three decades, Iran’s president or prime minister has spoken nearly every year at the U.N. One past speaker was Ali Khamenei, who addressed the General Assembly in 1987—when he was Iran’s president, before becoming supreme leader. Khamenei was killed in U.S.-Israeli airstrikes on the first day of the war. Even in 1980, as U.S. hostages were being held in Tehran, Iran sent a high-level delegation, which used its appearance not to address the hostage crisis, but to rally international condemnation for Iraq’s invasion of Iran. It isn’t clear what kind of reception Pezeshkian might receive in New York this year. Some think-tank analysts in-

vited to meet the Iranian delegation said they are wary of U.S. sanctions that restrict informal policy dialogues with Tehran’s officials. “No one wants to be seen going,” said one Iran specialist who previously received an invitation. Despite the rigidity of the official events at U.N. week, the event has provided a venue for diplomacy. In 2019, Trump considered reaching out to Iran’s delegation. Last year at the U.N., Pakistani officials served as an intermediary between the Iranian and U.S. teams, passing messages between them, which helped foster subsequent talks in Islamabad that ultimately made no impact. French officials likewise used the occasion to try to revive a version of a 2015 nuclear pact, though that fizzled, too. Trump is expected to meet with a number of Middle East leaders during his stay in New York. Multiple diplomats said Qatari officials plan to use the gathering to discuss the possibility of resuming talks. No one is expecting major breakthroughs. Gowan, the International Crisis Group executive, said he is unaware of plans for formal negotiations over Iran during U.N. week. U.N. Secretary-General António Guterres played down the likelihood of talks in New York. “It is a complex set of problems that requires a serious dialogue between the U.S. and Iran, between Iran and the countries of the Gulf, including the mediators,” he said last week. “Probably it will take place somewhere else.”

U.S. Plans To Invest \$5 Billion To Rebuild Gulf Sites

By ALEXANDER WARD AND SUMMER SAID

WASHINGTON—The Trump administration has proposed investing \$5 billion in a new fund that would help Middle East countries rebuild energy infrastructure battered in the Iran war and reduce their reliance on the Strait of Hormuz to transport oil and gas, said U.S. and Middle Eastern officials and documents seen by The Wall Street Journal. The move is a tacit acknowledgment that the conflict has roiled the global energy market and destroyed regional pipelines and refineries that will be costly to rebuild. Under the plan, the U.S. would seek a matching contribution from eight Middle Eastern partners—Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Iraq and Jordan—with the goal of generating a \$10 billion investment fund. The investment would be called the Partnership for Allied Trust and Construction, or Pact. Discussions are under way, and terms of the arrangement could change, U.S. officials said. It is unclear when, or even if, other countries will sign on. Some Middle East officials said the initiative appeared to be Washington’s attempt to cast the Strait of Hormuz as a less consequential energy route, and show the U.S. and its allies are united in confronting Iran. They added that creating a fund to rebuild destroyed energy sites without a peace deal with Tehran would be premature, as the regime could target new infrastructure with drones and missiles. “This strategy has risk written all over it,” said Bilal Saab, senior managing director of consulting firm TRENDS US. Gulf countries have differing dependencies on the strait, he said, noting that regional powers like Saudi Arabia and the U.A.E. could support alternative routes, while smaller countries such as Kuwait and Qatar rely on the waterway. Under the U.S. proposal, the fund would be managed by the Development Finance Corporation, a federal agency that works with the private sector to support U.S. national-security policy. Its programs historically have targeted projects in developing countries, not wealthy Gulf monarchies. The push by the Trump administration is the latest attempt to mitigate consequences from the Iran war. Iranian missile and drone strikes have hit dozens of refineries, oil fields and natural-gas export terminals across the region, ensuring a prolonged squeeze on global oil-and-gas markets even if the Strait of Hormuz fully reopens. Energy analysts and officials have pegged energy infrastructure repair costs in the region at tens of billions, covering engineering, construction, equipment and materials.

Siebel Scholars Class of 2027

The Siebel Scholars program was founded in 2000 to recognize the most talented graduate students in business, computer science, and bioengineering. Each year, over 70 outstanding graduate students are selected as Siebel Scholars based on academic excellence and leadership and join an active, lifelong community among an ever-growing group of leaders. We are pleased to recognize this year’s Siebel Scholars.

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Chyna Mays
William Pinney III

**STANFORD UNIVERSITY
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Pengrui Han
Tony Hong
Jiayue Melissa Shi
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WORLD NEWS

NATO Forces Hold Drills in Baltics

As Russian threat grows, Canadian-led troops work to adapt lessons from Ukraine

By Yaroslav Trofimov

DAUDZEVA, Latvia—Wearing strips of red tape on their helmets, Danish soldiers stealthily moved through the pine forest and then, unleashing a firestorm, overran a position held by Spanish troops. “*Todos muertos*”—“everyone is dead”—quipped one of the Spanish soldiers, relaxing under an armored vehicle that raised its cannon to signify it had been destroyed.

The Danish mechanized-infantry company role-played the enemy in this month’s exercise by the North Atlantic Treaty Organization’s brigade that has been deployed to protect Latvia from nearby Russia.

The exercise, one of several in the Baltic states this year, sought to prepare the Canadian-led NATO brigade here should the Russian threat against Europe spill into war. It also involved implementing the lessons of how the nature of warfare has been transformed by the drone revolution in the battlefields of Ukraine—with mixed results.

“We don’t just train anymore. We do mission rehearsal,” said the NATO brigade commander, Canadian Col. David Brassard. “This is a fundamental change in mindset.”

Some 35% of Canada’s entire land forces are committed to Latvia, he said. Similar NATO units are led by Germany, which is permanently position-



Canadian soldiers participated in a NATO military exercise in Latvia this past February.

ing a brigade in Lithuania, and the U.K., which is leading a battle group in Estonia.

Latvian President Edgars Rinkēvičs said he is getting assessments of looming Russian escalation, but for now below the threshold of a military invasion that would trigger NATO’s Article 5 commitments to mutual defense. The Ukraine war has made Russia’s military stronger, he said. “This is a military that now has battle experience, and has also been very flexible and agile to adapt to new warfare,” he said.

Unknown drones have been observed flying over the area during the exercise, Brassard said. The Baltic states have been subjected to several hybrid attacks. The Danes, from the Royal Life Guards Regiment, have spent considerable time watching drone footage

from Russian and Ukrainian social-media. Nearly all of the company’s troops have gained at least rudimentary piloting skills, and their commander said he has visited several units inside Ukraine.

Yet, he noted, even his unit was far from proficient in emulating the way Russians and Ukrainians fight, in which some 90% of the kills come from drones and much of the traditional military doctrine has become obsolete. Some 90% of the drones used by the Danish “red force” in the exercise were for observation and intelligence gathering, with only a few used as weapons.

In the forest, two Canadian Leopard tanks were parked at an intersection without any of the netting and drone defenses that have become indispensable in the Ukraine war. The

‘We don’t just train anymore. We do mission rehearsal,’ says brigade leader.

crews said they are starting to learn about drone warfare. Asked about what drone defenses he had, one of the soldiers said he should soon be issued a shotgun. There was no drone-detection technology in the tank.

At the Canadian artillery battery participating in the exercise, the commander said the troops have been spacing their M777-towed howitzers about 7 miles apart, much far-

ther than usual, to minimize drone detection.

The Canadian major, who served in Ukraine as an adviser before 2022, said his soldiers watch videos of the Ukraine war and propose new solutions and techniques.

Juris Jurašs, who served as a Latvian lawmaker before joining the Ukrainian military as a reconnaissance company commander in 2022, chuckled when he heard about the exercise. Towed howitzers like the M777 are rarely used in Ukraine because they get targeted by drones immediately after firing, he said. Tanks have all but disappeared from the front line. Those that attempt to operate are usually covered in layers of hedgehog-like drone defenses.

“A tank in the battlefield now is like a dessert cake—the drone boys will be fighting each other over the right to strike it first,” Jurašs said. “NATO armies are not ready for this kind of modern war. They’ve only heard about the war in Ukraine from TV or social media, and they don’t understand just how much everything has changed.”

Modern technologies are coming, and the NATO brigade in Latvia is adapting by practicing how to cover roads with antidrone netting and how to create hardened headquarters, Brassard said. While Ukrainian troops aren’t training with his forces, they work with the Latvian army and national-guard brigades.

“Are we where we are supposed to be? Not 100%,” he said. “But the threat across the border right now gives us some time to reach our cruising speed.”

German Chancellor Undeterred By Losses In Elections

By Bertrand Benoit

BERLIN—German Chancellor Friedrich Merz pledged to forge ahead with an unpopular economic overhaul despite his collapsing popularity, misgivings among his coalition partners, and a string of electoral routs that have raised doubts about his political future.

Monday’s comments sought to bring an end to weeks of debate about how long Merz can keep together his coalition, in office for just a year-and-a-half. The chancellor’s electoral setbacks culminated on Sunday in the worst-ever result for his Christian Democratic Union and the latest wins for parties on the far left and far right.

“We want to move forward



Friedrich Merz

with the reform process, but we know people are concerned and afraid and we must give them answers,” Merz said. “The extremists suggest that there are simple solutions, but anyone who has been in government knows these don’t exist.”

Merz’s CDU won’t be represented in the parliament of Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, a small northeastern state, after failing to clear a 5% vote threshold on Sunday—a result Merz described as “a disaster.”

This was the first time the CDU had fallen under the 5% mark in postwar Germany.

The election’s winner was the far-right Alternative for Germany, or AfD, with 38.7% of the vote. Unlike in Saxony-Anhalt, another Eastern state, where the AfD got close to an absolute majority of votes two weeks ago, it is unlikely to govern in the state because left-leaning parties have more seats.

Meanwhile, in the city-state of Berlin, the Left Party, successor to the former East-German ruling party, emerged victorious with more than a quarter of the votes, putting it in position to head the German capital’s next government.

The Left has pledged to expropriate residential properties from large commercial landlords in a bid to keep rents low. The party has received support from groups that have been accused of promoting terror and antisemitism.

“I stand for the protection of Jewish life,” Elif Eralp, the party’s lead candidate, said on Monday after photos emerged overnight showing a representative of a U.S.-sanctioned Palestinian organization and the Lebanese-born head of one of Berlin’s oldest organized-crime gangs attending a Left Party postelection party in Berlin.

Merz described the three elections of the past two weeks as a turning point, saying “we are witnessing a fundamental transformation of the party system, in Germany and in many other countries around the world.”

Some 40% of voters in Berlin had picked parties that aimed to topple established institutions, he added.

Merz has stressed the need for stable leadership in Europe’s largest economy amid persistent economic headwinds for Europe.

On the upside for Merz, there are no significant state elections until next June, when North Rhine-Westphalia, Germany’s most populous state, is expected to re-elect its CDU governor.

This gives the chancellor a few months of respite on the electoral front. Already the most unpopular leader in German postwar history, he doesn’t have much further to fall in polls.

Legendary Refiner Aims to Legitimize Africa’s Illicit Gold

By Alexandra Wexler

JOHANNESBURG—Behind several sets of locking doors, watched over by hundreds of security cameras, is a windowless refinery that has processed nearly a third of all the gold produced in world history.

Now, the storied Rand Refinery is switching up its playbook. Long the go-to destination for Africa’s commercially mined gold, it is working to tap the vast quantities of metal dug up by the continent’s countless informal miners, too.

The South African company recently started working with a refinery in Ghana that processes gold from local artisanal and small-scale miners, and aims to start handling that metal itself soon.

The move is one of the boldest yet to legitimize the billions of dollars worth of gold unearthed by informal miners, a business often associated with worker exploitation and environmental damage. Bringing more of that metal into the mainstream could improve conditions for impoverished miners and increase lawful supplies at a time of near-record prices.

“At this price, every milligram counts,” Rand Refinery Chief Executive Dean Subra-



manian said. Artisanal gold “is a serious player.”

The effort to tap artisanal small-scale gold mining (ASM) helps plug a gap. Traditionally, the Rand Refinery processed gold from big South African mines, but output from the country—once the world’s No. 1 producer—has dwindled in recent decades. That has left the Rand Refinery running at half its capacity, even though it has added gold from other large mines into its supply.

But using ASM gold as a feedstock poses challenges. Before the Rand Refinery can handle the metal, it needs to ensure it is mined in a responsible manner, including without damaging the environment, mistreating workers or funding corrupt officials.

Founded in 1920, the Rand



Locals searched for gold in Ghana near the border with Burkina Faso in 2023.

Refinery was established by gold producers upset about the cost of shipping gold to London for refining. Over the past century the facility has processed more than 50,000 metric tons of gold. It still handles about half of all gold from Africa’s commercial mines.

Gold doré, a semirefined bar made from a mixture of gold and silver that is cast at mines, arrives by helicopter at the site where it is melted into products including 276-pound bars worth some \$1.7 million each.

By contrast, gold from informal mines is often laundered into regular supply chains through smaller local refineries and exported to sites in Dubai and India where it is used to make jewelry.

About half the continent’s gold production is estimated to

come from ASM operations, which include panning for gold in rivers, descending thousands of feet underground to mine in abandoned commercial shafts and hand-digging shallow tunnels through rock.

In South Africa, informal miners pry open closed shafts to try their luck extracting what remains of the country’s gold reserves.

The illicit activity is fraught with peril, and miners frequently die in graves they themselves dug. The problem has only become more acute as gold prices have soared to all-time highs.

That has the Rand Refinery looking to other African nations to source ASM gold it can turn into legitimate bars. It signed a partnership agreement in December with

Ghana’s Gold Coast Refinery, in what is now Africa’s biggest gold-producing country.

Under that deal, Rand Refinery is expected to take a 15% stake in the business and could boost its holding, Subramanian said.

While ASM mining is regulated in Ghana, many of the local players continue to operate informally. These mines have been linked to environmental issues, accused of fueling corruption and suspected of employing child labor.

“The idea to formalize, to engage, is a really good one, [but] there are a lot of loopholes,” said Marc Ummel, head of raw materials at Swissaid, a nonprofit that works on development projects. “There is still a long journey until Ghana solves ASM challenges.”

AFGHANISTAN

Pakistani Airstrikes Kill 28 Militants

Pakistani jet fighters Monday struck sites in eastern Afghanistan that Pakistani officials described as suspected militant hide-outs. Pakistan said 28 militants were killed. Authorities in Kabul reported at least three civilian deaths.

The strikes near the countries’ border marked a renewed escalation in tensions, raising the prospect of further cross-border hostilities.

The strikes came after Pakistan warned it could target militants inside Afghanistan following two deadly attacks on Pakistani security forces near the border in recent days.

Afghanistan’s government said the strikes killed three civilians and wounded four others, a toll confirmed by the United Nations.

—Associated Press

MEXICO

Potential Hurricane Brewing in Pacific

Tropical Storm Polo will rapidly intensify in the Pacific Ocean and become a major hurricane later this week, forecasters said Monday.

Polo could bring heavy rain, rough surf and tropical-storm-force wind to parts of Mexico late Tuesday into early Wednesday, according to an advisory from the Miami-based National Hurricane Center.

Meteorologists said Monday that Polo would drop 4 to 8 inches of rain, with isolated totals near 12 inches, across coastal portions of the Mexican states of Guerrero and Michoacán through Thursday. Flooding and mudslides were possible. A tropical storm as of Monday, Polo had maximum sustained winds of 65 mph. It was centered about 255 miles south-southeast of Manzanillo, Mexico.

—Associated Press

WORLD WATCH



RISING ANGER: Thousands of Philippine protesters, angered by corruption and economic and military issues, marked the 54th anniversary of the imposition of martial law in the country by Ferdinand Marcos Sr. Martial law ended in 1981, and democracy was restored in 1986.

WORLD NEWS

Parents in China Use Watches to Track Kids

By HANNAH MIAO

SHANGHAI—When Jane Ding’s son headed on his first field trip in kindergarten, she was worried he would get lost. So she and her husband bought a gadget that has become ubiquitous for parents across China’s cities: a smartwatch for children.

With the watch made by Chinese brand Xiaotiancai, which means “Little Genius,” they could track their child’s location and video chat with him, among other features.

They sneaked the watch into their son’s backpack because electronic devices weren’t allowed on the field trip. After the outing, they introduced the watch to their son, Larix, and taught him how to use it. Now he is 8 years old and wears it when-

ever he goes out to play.

“It has a lot of functions that are really helpful for parents,” said Ding, 39.

About one in three children age 5 to 12 own a children’s smartwatch in China, and the figure rises to more than half in urban areas, according to state media.

Little Genius—marketed as Imoo outside China—introduced its first smartwatch in 2015. It commands nearly half of global sales of young people’s smartwatches, which exceeded \$1 billion in the first half of 2026, according to technology market research firm Counterpoint Research. China is the biggest market for children’s smartwatches, making up 58% of global sales in the first half of the year.

In China, Little Genius watches start at the equiva-



For parents Jane Ding and Jimmy Poek, the smartwatch they gave their son, Larix, offers peace of mind.

lent of about \$90, and some cost more than \$300.

They use SIM cards, like phones, and offer payment apps so parents can load money onto the watches for their children to spend.

Larix doesn’t leave the house alone, but the watch gives his parents peace of mind in case he gets lost at the mall or they lose track of him at the park.

“If he didn’t have a watch, I

would be very worried,” said his father, Jimmy Poek, 40.

A central feature of Little Genius watches is that children can tap their smartwatches together to add each other as friends on the brand’s social network, where they can chat with each other, post updates, and comment on posts. Schoolmates with smartwatches from other brands such as Apple, Xiaomi or Huawei can’t join.

That means parents often feel they have no choice but to buy a Little Genius.

At the playground, Larix ran into his friend, Gu Ling’en, who was among the first friends he added on his watch. Gu said the feature she likes the most about her Little Genius watch is the chat function—and the camera. The two snapped a selfie.

“I can chat with friends,

and add more and more friends. It’s so fun!” said Gu, 9.

Little Genius watches have been criticized in state media and on social media for sometimes being addictive and fueling social anxiety. They are banned in many classrooms. The company didn’t respond to requests for comment.

Jiang Kai, a 48-year-old father of two, recently spent about \$200 each on new Little Genius smartwatches for his children. He worries they might compare their watches to classmates who have more expensive models and feel disappointed.

For many parents, however, a Little Genius smartwatch feels safer than a smartphone with unrestricted access to the internet. They can manage who is on their kids’ contact lists and control which apps and games they use.



Top, Havana during a blackout in July. Top right, Mike Hammer, Trump’s top diplomat in Havana, at the Cuban American Bar Association’s gala in Miami in February. Right, Secretary of State Marco Rubio at a news conference last year.

Miami Is Full of Cuba Plans

Continued from Page One

repairs to the island’s crumbling infrastructure. They have plans to reach out to blue-chip companies, banks and investment funds to invest in a new postcommunist Cuba.

As the island sinks deeper into crisis, wealthy and politically connected exiles are racing to plot its future from Miami, where the Trump administration is turning for ideas, political support and private capital to rebuild the country if the regime falls.

The effort has drawn billionaires and Trump-linked powerbrokers, the scions of Cuban-American dynasties built on sugar, and immigrants who amassed fortunes over decades in the U.S.

Some of them have a direct line to the Trump administration—most notably to Secretary of State Marco Rubio, the son of Cuban immigrants who built much of his political career on a vow to end communist rule on the island.

The feverish preparations have been fueled by three words President Trump has repeated since the capture of Venezuelan strongman Nicolás Maduro in January: “Cuba is next.” He has slapped an oil blockade on the island and floated a “friendly takeover.” Earlier this year, senior officials told Florida politicians and wealthy Cuban-Americans that regime change could happen by this summer, and certainly by the end of the year.

The oil blockade has worsened acute fuel shortages and increased the dayslong blackouts, deepening the island’s humanitarian crisis. But Havana has proven to be resilient—and with Trump’s attention consumed by the war in Iran, any plans to focus on Cuba have been put on the back burner. Trump has repeatedly told aides he needs to wrap up the conflict in the Middle East before devoting resources to Cuba or other foreign-policy priorities, according to people familiar with the discussions.

Some senior officials have begun speaking of a campaign that could last the remainder of Trump’s term.

Pressed about earlier expectations that Cuba’s regime

could fall this year, Rubio bristled at the idea of a fixed timetable. “We’re not a miniseries, like you get in three episodes and it’s over,” he told reporters during a trip to Manila in July. “These are complex things that take time.”

Rubio has instructed his staff to keep up weekly Cuba-related announcements—news about indictments, sanctions, reports—even as administration officials have quietly begun to stretch the timeline, according to people familiar with the discussions. The steady drumbeat is itself a pressure tactic, a State Department official says, intended to create the impression that further U.S. action could be imminent.

“They have not changed the goal, but they have moved the goal post,” says Tony Costa, 86, a former owner of one of the world’s largest growers of ornamental plants, who retired years ago to devote all of his time to ousting the Communist regime.

An ally in Trump

Politically connected Cuban-Americans see an ally in Trump. Many believe the former real-estate tycoon largely sees Cuba as a distressed asset: a sun-soaked island of underdeveloped beaches and decaying properties that could be opened to American investment. They have sought to engage those instincts, pitching Cuba’s future to Trump not only as a political cause and part of his legacy, but also as a vast reconstruction project.

Jorge Mas, the billionaire co-owner of the Inter Miami soccer club and a close friend of Rubio, says Trump once asked him what it would cost to rebuild the island.

“We could invest multibil-

deep-red stronghold that renamed its main thoroughfare Donald J. Trump Avenue. “But at the same point, if it doesn’t happen now, it’s never gonna happen,” he says.

The gatherings of planners tend to be dominated by the patriarchs of the older exile community—men who left Cuba as children or young adults soon after the 1959 revolution, along with the children they raised on the expectation that they would one day reclaim the properties and businesses seized by Fidel Castro.

At a lunch in June, Pedro Freyre, chair of the international practice at the Akerman law firm, told a visiting U.S.

policy group that his phone was ringing off the hook with queries from Cuban-Americans seeking compensation for properties confiscated decades ago.

“Anybody who is hoping for a swing at the Cuban piñata is retaining lawyers and lobbyists, particularly in the Trump inner circle,” says Ric Herrero, the director of the Cuba Study Group, a Washington-based think tank that advocates for civil society development. “People are lining up for a transition that is by no means guaranteed, either gearing up for a friendly takeover or a giant exercise in wheel spinning.”

A feeling of inevitability was fueled at the beginning of the year by Trump’s avuncular top diplomat in Havana, Mike Hammer, who has been confidently pushing that communist rule would end this year.

“There has to be change,” Hammer told a ballroom of Cu-

ban-American lawyers at a February bar association gala in Miami. “I see it coming.”

But Hammer has quietly stopped pushing a 2026 timetable, say people who are in contact with him.

Despite an extraordinary burst of back-channel talks—from a secret meeting between Rubio and Raúl Castro’s grandson at a Caribbean resort to a visit to Havana by CIA Director John Ratcliffe—efforts to pressure officials in Cuba’s entrenched bureaucracy have made little headway. For months, Trump officials have sought to engage figures inside the Cuban system, including Castro’s grandson, known as

Raulito. They see him as someone whose connections and ambition could be used to shake up the regime from within, according to people familiar with the discussions. But the efforts stalled when the talks became public and South Florida politicians spoke out against the U.S. working through a member of the Castro family.

In their meetings with the Cubans, U.S. officials have demanded an overhaul of the country’s economy and political system and freedom for more than 1,000 political prisoners in exchange for lifting the U.S.’s oil blockade and other sanctions imposed on Havana. In June, Cuba approved a wide-ranging package of economic changes, which the U.S. dismissed. The government has refused to discuss political changes.

Some Cuban-Americans fear that the White House could try

‘We have our people on speed dial,’ says one architect in Miami.



to apply its Venezuela playbook to the island. There, U.S. special forces captured Maduro but left his vice president, Delcy Rodríguez, and the rest of the state apparatus in power in exchange for facilitating oil and other business deals. A democratic transition has been left for an unspecified future date.

Four out of five Cuban-Americans living in South Florida favor a U.S. military intervention in Cuba, be it to topple the government or to address the humanitarian needs of the population, according to a Miami Herald poll of some 800 Cuban-Americans published in April. The same number reject any negotiation with Havana that results in anything less than regime change.

An attack by the U.S. would provoke a “bloodbath of incalculable consequences,” President Miguel Díaz-Canel on X in May.

Transition plan

The planning in Miami, meanwhile, has extended from financing to the nuts and bolts of a political transition.

Mas, the chairman of the Cuban American National Foundation, a powerful lobbying group founded by his father, is working with Miami’s Cuban American Bar Association to develop a transition law that could cover the gap between the present regime and a democratic Cuba. The draft being circulated envisions a transitional government that would spend up to two years preparing for free elections.

Other debates have focused on whether a free Cuba should temporarily revive its 1940 constitution while a new one is drafted. The American Museum of the Cuban Diaspora recently hosted one such discussion.

“This is our Berlin Wall moment,” says Marcell Felipe, the museum’s chairman. Willy Bermello, 75, the architect who designed the proposed Trump library

in Miami, has his eye on re-making Cuba’s airports. Every two weeks, he convenes a small group of airline, airport management and investment fund executives over video calls to firm up \$8 billion plans to overhaul eight of the island’s airports once its government changes—a development he expects to happen soon. The re-making of Cuba’s airports will pay for itself, he says.

“We have our people on speed dial,” he says.

For now, the reality on the ground in Cuba is deteriorating. Lights are off for days at a time. Streets are clogged with uncollected mountains of garbage, which breed clouds of mosquitoes that spread dengue and other diseases.

Havana has accused the U.S. of imposing collective punishment by worsening the living conditions of ordinary Cubans.

Longtime Cuba observers say that there is little chance that increased deprivation will spark a popular rebellion. They note that for almost seven decades, Cuba hasn’t tolerated any organized political opposition. Significant protests have only erupted twice—once in Havana in 1994 and the other five years ago in towns and cities throughout the island. On both occasions, the protests were quickly put down.

In addition, Cuba observers say, more than a million Cubans, a majority of them young, have left the island since 2021, sharply reducing the number of potential demonstrators. Today’s Cuba is poorer, older and more racially mixed after years of having its population depleted by mass migration. The voice of the Cuban people is largely absent in debates of the country’s future.

“We are the children of abuse,” says Luis Fonseca, a Havana day laborer. “You try to survive and subsist.”

Back in Miami, Sixto, of the Cuban-American National Chamber of Commerce, plans to begin recruiting legions of volunteer Cuban-Americans next week to teach islanders the ways of modern capitalism when the regime finally falls.

“Cuba can’t advance with the people who are on the island,” he says. “It’s not their fault, but they are not modern. They are backwards.”



‘We could invest multibillions of dollars in Cuba,’ says Jorge Mas.

By **JESSE NEWMAN** AND **AMIRA MCKEE**

It can seem like there is no bigger problem for American families. The same question comes every single day. “What’s for dinner?” Schedules are more chaotic than ever. Dietary restrictions and picky eaters mean cooking multiple dishes. The cost is growing, and so is the pressure to measure up to social media’s food influencers—not to mention the “Make America Healthy Again” movement.

Kelly Mitchell and her husband, Craig, both work full time. Their 11-year-old daughter’s schedule is a crazy quilt of dance classes and competitions. Both Mitchell and her daughter avoid gluten. Figuring out what can feed everyone, based on the time, cost and ingredients on hand, is a struggle that repeats every day around 5:30 p.m. “The hardest part is having to solve that problem over and over again,” said Mitchell, who works for a nonprofit in suburban Chicago.

Eating out used to be an easy fallback on busy nights. But restaurant prices have shot up. Instead Mitchell’s family turns to ready-to-cook foods and meal-delivery services. Sometimes they make charcuterie boards with cheeses, nuts, salami and crackers as a dinner hack.

“We’re trying to shift our mindset,” Mitchell said, “and not try to hold ourselves to the expectations of what I saw my mom do.”

Americans now spend more time in the kitchen than they have in more than 20 years, according to the Labor Department.

Since 2020, about half of U.S. families have reported both parents working full-time jobs, according to a Pew Research Center analysis of U.S. Census Bureau data. Youth sports can go nearly around the clock. Even toddlers are enrolled in multiple extracurricular activities. Parents are the chauffeurs.

When 4 p.m. rolls around on any given day, about 80% of Americans still don’t know what they will have for dinner, said Lauren Fitzgerald, managing partner of the Mom Complex, a consulting firm that helps companies develop products and services for mothers. Text messages about dinner peak around that same time, she said, referring to findings from research conducted with thousands of families each year.

Squeezing dinner in between work and other activities can be a logistical nightmare. One in five meals are eaten in the car, Fitzgerald said. “Dinner is the number one pain point in modern family life,” she said.

Home restaurant

On average, Americans 15 years and older spent 43 minutes a day on food preparation and cleanup in 2025, data from the Labor Department’s annual



Three Dreaded Words: What’s for Dinner?

Hectic schedules and rising costs make evening meals a key pain point

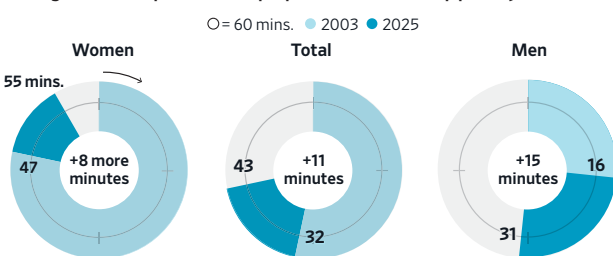
time use surveys show.

Time in the kitchen fell sharply after 1965 but began climbing again near the turn of the century, according to a historical time diary hosted by the University of Minnesota. It is up about 34% since the early 2000s, when the Labor Department began its survey.

Men are driving much of the rise. Their time spent cooking and cleaning has doubled in the past two decades, to 31 minutes a day last year from 16 minutes in 2003. (Women still spend more time in the kitchen—55 minutes a day.)

The Trump administration’s MAHA movement extols the virtues of home cooking. Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has said that Americans have

Average minutes spent on food preparation and cleanup per day



Source: Labor Department

forgotten how to shop for food and make meals. He has also said that cooking and eating together is one way to address the

country’s “spiritual malaise.”

Then there is the growing roster of online influencers showing off backyard chicken flocks and freshly baked bread, amplifying the pressure parents feel to produce healthy, home-cooked meals. Many turn to Instagram and TikTok for inspiration, only for recipe screenshots to go buried and unused in their phones’ camera rolls.

Alice Avelar, an Illinois insurance specialist, said she spends hours each week scouring the internet for recipes that can accommodate a variety of needs in her big, blended family.

Avelar’s youngest daughter has an eating disorder and is trying to gain weight. So is her father-in-law, who has diabetes and is recovering from colon cancer. Her husband suffers from gout, and doesn’t eat red meat. He and his father prefer spicy food, but the rest of Avelar’s family can’t tolerate as much heat.



Hannah Mitchell, 11, eats a quick dinner before she leaves for dance rehearsals.

Popular Trust Comes Under IRS Scrutiny

Continued from Page One

years. The aim is to pass wealth to the next generation, while using little or none of the \$15 million lifetime gift and estate tax exemption.

People set up GRATs for a set number of years, typically ranging from two to 10, to hold assets they expect to notably appreciate in value. Generally, if the assets appreciate faster than a special federal interest rate in the month the GRAT is formed—5.4% for September—the gains escape transfer taxes.

The grantor sets annuity payments to get back amounts that mirror the original contribution, plus interest at the special federal rate, to avoid gift taxes on the contribution. Payments must be made at least once a year.

If the assets don’t clear the hurdle rate, the grantor simply gets their money back through the annuity payments, leaving a balance of zero. Many simply roll over the annuity payments into another GRAT.

“It’s largely no-regrets planning,” said Mike Kaercher, deputy director of the Tax Law Center at New York University. “If your GRAT doesn’t

work, you just throw your assets into a new GRAT and try again.”

The Biden administration proposed cracking down on trust maneuvers, including GRATs, and estimated it would result in savings of \$84 billion over a decade. But legislative efforts to rein in various trusts have languished, and interest in GRATs has surged.

If someone had put \$1 million of Amazon.com stock in two-year rolling GRATs 10 years ago, for instance, it would have pushed out about \$4.5 million to the beneficiaries, free of gift and estate taxes, said Louis Laski, a former private-wealth lawyer and co-founder of GRATtrack. That is despite a big drop in Amazon’s stock in 2022.

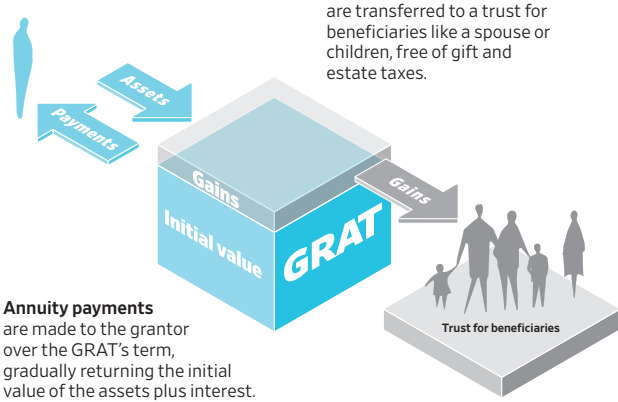
“If you keep doing it, you’re going to have winning years and losing years, and you hope you come out ahead,” said Lauren Wagner, a tax partner at Armanino Advisory.

Advisers said people should consider GRATs before their net worth approaches \$15 million, the level when the estate tax kicks in per person. “You should start thinking about GRATs when the velocity of your net worth starts to snowball,” said Nathan Dingler, co-founder of DiversiFi Capital, a Bay Area financial-planning firm.

One Dingler client in his 40s who works at a Magnificent Seven tech company has put \$8.2 million in a series of GRATs since March 2024 and was able to move \$3.1 million

Anatomy of a Grantor-Retained Annuity Trust

The grantor transfers assets like stock shares into a GRAT.



Annuity payments are made to the grantor over the GRAT’s term, gradually returning the initial value of the assets plus interest.

into trusts for his two children for a tax savings of more than \$1 million so far. Dingler said his clients typically set up new GRATs quarterly using the most “aggressive sleeve of their portfolio” to fund them.

There are ways GRATs can go wrong.

If the person who set up the GRAT dies before the end of the trust term, all or a portion of the assets are subject to estate taxes—which is one reason many set the trusts to expire after two years.

But most find success with GRATs, and many use additional methods to ensure their benefits. Some grantors, for instance, will lock in gains by “freezing” them and substituting the appreciated amount with cash or bonds—or even what

amounts to an IOU.

That is the move at issue in the Elcan case.

In 2018, Trisha Elcan funded three GRATs with assets valued at about \$1.5 billion: the Patricia Frist Elcan 2018 Annuity Trust I, Trust II and Trust III. Assets in the first two GRATs rose and resulted in trusts for the three daughters receiving assets of about \$200 million, according to Porter. The third GRAT, set up in August, didn’t grow enough to clear the hurdle and failed, he said.

Trisha funded the GRATs with interests in holding companies with HCA Healthcare stock. The disputed move came when she purchased assets from the GRATs in exchange for interest-bearing promissory notes, which she was required to repay.

Alice Avelar scours the internet for recipes that accommodate the varied needs of her family.

“Dinners are so exhausting,” Avelar said. “Most of the time I make two meals.”

For some parents, keeping up with everyone’s dinner needs leaves them feeling like they are running a restaurant. Others say they wind up serving foods like chicken nuggets more often than they’d like.

Some people said they are making it work. Luba Golosinskiy got a master class in bulk shopping and home cooking by watching her mother feed their large family.

“Hence all the meal prepping that I’ve been doing,” she said. “It all adds up at the end.”

To feed her own family of five, the South Carolina-based nurse said she spends hours turning Costco hauls into big batches of soup and salad. She has also got a rotation of slow-cooker meals like lasagna and chicken teriyaki that make for hot, low-effort dinners.

Selling convenience

Food brands see America’s dinner problem as an opportunity.

In 2023, snack giant Mars purchased Kevin’s Natural Foods, a startup that sells refrigerated meals like Chimichurri Beef and Chicken Tikka Masala. The brand touts its simple ingredients, targeting busy consumers who want to serve up healthier food in minutes.

The main consumers buying Kevin’s meals are millennial men, making the brand an anomaly among packaged foods.

“They are very time-strapped, but they don’t want to give up on their health focus,” said Kevin’s chief executive, Roxanne Bernstein.

The company expects Kevin’s to hit \$500 million in annual sales in the next few years.

Organic-food company Amy’s Kitchen, which started selling frozen pot pies nearly 40 years ago, has rolled out family-size options for meals like vegetable lasagna, cheese enchiladas and pad thai.

Amy’s pitch, CEO Paul Schiefer said, is tasty, healthy meals that can assuage people’s guilt about reaching for something quick.

Consumers are searching for restaurant-caliber meals that can be made even faster, said Jennifer Barnes, vice president of marketing for Nestlé USA’s frozen-foods division.

To understand people’s needs and preferences, Barnes said her team regularly follows shoppers through supermarkets and then home as they unload groceries.

Convenience hasn’t come cheap. Grocery prices in July were roughly 26% higher than they were five years ago, according to the Labor Department.

Anthony Fumo, a New Jersey-based accountant and father of two young children, said premade meals were the first to go when his grocery bill started climbing.

“The cost was just astronomical,” said Fumo, who sometimes hits four different grocery stores to seek out the best deals.

The trustee for the GRATs paid the annuities due to her by forgiving portions of the notes.

The IRS asserts that the use of the promissory notes in this fashion violated its regulations that govern GRATs. An agency spokesman said the IRS doesn’t comment on pending litigation.

The IRS wants to impose gift tax of \$614 million and penalties of \$122 million, on the theory that all of the transfers to the GRATs—including to the one that failed—were taxable gifts, taxed at 40%.

Trisha’s husband, Chuck, also faces liability, because the couple chose to treat any gifts they made as joint gifts.

The Elcans contend that Trisha’s use of promissory notes is consistent with both the tax code and regulations. She was a prolific user of GRATs, forming more than one each year from 2010 through at least 2019, according to court records.

While the Elcan case is pending, some advisers are recommending that people refrain from using promissory notes in GRAT transactions.

“Just do the tried and true thing with GRATs,” said Diana Zeydel, an estate lawyer and global chair of the private wealth services practice at Greenberg Traurig in Miami.

Zeydel said she disagrees with the IRS position but said she would caution clients against using notes for now.

“Why put yourself in the crosshairs?” she said.

The Elcans filed a summary judgment motion, requesting that the Tax Court reject the IRS’s position, and they are awaiting a decision.

NATE RYAN FOR WSJ (2)

PERSONAL JOURNAL.

What Changed With the Latest Apple Upgrade

The iPhone 18 Pros look similar to the 17 Pros but with a better camera and improved battery



PERSONAL TECHNOLOGY
NICOLE NGUYEN

To the dear readers, friends and family asking, “Should I upgrade?” consider this my official response: It depends. It depends on how you use your current iPhone or Apple Watch, and how old your current device is. I plan to review the iPhone Duo closer to its Oct. 23 availability date. Here, I will discuss the iPhone 18 Pro models, as well as the Apple Watch Series 12 and Ultra 4, which all recently came available.

iPhone 18 Pro and 18 Pro Max

“The Duo got all the attention, but what about the 18 Pro?”

Compared with last year’s 17 Pro models, the new 18 Pros look the same but have a better camera, more battery life (three more hours of video playback in the Pro, and six more hours in the larger Pro Max) and a slightly smaller Dynamic Island.

The headline is the main camera’s new variable aperture. There are now tiny blades around the lens that can open and close to control the light coming in, like a traditional camera. In older models, the aperture is fixed.

I’m certain a more technically proficient photographer would make better use of these controls. For testing, I kept the aperture setting on Auto.

The difference is subtle, though less so on nighttime shots. In the 18 Pro image, the details are sharper. That said, if you can’t tell which is better, you’re getting the picture: The 17 Pro already had a great camera system, and this is a marginal upgrade unless you’re coming from an older iPhone.

The 18 Pro also has a new A20 Pro chip. In benchmark tests, it is

impressive. But in my day-to-day, it was hard to notice performance improvements over last year’s iPhone 17 Pro. Apple says the chip unlocks more AI capabilities. I think app developers have yet to take advantage of it. So another reason to upgrade might be for AI tools that don’t exist yet.

“Is it worth looking for an iPhone 17 Pro? The 18 Pro doesn’t seem to be that much of an upgrade.”

Last year’s iPhone 17 Pro was one of my favorite iPhone releases, and came with substantial upgrades. The selfie camera got bumped up to 18 megapixels and the rear telephoto camera increased to 48 megapixels, with 8X zoom.

The 17 Pro was also the first device capable of running Apple’s most advanced on-device model (called AFM Core 3 Advanced) for more accurate dictation, and presumably more features to come. The 18 Pro models and Duo can run it, too.

If you are super-dependent on your phone for work, you could argue that the marginal gains of the 18 Pro are worth it. But if you just want to get in on the newer look and last year’s meaningful bump-up, a 17 Pro is a great upgrade, and you might find decent deals on refurbished models.

If you’re looking to save, the 16 Pro or 15 Pro would be affordable alternatives. If you go any older, you’ll miss out on the increasing slate of Apple Intelligence features.

Don’t want to go Pro? Apple has yet to release its basic iPhone 18—we expect that this spring—



but the iPhone 17 and iPhone 17e are still current. Just note, Apple raised prices \$100 on both of those models. It also still sells an iPhone 16, though it raised the price on that, too.

Apple Watch Series 12 and Ultra 4

“What’s new?” The Series 12 and Ultra 4 look like many past Apple Watches. But flip them over, and there’s a redesigned sensor array that can capture more frequent data. Apple claims these now have the most accurate wearable heart-rate trackers.

From my initial testing with indoor cycling and Pilates, the Series 12 did well: Over 97% of the readings within five beats per minute of my Polar H10 chest strap, the gold standard for heart-rate capture.

However, the Google Fitbit Air on my wrist was just as accurate, and the Garmin Cirqa on my bicep only fell short a bit.

Sumbul Desai, Apple’s vice president of health and fitness,



The Apple Watch Series 12, left, starts at \$399, and iPhone 18 Pro models, which cost \$1,199 and up.

told me that the Apple Watch algorithms for step-counting have been updated to be more accurate, even on older models. For example, aggressive knitting now won’t be counted as steps—and stroller walking will.

I was most looking forward to trying Readiness, a Series 12 and Ultra 4 feature that’s long been available in competing wearables. A high score means you’re ready for intense exercise, while a low score indicates your body needs rest. It’s based on recent fitness activity, as well as heart-rate variability, wrist temperature and other biometrics.

And it can change throughout the day: Recently, I woke up to an 8 out of 10. The Apple Watch nudged me to “Go for it,” which

was enough motivation to tackle a tough indoor interval workout on the bike. Later, my score dropped to 4 (“Pace yourself”)—the perfect excuse to hit the hay early.

The latest software, WatchOS 27, is available for models going back to the SE 3 and Series 9. The Series 12 or Ultra 4 is worth the upgrade if your watch is older than that, or if you’re serious about health and fitness. (If you just need a battery boost, a replacement costs \$99.)

“What about the other Watch stuff that was announced?”

Readiness will also be prominently featured in the AI-infused redesign of the Health app, coming later this year. If you don’t have a new Apple Watch, you’ll instead see Vitals, which compares your overnight metrics to previous nights.

From the developer beta preview, I got some great news:

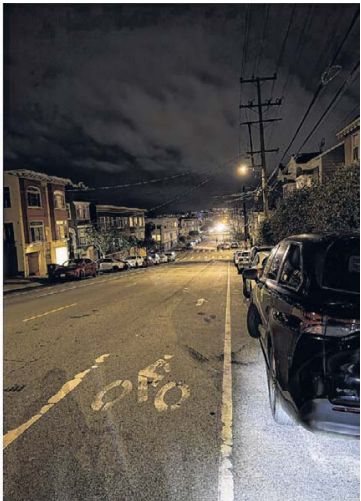
I’m aging backward. According to Apple’s new Health Age stat, I’m younger than my chronological years on Earth because of metrics like my cardio fitness, but my LDL cholesterol, based on lab work that I uploaded, could use some work.

I will soon write a bigger piece on the Health app and the watch’s coming AI features, which include the always-listening Siri Recap, Live Rewind and Sound Recognition.

The Apple Watch Series 12 and Ultra 4 can continuously measure heart rate every five seconds, compared with every five minutes in previous models.



Compared with the iPhone 17 Pro’s shot, at left, the 18 Pro at right captured more details—but you have to zoom in to spot the differences.



Gym Bros Get Humbled By Pilates

Continued from Page One with toy dumbbells. Many severely underestimate the difficulty of Pilates or its high-intensity offshoots, which are built on low-impact movements that prioritize core strength, posture and slow burn. They leave broken men—much to their part-



ners’ delight. Though women continue to dominate the discipline, more men are participating. The number of men doing Pilates at Life Time’s roughly 200 athletic clubs in North America, for instance, has more than doubled over the past five years. Some guys become interested after seeing videos of NFL players gliding on reformers during the off-season. Many are introduced by the women in their lives.

“All the girls want to bring their boyfriends and husbands,” said Laura Wilson, founder of Natural Pilates, a studio in Los Angeles and New York. She said women typically bring their partners after the partners say: “What is this ‘Pilates’ and why is it so expensive?”

Usually, she said, the women tell their instructors: “Make sure you kill them.”

In Wilson’s early-morning classes in Beverly Hills, West Hollywood and Sherman Oaks, three or four of the 13 reformers are claimed by men, she said—a 25% increase from a couple of years ago. More of the guys are younger now, said Wilson. The vast majority first came with a female companion.

WSJ reporter Jamie Waters fell off the machine during a Pilates class with his sister.



She said certain Pilates moves can be more difficult for men. “Their legs are like three times heavier than women’s, so when they do an exercise where their legs are out on a diagonal, they need to exert three times more force.” Though Pilates is a full-body workout, she added, it often focuses on glutes and legs, which many men neglect in their gym workouts.

Like the men I spoke to, I’d never done Pilates before. But I’m a HIIT class regular and a keen runner, so I figured I would do alright. One recent weekend I headed to reformer Pilates with my sister. Ten minutes and a flutter of scissor kicks later, my thighs felt like concrete pylons, and my hip flexors, which I was previously unacquainted with, were

Kedric Walker thought he was in for a ‘cute little workout.’ He later prayed the Lord would ‘heal us from Pilates.’

screaming. Then, while trying to put my feet into these stirrup things like I was about to give birth, I fell off the machine. My sister nearly coughed up a lung from laughing, though, like any self-respecting Pilates princess, she didn’t break form. (After class, I watched an Instagram video of NFL wide receiver Stefon Diggs falling off a reformer, which cheered me up immensely.)

The toughest part? Unlike my HIIT workouts, the handful of Pilates classes I attended didn’t allow any

breaks. In one, the “reset” between exercises was an ab plank. That is not a reset!

The relentless burn also wiped the smile off the face of Josué Loza, a delivery driver who accompanied his girlfriend, Karen Escandon, to a hot Pilates class in Houston several months ago. A before-and-after video that Escandon, a housecleaner, posted to TikTok received more than 135,000 “likes.”

Loza, 26, is “used to throwing weights around,” and at the start of the mat Pilates class, which was held in a 100-degree studio, he asked Escandon if the dumbbells would seriously only be 2.5 pounds. “He was talking so much crap,” said Escandon.

Within 10 minutes, he was drenched with sweat and out of breath. “The instructor kept telling me, ‘Hey, proper form, proper form, proper form,’ and I was like, ‘Ma’am, I can’t even lift my legs,’” said Loza.

His soul, he said, left his body. Though Loza hasn’t returned to Pilates—“I can’t show my face in there again”—the experience made him reassess his physicality. His ability to hurl 500-pound weights means nothing, he said, if he can’t execute simple bodyweight movements. Loza has since changed his gym routine to focus more on building flexibility.

“I don’t power lift anymore,” he said. “I am a new man.”

ARTS IN REVIEW

CULTURAL CONVERSATION

On the Rapid Rise in Art Theft

An experienced art detective discusses the upward trend in stealing jewels, paintings and more

By JUDITH H. DOBRZYNSKI

Before dawn on Sept. 8, thieves in southern France broke into what was Impressionist painter Pierre-Auguste Renoir's last home, now a museum, and escaped with two of his paintings. In August, unmasked men absconded with a 200-carat Van Cleef & Arpels platinum and diamond necklace from Vienna's Museum of Applied Arts; thieves stole several Bronze Age objects—some crafted in 23.5 karat gold—from an archaeological museum in Villena, Spain; and criminals took four paintings by the 15th-century master Antonello da Messina from a Sicilian museum. (Estimated combined value: more than \$100 million.)

Those daring crimes followed the July heist of a 2,500-year-old gold collar from a museum in Burgundy; the March theft of three famous paintings from a foundation near Parma, Italy; the infamous October 2025 raid at the Louvre, where men disguised as construction workers made off with eight pieces of the French crown jewels; and the early 2025 theft of the 2,500-year-old "Helmet of Cotofenești," plus three ancient gold bracelets from a Dutch museum. (Estimated combined value: about \$105 million.)

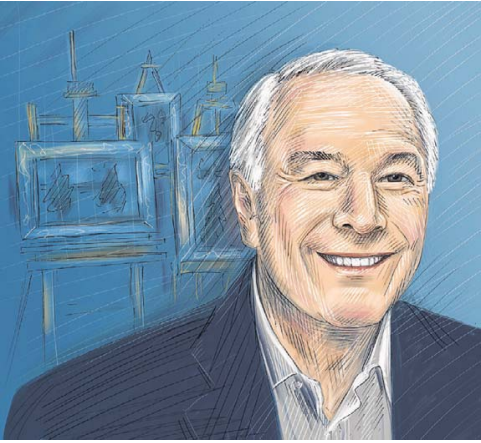
Coincidence? No, "it's a real uptick," says the art detective Robert King Wittman, a former FBI agent who during his 20-year tenure there recovered more than \$300 million of stolen art and cultural property. And there are reasons for it. "Criminals follow the market," he says: They read newspapers and see reports of over-the-top sales at auction houses and of gold surging to record prices exceeding \$5,000 an ounce, and "they want to go where the money is." After the theft in Messina, an Italian official cited as possible inspiration the much-noted purchase by Italy of a small

painting by Antonello for about \$15 million in February.

Equally important, Mr. Wittman says, are the targets themselves: "Criminals are going after easy targets, soft targets, and museums are much softer targets than banks and even some jewelry stores," which frequently employ armed security guards.

Mr. Wittman disparages the common notion that criminals are commissioned to steal renowned paintings for underworld plutocrats who want to look at them se-

their small museums are rich with treasures, but typically their guards are unarmed, acting more as visitors' guides than protectors of the art. Moreover, Mr. Wittman says, "A lot of the museums in Europe are literally hundreds and hundreds of years old, and they are historic houses, and it's very difficult to rewire internet technology into museums that are hundreds of years old with walls that could be three or four feet thick. It's not conducive to modern technology."



Robert King Wittman worked for the FBI for 20 years.

cretly on their walls, an idea popularized by the 1962 James Bond film, "Dr. No." As an inside joke, the movie featured a Goya portrait that had been stolen from London's National Gallery in 1961—it's shown hanging in the underground quarters of Dr. No, a mad scientist working for an organized crime syndicate. "I don't think that stealing for hire, when it comes to paintings, exists," Mr. Wittman says. "I've never seen it." Rather, he says, "these thieves are looking for a quick hit." Many are over in minutes.

It's no accident that most cases are taking place in Europe. Even

tion is not there, as it is in many U.S. museums today." (Smaller American museums may not have advanced security systems, but they rarely have high-value objects that lure major heisters—though they are vulnerable to what Mr. Wittman calls "shoplifting.")

Mr. Wittman, an avuncular, white-haired 70-year-old of medium height—self-described as "nondescript," which he noted is an asset for going undercover—has seen a lot of museums in his lifetime. Since his 2008 retirement from the FBI, he has acted as a "high-value asset security consultant" to museums, auction

houses, trade shows, collectors and the like to protect and, when necessary, recover illicitly acquired objects.

He has concluded that the perpetrators (even when they are "good thieves"—that is, not amateurish) are "terrible businessmen" who overestimate their potential returns. Consider the Van Cleef bib necklace, a dazzling Art Deco piece fashioned with 673 diamonds set in platinum that was commissioned in 1938 by Queen Nazli of Egypt. "No one will buy that intact," he says. While precious metals can be melted down and sold anywhere, and jewelry can be broken apart and its stones sold as separate gems in places like Antwerp's diamond market, part of the piece's estimated \$6 million value rested in its past ownership. Plus, he added, "a lot of the diamonds are small chips, and I bet that the 6- to 8-carat one in the middle is certified and identifiable" because of its provenance. "They won't get that much money for it," he says.

Famous paintings are obviously even more difficult to monetize. As they are not stealing for hire, criminals may not have a precise plan and are often forced to hold on to—and take care of—precious paintings for years until they can unload them, possibly to shady art dealers who try to sell them to unsophisticated buyers who don't know, or don't care, about provenance. That's where Mr. Wittman's undercover work has come in.

He likes to cite a 2008 recovery in Marseilles, France. Posing as an American art dealer, he gained the trust of the men who had stolen four paintings at gunpoint a year earlier from Nice's Museum of Fine Arts, and lured them into a trap. The thieves had agreed to meet a Frenchman sent by Mr. Wittman to receive the art in exchange for \$4.6 million in cash. Instead, they were met by French police, arrested, tried and sentenced to multiyear terms.

Based on his undercover work, Mr. Wittman figures that thieves can expect, perhaps, to get 10% of an artwork's estimated value. "That's what I'd offer them," he says.

That's not much, but neither is the downside. Penalties for art theft are usually low. "Art crime is a property crime, and any type of property crime is not considered a priority by most police departments," he explains. "It doesn't matter if it's a Monet or a Chevrolet at a police department—it's just property." Unless they use firearms—as in Nice—culprits are usually spared steep sentences.

Thieves may try to ransom the paintings, often a non-starter, but they can plausibly use them as bargaining chips. Mr. Wittman knows of gangs, stuck with stolen paintings, that "were using them as negotiating tools to get out of jail for other crimes. If they were caught for stealing cars, or gun-running or drugs, they would try to use the paintings to get their charges lowered or dropped." Some countries—including France, Norway and in some cases, Italy—permit that, he says. In the U.S., federal prosecutors can recommend lighter sentences if a defendant substantially aids in the recovery of stolen property.

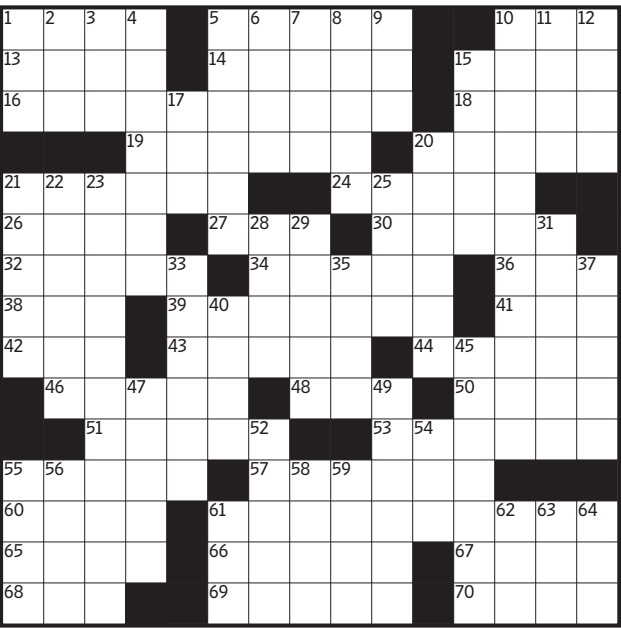
The recent spate of thefts is worrying officials. Europol, the EU's Hague-based law enforcement agency, recently reported that art thieves are increasingly using bolder, more confrontational approaches, wielding firearms, sledgehammers, axes and explosives, and that they may well recognize the low risk involved.

To Mr. Wittman, the answer is deterrence. Museums, he says, have to improve their electronic security systems; vet, annually train and check on all of their employees and volunteers; and make sure their operations manuals and procedures are updated and circulated every year. "You need all three legs, and if any of those legs are not there, you have vulnerability, and that's a bad situation for a museum." For a growing number of institutions, that is proving all too prescient.

Ms. Dobrzynski writes about art for the Journal and other publications.

BARBARA KELLEY

The WSJ Daily Crossword | Edited by Mike Shenk



VARIETY PACK | By Zhouqin Burnikel

- Across**

1 Chunk of granite

5 "Paradise Lost" tempter

10 Debate side

13 Romance writer Roberts

14 Political pamphlet

15 Cambodia neighbor

16 High vantage point

18 Like some vaccines

19 Duck or chicken piece

20 First course, for short

21 Share on social media

24 Like an old mattress

26 "Just doing my job"

27 Windy City trains

30 Tooth projections
- 32 Game with captures and checks

34 Japanese spitz breed

36 Lobed organ

38 Toronto's prov.

39 Enters via a keyboard, and (with an added apostrophe) a hint to this puzzle's theme

41 Bear, in Spanish

42 Request in blackjack

43 Financial review

44 It comes before beta

46 Suspicious sort

48 Cribbage jack

50 Cheers at a bullfight

51 Finds a spot in a lot

53 Get into the market
- 55 Sunflower supporters

57 Total beginner

60 Melody

61 Writing tool shaped like a pickle, e.g.

65 Rustic stopovers

66 Pickling liquid

67 Eight, in Italian

68 Tropicana Field player

69 Druids, e.g.

70 Previously owned
- Down**

1 "Weekend Update" show, for short

2 Bathroom, in Brisbane

3 Boxer's warning

4 Diamond gofers

5 Tropicana Field locale, familiarly

6 About 31,700 square miles, for Lake Superior

7 Does some road repair

8 They have nos. at banks

9 Indefinite degree

10 Nightlife enthusiasts

11 Crowd noise

12 City with an opera house next to a fjord

15 Yearns

17 Cal. spans

20 Lizard with a dewlap

- 21 Maker of ScanSnap scanners
- 22 Of a particular race or culture
- 23 Tidy sum
- 25 Broadway opening
- 28 Org. in "The Rookie"
- 29 Bundle of yarn
- 31 Places for scouts' merit badges
- 33 Flight features
- 35 What an analogy colon means
- 37 Tribute with many put-downs
- 40 "That's disgusting!"
- 45 Parting words before ending a call
- 47 Choices for parents-to-be
- 49 Books with cross references?
- 52 "Bo-o-oring!"
- 54 Trivial complaint
- 55 Show signs of waking up
- 56 Makeup of some cat food
- 58 Not good at all
- 59 Headed out
- 61 Network for 1-Down
- 62 Scoreboard amts.
- 63 Summer, in Martinique
- 64 Silent approval

Previous Puzzle's Solution

S	H	O	T	S		P	E	R	P		Z	I	P
T	O	U	R	E	D		E	R	I	E		E	D
O	N	T	I	M	E		N	A	M	E	D	R	O
I	D	O		P	L	A	N		V	I	O	L	A
C	A	F	F	E	I	N	E		F	R	E	E	
						U	R	S	A		L	I	D
												W	A
S	C	A	R	F		K	I	D		C	E	N	T
M	A	R	R	I	A	G	E		P	E	N	A	L
O	R	G	Y		L	A	Y		I	N	D	E	X
G	E	O		S	O	N			D	A	T	A	
S	O	U	S	A		A	C	A	I		C	H	E
K	I	C	K	B	A	C	K		M	C	K	E	A
I	L	L				B	L	U	E		S	K	I
T	S	A				Y	A	R	N		S	N	A

ARTS CALENDAR

HAPPENINGS FOR THE WEEK OF SEPTEMBER 22

By WSJ ARTS IN REVIEW STAFF

Film

"Primetime" (Sept. 25)
Robert Pattinson stars as "To Catch a Predator" host Chris Hansen in Lance Oppenheim's film about the complicated relationship among the TV program, law enforcement and the pursuit of justice.

"Heart of the Beast"

(Sept. 25)
A former special-forces soldier (Brad Pitt) and his military K-9 survive a plane crash and must rely on their skills and trans-species bond to survive the Alaskan wilderness in David Ayer's film.

TV

"Brothers" (Apple TV, Sept. 23)
Matthew McConaughey and Woody Harrelson discovered in 2023 that they might be half brothers. In this meta-comedy from

Theater

"How Shakespeare Saved My Life" (Public Theater, New York, Sept. 27-Oct. 25)
Jacob Ming-Trent wrote and stars in this autobiographical solo show about a talented young poet who finds his opportunities limited by his identity but finds the power to overcome in the works and words of great writers.

Music

Leon Bridges, "Happiness Anytime" (Sept. 25)
The artist globe-trots across genres on his new record, blending South American sounds, Afrobeats and disco with his neo-soul vibes.

Dance

New York City Ballet (David H. Koch Theater, New York, Sept. 22-Oct. 18)
George Balanchine's "Jewels" opens what the company hopes will be a sparkling fall season, which

Exhibitions

The Lucas Museum of Narrative Art (Los Angeles, opens Sept. 22)
George Lucas's long-percolating institution finally opens the doors to its sci-fi-like building, offering visitors "Star Wars" props, comics memorabilia, art from the likes of Norman Rockwell, Beatrix Potter, Frida Kahlo, and much more.

"The Horror Show"

(Academy Museum of Motion Pictures, Los Angeles, Sept. 26-July 25, 2027)
As the spooky season opens, so does this presentation that explores audiences' enduring love for the horror genre. The immersive show explores horror tropes through themed galleries that explore cinema classics including "Alien," "The Exorcist" and "The Shining," as well as more recent fan favorites such as "Midsommar" and "Get Out."

Art

"Teresa Margolles: En el lugar de los hechos (At the Scene)" (MoMA PS1, Long Island City, N.Y., Sept. 24-Feb. 2027)
The first American survey of the Mexican artist includes multiple room-size installations and a new commission. Trained as a forensic pathologist, Ms. Margolles focuses on violence and the forces that drive it in sculptures, photographs and more.

Last Call

"Musical Bodies" (The Met Fifth Avenue, New York, through Sept. 27)
With objects spanning millennia and cultures, this exhibit explores the dynamic relationships among instruments, art and our physical selves. Our critic called it a "rousing exhibition celebrating the creative and aesthetic realm where music, art, and global cultures meet."

Write to brian.kelly@wsj.com.

A24

OPINION

AI’s Threat to China’s Control



GLOBAL VIEW
By Walter Russell Mead

As artificial intelligence reshapes the world, it is making its presence felt in high-level diplomacy. After meeting with Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng in New York Sunday, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent told journalists that the world’s two AI superpowers discussed establishing a channel for communication over AI developments with national-security implications. This is good news, but deep cooperation between the two countries will be difficult to build.

On AI as on so much else, Washington and Beijing see similar problems through different lenses. Both sides seek the military and economic advantages AI can bring, but both also worry about the job losses, economic turmoil and potential catastrophes the new technology could unleash. Chinese officials, however, will be focused on a topic many Americans haven’t thought much about: the existential threat AI could present to communist rule.

For the party, the ultimate point of technology is to secure communist rule in China while increasing the country’s clout in the wider world. Making China the global leader in the development of new technologies, AI included, legitimates communist rule by highlighting the party’s technocratic competence. It advances Communist Party goals

by producing the wealth needed for the construction of socialism at home and the projection of Chinese power abroad. It improves Communist Party governance by providing policymakers with the information and feedback they need for smarter and more finely tuned economic planning, and it secures Communist Party power by enhancing the government’s ability to monitor the population and to suppress or marginalize dissent.

The arrival of the internet led many in the West to predict the fall of Chinese communism as the torrents of free content on the global web undermined the party’s control of information and empowered individuals. China’s rulers solved that issue, though not without some continuing problems. The so-called Great Firewall cut most Chinese users off from the open internet, and a combination of close censorship and heightened surveillance dramatically reduced Chinese citizens’ ability to use the web as a tool for political dissidence. Even as Chinese policymakers blocked much of the internet’s destabilizing potential, they went all in on its ability to promote economic growth.

It was a brilliant success. Thanks to the web, the Chinese government can use an unprecedented network of cameras, centralized information gathering and other forms of surveillance to build the most powerful form of social control the human race has ever seen. The government tracks your purchases,

your movements and your online activity and has access to everything from your medical records to your credit information.

This is the template that Beijing’s planners bring to AI. The question is whether it can work.

The greatest value of AI comes from its ability to run wild. Hoovering up gobs of information, analyzing data without external constraints,

Artificial intelligence isn’t very intelligent if its knowledge base is lies and propaganda.

and addressing complex problems on a purely pragmatic, results-oriented basis allow AI to offer insights and strategies that its human creators haven’t foreseen.

If Chinese AI, for example, is forced to stay inside the Great Firewall, using only party-approved information and sources, the value of its results will be gravely compromised. There is a lot of important and even necessary information that the Chinese Communist Party doesn’t want the public to have, and communist manipulation of everything from the historical record to current official statistics creates discrepancies throughout the information domain. If AI in China works only with official data and within the officially sanctioned, propaganda-soaked and politically vetted versions of

the past, it will give Chinese users misleading information and bad recommendations. Garbage in, garbage out.

But keeping Chinese AI inside the Great Firewall may not be easy. Good AI isn’t a respecter of human taboos. The body of doctrine Chinese media refers to as Xi Jinping Thought on Socialism with Chinese Characteristics for a New Era may be essential reading for party officials, but this is exactly the kind of conceptual prejudice that AI agents are built to transcend. Getting AI to respect foundational party doctrines without losing the creativity and unpredictability that give AI much of its value may prove too daunting a task even for the most zealous party officials.

While the U.S. should seek cooperation with China when it comes to reducing the dangers AI poses to both countries, we have no interest in helping the Communist Party harness the power of AI to cement its increasingly totalitarian hold on Chinese society.

American officials discussing AI with their counterparts should remember that the two governments want different things. We want AI to promote human freedom and creativity. China wants a technological platform that bolsters communist power at home and Chinese influence abroad. We can be sure that the Chinese side never lets pragmatic cooperation in areas of mutual interest obscure the core differences that divide us. We must be no less realistic.

BOOKSHELF | By Naomi Schaefer Riley

Teaching Kids How to Code

Coding Kids

By **Natasha Singer**
Norton, 352 pages, \$31.99

In 2014 the FBI began investigating the Los Angeles Unified School District for its \$1 billion iPad program. Security breaches and questionable procurement practices had plagued an initiative that was supposed to bridge the digital divide for underprivileged students. The investigation, though it didn’t lead to criminal charges, marked the beginning of a serious rethinking across the country about technology in classrooms, culminating most recently in some districts banning screens in school, particularly in lower grades.

In “Coding Kids,” Natasha Singer tells the story of “big tech’s battle to remake public schools.” But it was more than hardware and software that technology companies were selling. It was also, as Ms. Singer explains, the idea that “computing was a golden ticket to propel kids into jobs, money and power.” Ms. Singer, who covers tech-industry influence in schools for the New York Times, argues that marketing paid for by Apple, Google, Microsoft and a variety of other tech firms helped “to steer more students to computer science.” Now that “learn to code” doesn’t seem to be the foolproof career advice it once was, thanks to artificial intelligence, Ms. Singer argues that it’s time for a reckoning.

In 2013 the twin brothers Ali and Hadi Partovi founded a nonprofit called Code.org. With millions in funding from tech companies and the use of star-studded videos, the organization launched the Hour of Code. Everyone from Ashton Kutcher to Rep. Eric Cantor, the House majority leader at the time, was recorded encouraging children to learn to write code. Even President

Barack Obama got in on the act. “The publicity blitz for Hour of Code,” Ms. Singer writes, “had no antecedents in U.S. education and represented a new strategy for education reform.” In its first week alone, the organization’s promotional video “generated more than two million views on YouTube.” But this was not simply an effort to get individual children interested. It was an elaborate plan to get administrators involved. Code.org even offered \$10,000 in computer equipment to those schools where all students participated in an hour of coding.

But what exactly did Code.org mean when it said that the Hour of Code had reached 10 million students in 170 countries? Ms. Singer calls it a gimmick, noting that “many kids were clicking, dragging and dropping—essentially stacking or compiling—prewritten coding blocks, without writing out the computer code itself.” Moreover, the statistics measured only the number of students who started the lesson. The Hour of Code didn’t even last a full hour.

There are points in “Coding Kids” where Ms. Singer seems aware of the dumbed-down nature of many of these efforts. Students were spending time with videogame characters, not learning much useful information about the machines they were supposed to be mastering. At the same time, the author worries that computer science was being taught as “an engineering discipline centered on technical training” by people who had a “disdain” for “issues like the social impacts of new technologies.” She cites “key figures in computer science” who observed how this approach was creating “inequities.” Indeed, much of the book is devoted to decrying how girls and black children are less likely than white and Asian boys to enroll in computer science.

The strategy to get computer science added to more school curricula was wildly successful. In 2024, 60% of American high schools offered a course in computer science, compared to only 10% in 2013. But, Ms. Singer laments, “Black, Latino and lower-income students were less likely to have access to and take computing courses.”

How tech companies sold schools on computer-science instruction that hasn’t worked out for many children.

The tech sector’s interest in adding computer-science courses to schools grew from a desire to get more customers and capable employees. If more students were to take computer science, and particularly AP Computer Science, the thinking went, the tech sector would gain a skilled workforce. But offering courses is different from ensuring that students will succeed in them. In Los Angeles, Ms. Singer reports, the number of schools offering AP Computer Science nearly doubled between 2004 and 2006, “but many of the Black and Latino students in the courses ultimately struggled with the AP computer-science exam and, as a result, would not be able to earn college credit for the course.”

In Los Angeles, where a little more than a quarter of black students are proficient in math, it can hardly be surprising that the population is struggling with a college-level computer-science course. The subject requires that students use logic and math and go back over work carefully to find errors. Even if we don’t need many coders in the future, as an intellectual exercise computer science is not the worst use of time.

The truth is that most tech companies would be perfectly happy to hire employees who have done well in calculus and physics even if they have never taken a computer-science class. But Ms. Singer’s solution is instead to push “critical computing” classes that treat computer science as a social science. She writes favorably about courses that ask “probing questions about computing, including about the impact of white male hacker stereotypes on girls interested in the field.” She profiles a teacher who gives “students permission to interrogate corporate power” and a “tech auditor” who incorporates spoken-word poetry to “raise deeper questions about the limits of AI systems and their potential to exclude certain groups of people.”

Ms. Singer describes what she believes is the inspiring addition of a course called AP Computer Science Principles to school offerings. This class, which is significantly less rigorous than AP Computer Science, does seem to enroll more girls and more black and Hispanic students and is more like a social science. But to what end? There is no equivalent class in college and so no college credit to accrue. Computer Science Principles will not prepare students to work in tech. It could make them more savvy about the way Silicon Valley sells its wares. But it also eliminates what may be the only real argument for keeping the subject in schools—which is that students may start to grasp how computers work. If teaching computer science now means students learn critical theory instead of coding, our AI overlords have already won.

Ms. Riley, a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute, is the author of “No Way to Treat a Child.”



MAIN STREET
By William McGurn

Hong Kong prison cell. But does the master deal maker in the Oval Office still have the juice?

Days before the 2024 election, radio host Hugh Hewitt asked Mr. Trump about getting Mr. Xi to free Jimmy—who is my godson. “Hundred percent yes. I’ll get him out,” Mr. Trump assured. “He’ll be easy to get out.”

The reason Jimmy was in jail, he added, was that Mr. Xi “doesn’t respect Biden and Kamala. Who would?”

Now Mr. Trump is president. If Jimmy was in jail in 2024 because the Chinese didn’t respect Joe Biden and Kamala Harris, isn’t the fact that he’s still behind bars a sign that China doesn’t respect Mr. Trump?

Mr. Xi can deliver a face-saving gesture when necessary. In January, British then-Prime Minister Keir Starmer made a trade visit to Beijing. China waited nine days before a Hong Kong court sentenced

Mr. Lai, a British citizen, to 20 years in prison.

But for its summit in Washington, Beijing hasn’t wasted any time in embarrassing Mr. Trump. Little more than a week ago, China handed down prison sentences to three Hong Kong leaders for organizing a vigil to commemorate the June 1989 military crackdown on Tiananmen Square.

Yet Mr. Trump keeps tout-ing his “good relationship” with Mr. Xi, perhaps because he thinks a trade deal with China will bail him out in time for the midterms. It may explain why Mr. Trump will be at Joint Base Andrews to greet Mr. Xi when his plane arrives. But Mr. Trump’s waiting on the tarmac like a supplicant will only confirm Mr. Xi’s view that China is on the rise while America is on the decline.

“Donald Trump is being played in a false belief that the Chinese can deliver a good trade deal,” says Mark Simon, Jimmy’s top business associate. “It can’t. The ABCs of China’s economy today stand for aging, broken and corrupt.”

Before departing for Beijing in May, Mr. Trump again called Mr. Xi “a friend of mine” and “somebody we get along with.” But his “friend” made sure he left China largely empty-handed. Mean-

while, the buttering up risks making Mr. Trump look like a chump if the Chinese don’t give him something in return.

Then there’s Jimmy Lai. He doesn’t carry a U.S. passport, but he believes America is the best friend the Chinese people have. And he has always said so, in person and in his publications.

Long before Mr. Trump made it a slogan, Jimmy believed America was great—a force for good in an imperfect

Jimmy Lai is more a threat to Beijing in prison than out.

world. He defended U.S. military interventions. He thought the First Amendment a gift to the world. And he defended Mr. Trump up to the moment when Jimmy was arrested.

Though he started his business career making clothes, Jimmy moved to media because he wanted to empower Hong Kong’s people with an American-style free press. The Chinese recognized what he was doing, put him in jail, and basically called him an American agent. Doesn’t a man who put it all on the line to defend America deserve Mr. Trump’s help in his hour of need?

In 1987, Ronald Reagan

Mamdani Won’t Intimidate Israel

By **Ofir Akunis**

New York

This city becomes the world’s diplomatic capital every September, as leaders from nearly all 193 member countries convene for the United Nations General Assembly. The purpose is for nations to debate and for adversaries to converse. Yet this year there is a distraction: Mayor Zohran Mamdani.

Our prime minister will proudly stand before the General Assembly Thursday.

Throughout his campaign and early months in office, Mr. Mamdani vowed to order the city’s police to arrest Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, Israel’s democratically elected leader. In July Mr. Mamdani admitted he had no lawful power to do so. After nearly 10 months of intimidation, Mr. Netanyahu will proudly stand at the General

Assembly podium on behalf of the Jewish state. He arrives in New York this week for a visit I am arranging as Israel’s consul general.

The hypocrisy of Mr. Mamdani’s selective criticism of Israel must be acknowledged.

Iran, whose regime murders its own people and supports terrorist proxies, will have a voice at the General Assembly this week. So will Turkey, where Recep Tayyip Erdoğan’s government has detained opposition politicians and restricted free speech.

Why is the focus on Israel’s democratically elected leader rather than actual tyrants and demagogues? The answer is clear: antisemitism.

Mr. Mamdani’s rhetoric confirms that his issue isn’t with Mr. Netanyahu but with the Jewish state. These activists would oppose our presence at the General Assembly no matter who leads Israel.

Supporters of the mayor have waved terrorist flags on the streets, lionized the Oct. 7 massacre as “resistance,” vandalized Jewish businesses with swastikas, and attacked people wearing yar-



Benjamin Netanyahu.

mulkes on the subway.

Antisemitism is the oldest form of hate, and throughout history it has found new excuses. Today, the excuses are Israel and our military.

The Jewish people’s history of persecution demonstrates the need for a strong Jewish state with a voice at major diplomatic gatherings. And when Israel is singled out, the impact doesn’t stop at the United Nations.

Antisemitic hate crimes in New York City this year have increased by 8.5%. In July, Jews were the targets of 70%

of all hate crimes. This is the consequence of Mr. Mamdani’s rhetoric. But intimidation won’t stop us.

Israel is working with the New York City Police Department and federal agencies to ensure the prime minister’s safety, as well as that of Israeli and Jewish New Yorkers. I thank the many New Yorkers standing with Israel and supporting democratic values.

This week, when Mr. Netanyahu comes to New York, as leaders from around the world do every year, it is important for New Yorkers to consider the duplicity of those opposing Israel’s presence and what that says about the city we all call home.

I call on the mayor to mind his own business and protect the city of New York, rather than wreaking havoc that will put his own residents at risk. You are either on one side or the other. You either support the Jewish state or you support our extremist enemies. There is no in between.

Mr. Akunis is Israel’s consul general in New York.

OPINION

REVIEW & OUTLOOK

What Does Trump Want From Xi?

President Trump is giving Chinese President Xi Jinping a king’s welcome this week, as he pursues what the White House calls “strategic stability.” The question is whether there will be much substance beneath the surface pomp and bonhomie.

What would a productive outcome look like? Start with a change in Beijing’s aggressive behavior that seeks to change the global status quo. This means more than the usual press release about buying more soybeans and Boeing planes.

Ask Mr. Xi whether China is helping Iran shoot at Americans in the Middle East. Warn Mr. Xi about ripping off U.S. artificial-intelligence models, and to stop threatening the peaceful status quo in the Taiwan Strait. Press Mr. Xi to stop using his advantage in rare-earth minerals to coerce other nations.

Consider Iran. Mr. Trump wants a non-nuclear regime in Tehran and a peace deal in Ukraine, and the impediment to both is war support from Beijing. China masks its provision of satellite data for targeting as a commercial operation, and it buys Iranian oil and sells semiconductors for weapons. And why did China join Russia last week in vetoing the U.S. resolution extending the mandate of experts monitoring Iran’s compliance with international sanctions? These aren’t the actions of a friend, and Mr. Trump can say so.

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said Monday the leaders will also address artificial intelligence and the two countries have started a joint AI dialogue. This could be useful if it reduces the opacity around China’s AI progress and creates a hotline in case of harm from rogue agents.

But don’t expect much cooperation given the competition for AI dominance, which Mr. Trump well understands, and Beijing’s long history of technology theft. The U.S. will have to sanction entities that distill American AI models, which is fuel for Chinese progress. Another

red line: No new advanced chip exports that would help China catch up more quickly.

Mr. Trump does have leverage with Mr. Xi.

The new sanctions law he signed last week gives him the power to impose tariffs of up to 100% on Russia’s biggest oil and gas customers to choke Vladimir Putin’s war financing. China and India are the two biggest buyers. Mr. Xi should finish the week thinking the President is willing to use that tariff power if China keeps helping the Russian war machine.

Mr. Xi also needs the U.S. market for his exports given the weakness in China’s domestic economy. China’s mercantilist economic model relies on exports for growth and jobs, and the rest of the world is losing patience with absorbing China’s surplus production. Mutual reductions in tariffs and trade barriers could help both countries if China drops its rare-earth extortion and cyber hacking.

The Communist Party boss’s main priority, as always, will be Taiwan. He wants Mr. Trump to delay or scuttle a pending \$14 billion U.S. arms sale to the democratic island, and caving on this demand would be an historic mistake.

Taiwan is trying to spend 5% of its economy on defense by 2030, but it will struggle to reach that NATO standard absent faster U.S. weapons deliveries. Taiwan’s internal politics is divided, and a U.S. delay would feed anxiety that America is unreliable and help those on the island who think Taiwan must accept a Hong Kong-style takeover. For the sake of deterrence, Mr. Xi has to think Mr. Trump would defend Taiwan if China tries a blockade or invasion.

The world’s most powerful nations need to communicate, and personal trust between leaders can be helpful. But Mr. Trump has largely rejected the strategic competition with China that defined his first term, and now he is betting on his personal rapport with Mr. Xi to advance American goals. So far there hasn’t been much tangible to show for it.

Start with no more help for Iran to target and kill Americans.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The Dangers of Fractional-Reserve Banking

Norbert Michel and Ryan Chan-Wei are right that the current expected credit losses methodology (CECL) asks banks to make unreliable forecasts about future losses (“A Flawed Model That Burdens Small Banks,” Letters, Sept. 15). They are also right that credit risk isn’t the same thing as an incurred loss. But the deeper problem is fractional-reserve banking itself.

Banks promise depositors money on demand but then turn around and lend at longer maturities and at risk. Ordinarily, a bank would be disciplined by depositors’ concern about its solvency and by bank competition. The Federal Reserve and federal deposit insurance weaken that discipline. The Fed stands ready to supply liquidity during panics, while the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation assures most depositors that they need not bear the consequences of choosing an unsound bank.

After institutionalizing this inherently risky arrangement, the govern-

ment then tries to deal with the risks it helped create with another layer of intervention: capital requirements, supervisory rules, and now enforcing the CECL standard.

Instead of tinkering with these interventions, which are likely to create further problems and another layer of interventions, we should deal with the fundamental problem. Immediately redeemable deposits should be fully backed by reserves, while loans should be financed by bank capital and genuine saving through time deposits, bonds and other credit instruments. Losses would then fall on the investors and creditors who voluntarily take on the credit risk.

CECL doesn’t solve the problem of fractional-reserve banking. It adds another regulatory patch to an unstable system propped up by the Fed and FDIC.

JONATHAN NEWMAN
Mises Institute
Auburn, Ala.

Whitmer Is to Blame for Michigan’s Troubles

In her op-ed “How Tariffs Hurt Michigan” (Sept. 16), Gov. Gretchen Whitmer rightly points out the damage that tariffs are causing Michiganders, as well as most Americans. She also notes the lack of pushback from Republicans to dial back the debilitating trade war with our allies. But she glosses over important points about how tariffs and taxes affect our state.

If Ms. Whitmer truly wishes to help consumers by rolling back tariffs, how about pushing to cut the 25% duty on light-duty pickups, often called the “chicken tax” because it originated as a retaliatory measure in a trade dispute over poultry? Imagine how much that would save truck buyers. But ending the tariff would affect the profits of Ford and General Motors, so dear to Michigan’s economy, so it will never be proposed.

The governor also touts putting “money in people’s pockets by delivering free pre-K and school meals and more than \$1 billion in tax cuts.” What she doesn’t mention is that her administration challenged a law that was supposed to cut Michigan’s personal income tax from 4.25% to 4.05%. Ms. Whitmer determined that the law’s language meant a one-year-only rate cut, while Republicans and

business groups argued that the cut was supposed to be permanent. The Michigan Supreme Court declined to hear an appeal, letting the 4.25% tax rate stand. The 0.20% cut would have been nice for Michigan taxpayers. Perhaps the money was used to provide “free” lunches, thus creating more dependence on the government.

BILL RYCKBOST
Holland, Mich.

Gasoline prices in Michigan exceed those of neighboring states. The price per gallon in Michigan is 36 cents higher than in Ohio, 48 cents higher than in Wisconsin and 90 cents higher than in Indiana, according to AAA. Why? Ms. Whitmer and her Democratic allies passed a new fuel tax. Michigan energy prices compared with nearby states are even more stark, and the service is less reliable, after Ms. Whitmer’s aggressive push for renewables such as wind and solar.

The governor blames President Trump for Michigan’s economic challenges. But Michigan’s problems aren’t Mr. Trump’s, nor are they Canada’s. They are hers.

MATTHEW J. WILK
Northville, Mich.

Don’t Expand Payroll Taxes for Social Security

In his column “Republicans’ Pre-Emptive Social Security Surrender” (Political Economics, Sept. 18), Joseph C. Sternberg makes a persuasive argument against expanding payroll taxes to cover higher incomes as a way to solve Social Security’s financing crunch, aptly explaining the complicated trade-offs involved. But he only scratches the surface when he describes the damage higher payroll taxes could do.

While Mr. Sternberg focuses on the effect higher tax rates might have on work incentives, it also matters how the high earners who would be taxed would otherwise allocate that money. For example, higher earners are much more likely to save for retirement using private investments. Private investments generate higher returns than the Social Security formula and help finance businesses and long-term economic growth.

Further, if the payroll tax cap were lifted, the additional tax would fall statutorily on both employees and companies. Companies might re-

spond to the increased labor costs by reducing labor costs in other areas. A very tempting target would be their 401(k) matching contributions. After all, employees would be eligible for additional Social Security benefits.

Policymakers and the public need to ask whether it is in the long-term interest of the country to redirect this large amount of money away from private investment and feed it into a convoluted redistribution formula that will redistribute these taxes, at least in part, back to the high earners themselves.

JEREMY NIGHOHOSSIAN
Competitive Enterprise Institute
Washington

Smartphones in the Military

As a veteran, I read John Spencer’s op-ed “Can Military Morale Survive Smartphones?” (Sept. 17) with interest. Service members shouldn’t be blamed for maintaining contact with family members back home. It’s likely that effective leadership was lacking at every level of the military chain of command and resulted in the many issues that Mr. Spencer lists regarding the use of technology.

Today’s military leaders need to step up and manage the use of personal electronics. More importantly, they need to lead their soldiers, sailors and airmen through adversity, just as plenty of second lieutenants did during World War II when they tended to their troops after they received “Dear John” letters.

CHRISTOPHER HIKADE
Former U.S. Air Force officer and retired CIA intelligence officer
Winnetka, Ill.

Pepper ... And Salt

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL



“I tell you, this polluter watching never gets old.”

Letters intended for publication should be emailed to wsj.letters@wsj.com. Please include your city, state and telephone number. All letters are subject to editing, and unpublished letters cannot be acknowledged.

Rob Bonta’s Paramount Bounty

The political melodrama over the future of Warner Bros. Discovery has been a full length feature film. But on Monday the credits finally began to roll as California Attorney General Rob Bonta extracted a bounty in return for letting Paramount Skydance acquire the Hollywood studio.

In a less partisan era, Paramount Skydance CEO David Ellison’s \$110 billion bid for Warner Bros. Discovery probably would have drawn less opposition. But government today wields enormous regulatory power over business, which both parties are seeking to exploit for political gain. That’s the background for understanding Monday’s settlement.

Twelve Democratic state AGs led by Mr. Bonta agreed to drop their suit against the merger in return for various concessions. The combined studios will invest some \$1.5 billion in domestic film and TV production over the next five years and release at least 30 movies a year in theaters. This will please Hollywood’s big-shot producers, stars and unions.

The two companies will also separately negotiate carriage fees with cable providers. That could reduce the combined company’s leverage to obtain higher fees for carrying their channels. You have to smile at Democratic AGs collaborating to protect giant cable companies, which are also combining to gain scale and leverage.

The lawsuit focused on the merger’s effects on theater and cable distributions, but both are shrinking businesses. Driving Mr. Ellison’s pursuit of Warner Bros. was the need to expand Paramount’s streaming library to compete with the likes of Netflix, Disney+ and Amazon. Netflix has four times as many subscribers as Paramount Plus.

The new company will boast some \$80 billion in debt. To clinch the deal, Paramount had agreed to pay Netflix \$2.8 billion to cancel its engagement with Warner Bros. It also promised a \$7 billion breakup fee to Warner Bros. if its merger wasn’t approved, and \$7 million a day if it wasn’t consummated by the end of this month. So the clock

was ticking. Mr. Ellison installed Bari Weiss as head of CBS News to grease the wheels for Trump Administration approval. But his courtship of the White House magnified Democratic opposition. Saving CNN from Mr. Ellison became the real motivation for Mr. Bonta and the AGs. Irony alert: Mr. Ellison in 2024 gave a Democratic Super PAC backing the Biden-Harris campaign nearly \$1 million.

Mr. Ellison placated the AGs by agreeing to establish an “editorial independence board” to ensure “accuracy, independence, fairness and journalistic integrity” at CNN and CBS News. Isn’t this what news editors are supposed to do? The board will consist of five retired or active journalists to be appointed by the new Paramount-Warner Bros. board.

The board will apparently act as a sort of ombudsman that will arbitrate disputes between employees and management regarding “alleged reporting bias or failure to meet agreed reporting fairness standards.” This could make life miserable for editors. Watch the staff leaking flourish. From our experience, a company works best when employees aren’t at cross purposes with management.

Mr. Ellison may have agreed to these terms because he cares less about the success of the news networks than he does its streaming business. Don’t be surprised if he eventually agrees to part with CNN for the right price.

Democratic AGs bless the Warner Bros. deal for a political price.

OPINION

The Coming Republican Revolt Against Tariffs

By Phil Gramm
And Donald Boudreaux

Donald Trump’s tariffs are hurting Americans. Real economic growth is slowing, consumer prices rising, and real wages stagnating. Now the Republican Party is set to pay for it.

Since the founding, tariffs have proved toxic to the party that implemented them. When Mr. Trump asserted executive authority to impose the highest tariffs in 90 years, Republican congressmen, though skeptical, remained silent. If tariffs hurt Republicans in the November elections as much as they have hurt the economy, the midterms could end up igniting a Reagan revival on trade, shifting the trajectory of the party and the country.

If Republicans lose big in November, watch for them to move away from Trump and back toward Reagan.

No American president was more passionate about trade liberalization than Ronald Reagan. He understood that free and open markets allow “more productive use of our nation’s resources, more rapid innovation, and a higher standard of living,” as he said in 1985. “The freer the flow of world trade, the stronger the tides for human progress and peace among nations.”

Most Republicans in Congress favor free trade. They voted by large majorities for the North American Free Trade Agreement, almost unanimously for free trade agreements with Colombia, Panama and South

Korea, in large numbers for giving President Obama trade promotion authority, and overwhelmingly for Mr. Trump’s U.S.-Mexico-Canada Agreement.

The production disruptions and economic uncertainty that have come with Mr. Trump’s tariffs aren’t winning Americans over. Instead, the prevalence of the view that trade is “an opportunity for economic growth” has soared to 82%, twice the 2008 level, according to a March Gallup poll, which found that 74% of Republicans have a positive view of trade. Republican voters may tell pollsters they support Mr. Trump’s tariff policy, but that support is declining. A February Guardian-Harris Poll found 53% of Republicans say tariffs aren’t the right solution for improving the economy, and 64% said Mr. Trump’s tariffs caused higher prices.

Historically, presidents needed congressional approval for major policy changes. But while most Republicans in Congress supported the president’s decision to attack Iran to prevent it from producing nuclear weapons and to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, Mr. Trump’s use of executive authority to impose tariffs hasn’t been broadly supported by Republicans in Congress.

In this extraordinary circumstance, congressional Republicans, because of intimidation or party loyalty, failed to oppose Mr. Trump’s tariffs despite their own strong pro-trade records. The unwillingness of Republicans to serve as a check on Mr. Trump’s use of executive author-



SARA GRON CARNEVALE

ity under almost any circumstance has strengthened the argument that a Democratic majority in Congress is needed to check Mr. Trump’s power. If the November elections go badly for Republicans, we can expect a Republican backlash against Mr. Trump’s tariff policies.

As Republicans struggle to find their way in the aftermath, we will find out whether the north star of the party is still Reagan’s commitment to open markets and free enterprise. Trade, in turn, could become a major issue in the 2028 presidential election. That campaign begins on Wednesday, Nov. 4, and Republicans can win by embracing trade. The case for ending the Trump tariffs, lowering consumer prices and expanding U.S. world commerce becomes stronger with American domination of artificial intelligence.

Americans have reaped enormous gains from the fall of protectionist barriers. Per capita gross domestic product has risen 367% in real purchasing power since 1947. In a paper for the Peterson Institute for International Economics, Gary Hufbauer and Megan Hogan estimated that from 1950 through 2022 America’s engagement in the world economy helped hundreds of millions of people worldwide escape poverty and added 10% to U.S. GDP.

U.S. agriculture needs foreign markets, and almost all U.S. manufacturing needs foreign components. Without low-cost inputs from abroad, many manufacturers can’t export their products. Our AI industry relies on foreign chips and other imported components to remain cost-efficient and will need open

The 2028 Republican primaries could be an opportunity for this Reagan trade revival to reassert control of the GOP. The right candidate could run on “affordability,” committing to overturn the Trump tariffs and differentiating himself from Trump protectionism and industrial policy. He might win the nomination and then run in the general election, unencumbered by Mr. Trump’s record, on a platform of reviving the Reagan policies of free enterprise, open markets and limited government.

Mr. Gramm, a former chairman of the Senate Banking Committee, is a nonresident senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute. Mr. Boudreaux is a professor of economics at George Mason University and the Mercatus Center. Michael Solon contributed to this article.



EDITOR AT LARGE
By Gerard Baker

I’ve never been a victim of Trump derangement syndrome. Yes, I’ve found much that is repellent in the man’s character and rhetoric. But whatever his shortcomings, it seemed clear to me by 2016 that the country had, through years of bipartisan failure and the transformative effects of a malign cultural revolution, reached a point where radical change was needed. I was open to the idea that jarring disruption of the political order—perhaps necessarily delivered by a jarring figure—might be the only way to reassert the sovereignty of a disenfranchised people, restore the primacy of American interests against globalized progressivism, and reclaim our traditional civilizational values.

Even after Jan. 6, 2021, removed any doubt about the threat Donald Trump might pose to our constitutional norms and rules, I thought the institutions of the U.S. would be strong enough (as they were then) to constrain his worst instincts and intentions. And by November 2024, after four years of a Democratic

presidency had revived the prospect of a restoration of the progressive left’s crippling hegemony, the risks he posed seemed smaller than theirs.

But I am sorry to have to report that I have now self-diagnosed with a virulent form of TDS. Not one malady but three: as my condition has steadily progressed over the last year from Trump disappointment syndrome through Trump disillusionment syndrome to a full-blown case of Trump dismay syndrome.

Dismay seems to me the only natural response to the way the Republican Party has blown one of the great opportunities in political history in less than the time it takes to graduate from community college. When Mr. Trump won in 2024, becoming only the second Republican since 1988 to receive a plurality of the popular vote, he had a real chance to establish a new governing order, perhaps even to break the generation-long deadlock in partisanship.

He didn’t have to do anything especially risky. The opportunity was to use his victory—and a Republican Congress—to do things that would command significant majorities among Americans: take control of the border, alleviate the pressure on

working Americans from rising prices, roll back the woke authoritarian takeover of governing and cultural institutions, and keep the U.S. military out of costly, ineffective foreign interventions so we could focus on confronting with our broad network of allies the great strategic threats of the next 20 years.

After 2024, Republicans blew a great opportunity to set the country back onto the right track.

How’m I doing? as another controversial, larger than life New Yorker used to ask.

Thanks to a self-indulgent tariff fixation based on a profound misunderstanding of international economics, an insouciance about public finances that has widened the deficit, and a reckless military adventure that has choked off global energy supplies, inflation and interest rates are higher than they were in November 2024. Instead of a hands-off approach to the economy that would have generated noninflationary growth owing to the AI investment

boom, we now have gasoline prices 30% higher than they were two years ago, diesel 60% higher, and the average mortgage rate nearly a percentage point higher, adding more than \$2,000 a year to a typical home buyer’s interest cost.

The war that has done so much harm to Americans’ finances is doing far more harm to our military capacity and our strategic interests. The president has alienated everyone in the world who could be helpful to us (perhaps excepting Israel) and emboldened and even embraced every country in the world that threatens us: China, Russia, North Korea.

A signal achievement has been getting control of the border and removing some of the people who have no legal right to be here. But even with this proper and overwhelmingly popular policy, the administration has managed to harm the country and the GOP’s standing. The unnecessarily cruel and indiscriminate approach has caught many in its dragnet who shouldn’t be treated that way and is fundamentally un-American. The political effect has been to devastate support for the GOP among Hispanics, more than reversing the gains Mr. Trump had made with the fastest-growing

ethnic population in the country.

Further dismaying is the caesarism of the past two years: the grotesque self-enrichment, the self-satisfying prosecutorial pursuit of political enemies, the endless projects of self-grandiosity—the ballroom, the Kennedy Center and the Memorial Arch. Not to mention the buffoonish symbolic acts that substitute for actual thought and policy: the Gulf of America, Lake America, New America, the 51st state.

When presidencies fail, when political parties’ fortunes collapse, it’s often the result of circumstances and decisions beyond their control: an unforeseen global crisis, a recession caused by exogenous economic forces, the sentiment that it’s time for a change after a relatively successful period in office.

None of that applies to the looming Republican calamity. Instead, it will be the result of presidential hubris, vanity, recklessness and the wider party’s abdication of accountability. Instead of seizing an unrivaled opportunity to shift America off the path of progressive endangerment, the GOP risks handing it back to the Democrats and their own obsessions.

It’s enough to give anyone a case of Trump derangement syndrome.

Good News for the GOP: Some Politics Is Still Local

By Matthew Continetti

The GOP faces an ominous landscape this November. President Trump’s job-approval rating is underwater. Voters prefer Democrats to Republicans. Inflation remains above target. Interest rates and gasoline prices continue to rise.

The map favors Democrats. They need to net only three seats to win control of the House. A swing of four seats puts them in charge of the Senate. They expect a blue wave. “Donald Trump is absolutely on the ballot in November, and the American people are going to send a message loudly and clearly on Election Day that even Donald Trump cannot ignore,” House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries said recently.

Look at each state, however, and it’s a different picture. The list of

competitive Senate seats is growing—and not entirely in the Democrats’ favor. The complex scene is a reminder that local problems and individual candidates can matter more than the national environment. The ghost of Tip O’Neill haunts the 2026 election.

O’Neill, who served as House speaker from 1977 to 1987, famously quipped that all politics is local. His first election, to the Massachusetts House in 1936, taught him the value of community concerns, constituent service and trust. Such factors remain important despite globalized social media, political polarization and negative partisanship.

Consider New Hampshire. The Granite State hasn’t elected a Republican to the Senate since Kelly Ayotte won in 2010. Now Ms. Ayotte is coasting to re-election as governor,

and Republican former Sen. John Sununu is in a tight race against Rep. Chris Pappas for his old seat. Last week the Cook Political Report shifted the race from “lean Democrat” to “toss up.”

National conditions establish the boundaries of an election, but state issues and a candidate’s personality and ideology determine where a race falls within them. New Hampshire isn’t unique. Republicans are looking favorably at Michigan and Maine, where Democrats nominated candidates with extreme views. They might even have a shot in Minnesota.

Although the last GOP senator from Michigan was elected in 1994, former Rep. Mike Rogers is neck-and-neck with Abdul El-Sayed, the former public health official and pal of anti-American livestreamer Hasan Piker. The Real Clear Politics polling average has Mr. El-Sayed 2 points ahead of Mr. Rogers, well within the margin of error.

The Maine Senate contest was rocked by Democratic nominee Graham Platner’s sudden departure in July. His replacement, Troy Jackson, is Mr. Platner without the charm. Incumbent Susan Collins narrowly trails Mr. Jackson, but his lead is tiny and Ms. Collins has outperformed polling before.

The most unexpected polling comes from Minnesota, which hasn’t elected a GOP senator since 2002. Yet recent Senate polls show Republican Michele Tafoya, a former NFL sideline reporter, close behind Lt. Gov. Peggy Flanagan.

In a state that likes renegades—professional wrestler and actor Jesse

“The Body” Ventura served as governor from 1999 to 2003—Ms. Tafoya has taken advantage of an independent profile and expert communications skills to make it a shockingly competitive race. It helps that Ms. Flanagan, who touts endorsements from Sens. Bernie Sanders and Elizabeth Warren, is a far-left activist who presided over the welfare-fraud scandal roiling Minnesota politics.

National trends favor the Democrats, but there are also some opportunities for Republican upsets.

State-level politics cuts both ways, however. For every Michigan, there’s a Texas; for every Minnesota, there’s a Kansas. Texas Attorney General Ken Paxton has yet to heal GOP divisions over his Senate candidacy, and the personal and ethical controversies that trail him in office have opened space for state Rep. James Talarico’s progressive challenge.

Mr. Talarico leads by 3 points in the Real Clear Politics average in a state Mr. Trump carried by 14 in 2024. Texas last elected a Democratic senator in 1988. Mr. Paxton’s flaws are no secret. “You might not love his look,” Mr. Trump said this month. “You might not love his television interviews.” Nevertheless, Mr. Trump added, “he was our greatest attorney general, and he deserves to go to the United States Senate.” Texans may differ.

The sleeper race for Democrats is Kansas, which last elected a Democratic senator in 1932, the longest streak for either party in any state. Republican Sen. Roger Marshall didn’t expect his opponent, Adam Hamilton, a minister, to pose such a threat. While polling is scarce, Mr. Marshall’s lead is negligible. Visits from Vice President JD Vance and Sen. John Kennedy of Louisiana show Republican concern. States like Iowa, Nebraska and Kansas “ought to be fat-guy layups for us,” Mr. Kennedy said last week. Instead, they’re close due to Democratic recruitment tailored to the states and farmers reeling from Mr. Trump’s tariffs. Local considerations predominate.

Conventional wisdom holds that state results will converge with the national atmosphere by Election Day. New Hampshire may look competitive now, this argument goes, but it will soon revert to its bluish hue and send a Democrat to the Senate. A massive swing toward the Democrats will pull down Republicans in reliably conservative states.

Another possibility is that open seats, weak candidates and local issues, from fraud to soybeans and streamers, deliver an unanticipated outcome. Something similar happened in 2022, when eccentric candidates prevented GOP gains despite President Biden’s unpopularity and record-high inflation. Democrats are counting on the nation to repudiate Mr. Trump. But it may be one of their own, Tip O’Neill, who has the last laugh.

Mr. Continetti is a columnist for WSJ Opinion’s Free Expression.

SPORTS

 I'm sorry, but a college-football game that finishes 84-0 makes me a little embarrassed—for the winner.

That's how I felt about Oregon's 84-0 dismissal of Portland State this past weekend. Congratulations on punting an in-state school into the fiery sun, you ruthless Ducks.

A suspenseful evening in Eugene it wasn't. Oregon emptied its bench and played four quarterbacks and couldn't stop scoring. Up 63-0 after three quarters, the Ducks added 21 more points to finally put the game away for good.

"We have a better team," Oregon coach Dan Lanning said when it was over. "No disrespect for Portland State, but that's the way it should look when you execute the way we're supposed to execute."

(OK: Saying "no disrespect for Portland State" after you thrashed them by 84 is fairly hilarious?)

Is something wrong with me? Do I not get it? Should I see these mega programs feasting on easy prey, passing the ball in the fourth quarter like Oregon did, and think that's the way big time sports should be?

Have I gotten soft? I'll admit to becoming more blowout-sensitive since I've become a youth sports parent. Blowouts are epidemic across youth sports. I've been a parent to the blowout-er and the blowout-ee, and they're equally icky experiences that make for a weird car ride home.

Some coaches do their best to take their foot off the gas, tell their teams to try new things, move the ball around and stop wearing out the scoreboard.

Some coaches do not.

I know it's a rabbit hole. What is an acceptable level of winning? Would it have been OK if Oregon won 47-0? 60-0? At what point does it turn from permissible to yuck?

Also: How do you suggest a football team roll over? It isn't like soccer where you can just boot the ball around for 45 minutes and lull your overmatched opponent to sleep. Should your running backs fall to the turf as if tackled by invisible linemen?

I'm not sure! (Though at the very least: stop passing!)

I believe no reasonable person looks at 84-0 and says: *What an impressive performance.*

They say: *Who thought this was a good idea?*

Of course, no industry on Earth is less reasonable than college football. This haywire sport has a rich tradition of pay-for-play cupcakes—small time programs awarded a check for three hours of missing tackles against a large-

JASON GAY

Is It Rude to Win a Game 84-0?

Oregon romps over an in-state rival, triggering a debate about the value of record padding



Oregon's Evan Stewart, above, scores a touchdown during the Ducks' 84-0 win over Portland State. Right: Players walk off after the game.

conference behemoth.

Everyone knows the deal. The justification for putting these schools in harm's way is that the small programs need the dough for their athletic departments.

That money helps keep a program rolling. Quit whining about physical and emotional distress!

In exchange for its cash, the monster team gets to inflate its win total, rotate through its roster, experiment with plays, and build confidence.

Considered a title threat, Oregon was coming off a humbling loss to Oklahoma State, which won a single game last year.

The On3 college football reporter Brett McMurphy reported Portland State was paid a not-insignificant \$590,000 for sacrificing itself in Eugene.

"Was it worth it?" McMurphy asked.

There's got to be a better way. Since 1994 Oregon has played PSU seven times. The cumulative score

over the seven contests is 450-49.

To steal a line from the manager in "Bull Durham," how'd they ever score 49?

(If you want to be really confused, Portland State won a game 91-0 in 2023 and beat Delaware State 105-0 in 1980, with former NFL Cardinals QB Neil Lomax throwing eight TD passes.)

This stuff isn't new or unusual. Pretty much every power does the record-pad. Already this season No. 2 Georgia edged Western Kentucky 70-20. Ohio State eked past Kent State 59-3. My not-so-powerful Wisconsin Badgers, who began the season getting run over by Notre Dame at Lambeau Field, have rebounded with back-to-back wins over Western Illinois and Eastern Michigan.

And yes, sometimes these games do go the other way, like a few weeks ago, when Western Michigan beat Michigan, only to have time traveling referees give the Wolverines a chance to take it back.

I don't think it's worth the squeeze. College football is supposed to be in its clarity era. There's a 12-team playoff now,



with designs to expand it even further. A widened shot to win the championship should incentivize schools to stop the padding and play tougher opponents. Cutting down the overall number of games wouldn't hurt, either.

Instead college football is doing what it does best, which is to make zero sense. This is a sport that still has its playoffs entangled with a zombie rotation of bowl

games. This is a sport asking for financial reform for players as it continues to pay gargantuan divorce penalties for coaches. This is a sport that wants me to loathe Lane Kiffin as it keeps serving me more Lane Kiffin.

I know: it's college football, and it's nuts. Soft as I may be, I want to believe that reasonable people can reach a reasonable conclusion. 84-0 is a bit much.

LYDIA ELVAP (2)

Harbaugh Thought He'd Built a Winner. He Can't Stop Losing.

By Andrew Beaton

OVER THE COURSE of Jim Harbaugh's two decades as a head coach, he has been America's most famous khaki-pants evangelist, moonlit as a Supreme Court scholar, and declared steak a daily vitamin. But wherever he has gone, his quirky methods have always produced the same result.

Jim Harbaugh teams win football games.

That's what makes the start to the Los Angeles Chargers' season so bewildering. With back-to-back losses against teams expected to finish the year near the bottom of the standings, Harbaugh's squad is on the brink after only two weeks.

The latest disappointment came on Sunday when the Chargers lost to the Las Vegas Raiders 26-14, right on the heels of another 26-14 defeat to the Arizona Cardinals the week before. For a team that notched 11 wins in each of Harbaugh's first two seasons in charge, the cold snap is especially jarring.

But Harbaugh's reimagination of the team's offense has fizzled, and it has left a coach who won a national championship at Michigan and boasts one of the highest winning percentages in modern NFL history in unfamiliar territory. This season marks the first time in Harbaugh's entire head coaching career that one of his teams has started a campaign 0-2.

Things will only become more difficult from here. The Chargers' first two games were against clubs that won a combined six games last year. Their next six are against the Bills, Seahawks, Broncos, Chiefs, Rams and Texans—a group made up of teams that reached the playoffs in 2025, plus



Jim Harbaugh and the Los Angeles Chargers fell to 0-2 after a Week 2 loss to the Las Vegas Raiders.

another that happens to be quarterbacked by Patrick Mahomes.

"We'll go back to work," Harbaugh said. "That's all I know how to do."

Beginning with his first coaching job at the University of San Diego in 2004, Harbaugh built a reputation as a milk-guzzling turnaround specialist. After back-to-back 11-win seasons with the Toreros, he took over at Stanford where he inherited a program that won a single game the prior season. In his final year, the Cardinal went 12-1.

When Harbaugh took over the San Francisco 49ers, they hadn't

produced a winning season for eight straight years before he led them to a 13-3 record in his debut campaign. Under Harbaugh, however, they reached three conference championship games in three years and a Super Bowl. After that, he returned to his alma mater and delivered Michigan's first national championship since 1997.

It was more of the same when Harbaugh bolted to the Chargers—where he had finished his own career as a quarterback. His most urgent task was to mold passer Justin Herbert into a winner after prior regimes seemed to squander

his talents.

The turnaround came quickly. Back-to-back playoff appearances suggested there was more to come—especially considering the rash of injuries the team overcame last season. So the Chargers, whose only fruitless trip to the Super Bowl came more than three decades ago, kicked off this season with soaring anticipation.

Not only was Harbaugh hitting his stride in Los Angeles, he had also brought in former Miami Dolphins coach Mike McDaniel, regarded as one of the game's savviest tacticians, as his new offensive coordinator.

"I'm not smart enough to know how smart those two are," Harbaugh said of McDaniel and Herbert over the offseason. "The more those two are together...bodes great for the Los Angeles Chargers."

But after a briefly promising start against Arizona—a 77-yard touchdown drive to begin the season—things turned ugly. Problems with the offensive line, which was supposed to be a strength, became apparent when Herbert was sacked on a fourth-down attempt from the Cardinals' 3-yard-line.

Herbert has now been sacked three times in both games. Against the Raiders, he was pressured on nearly half of his dropbacks.

Making matters worse, the offense has looked out of sync through McDaniel's first two games. In one instance on Sunday, facing third and short, the center snapped the ball when a receiver was in motion in the backfield and hit him.

"We can't expect to win games when we're playing like that," Herbert said.

Six fumbles on Sunday didn't help either. Combine that with Herbert's three interceptions and only two touchdowns and the 0-2 record begins to make sense.

Harbaugh, who has never posted a losing season as an NFL coach, doesn't have much time to figure it all out. Next up the Chargers and their shaky defense will face Josh Allen and the Bills, who have scored 77 points through their first two games.

But Harbaugh—who loves to parrot the phrase "Who's got it better than us? Nobody!"—is known for his optimistic streak.

"No one in the locker room is deterred," Harbaugh said. "We're going to have to fight our way out of this."

LUKE HALES/GETTY IMAGES

S&P 7764.70 ▲ 1.49% S&PFIN ▲ 0.30% S&PIT ▲ 2.46% DJ TRANS ▼ 0.54% WSJ\$IDX ▲ 0.09% 2-YR. TREAS. yield 4.751% NIKKEI (Midday) 65018.95 ▲ 1.38% See more at [WSJ.com/Markets](#)

Silver Lake Takes On Icahn, Allies

Private-equity firm alleges activist and hedge funds colluded to fight Endeavor deal

By Lauren Thomas and David Benoit

Private-equity firm **Silver Lake** is asking a judge to declare that activist investor Carl Icahn and a group of hedge funds illegally colluded in attempts to fight the \$13 billion acquisition of talent agency Endeavor.

There are billions of dollars

at stake and now a legal debate that could upend the entire merger arbitrage industry.

Silver Lake, Endeavor, Icahn and shareholders have been locked in legal battles since the deal closed early last year, with the shareholders arguing the buyout underpriced by billions of dollars the owner of agencies WME and IMG headed by Hollywood super-agent Ari Emanuel.

At the center of the dispute has been Endeavor's majority stake in **TKO Group Holdings**, the owner of UFC (Ultimate Fighting Championship) and WWE (World Wrestling Enter-

tainment). Shares of TKO rallied between the time Silver Lake announced the Endeavor take-private deal in April 2024 and its closing in March 2025.

That is when investors started buying into Endeavor.

Silver Lake already controlled the votes in Endeavor before the deal, allowing it to skip a shareholder vote and stick by the price it

said was a 57% premium. Icahn and others have since sued, saying the deal and management undercut public shareholders for their own gains.

On Monday, the company launched a new broadside that would have the investors' shares thrown out of appraisal proceedings, which ask the Delaware Court of Chancery to declare the

fair value of the company.

In essence, Endeavor and Silver Lake argue the investors are interlopers who shouldn't have a voice in the appraisal fight because they bought after the deal was agreed.

A ruling on that could be a landmark decision on the rights of these arbitrageurs, an industry that buys up shares in announced deals. These funds often pocket profits when the deals close from small technical price changes and sometimes fight for higher payouts.

Appraisals are a risky move

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\$13B

Value of the acquisition of talent agency Endeavor, which closed in 2025

Tariffs Backfire Particularly Hard on Harley

By John Keilman

When foreign governments want revenge for U.S. tariffs, America's most celebrated motorcycle manufacturer usually makes the hit list.

The European Union hit **Harley-Davidson** with 25% retaliatory tariffs in 2018. In 2025, the EU threatened another round, while Canada imposed its own levy. Then this month, Canada struck again with a 50% import duty on the company's products as part of a wide-ranging response to heightened U.S. tariffs.

Harley has previously eaten retaliatory tariffs to keep retail prices stable, a practice that has cost it more than \$170 million over the past eight years. The company declined to outline its plans for Canada, which accounted for 4% of its \$4.5 billion in revenue last year, but said it was committed to supporting the country's dealers and riders.

This year's inventory has already arrived, but dealers are still worried about the possibility of future sticker shock. "It would be very surprising if the Canadian consumer would be willing to pay those prices," said Mandie Ciotucha, co-owner of Thunder Bay Harley-Davidson in Ontario.

For decades, Harley-Davidson and tariffs have gone together like leather and chrome.

When the company hovered near bankruptcy in the 1980s, it was boosted by levies the Reagan administration placed on imported bikes. In 2018, stiff motorcycle tariffs imposed throughout Southeast Asia prompted Harley to open a factory in Thailand.

Scott Lincicome, vice president at the Cato Institute, a free-market think tank, said it is no mystery why Harley



A Harley-Davidson dealership in Kentucky. Other countries have hit the U.S. motorcycle brand hard with retaliatory tariffs.

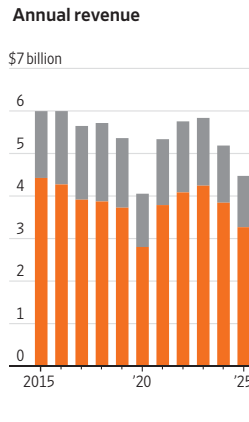
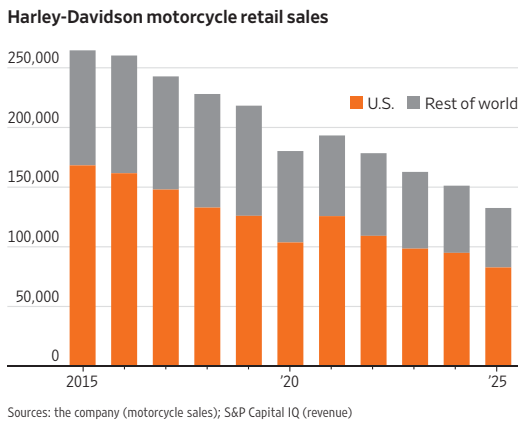
keeps finding itself in the tariff crosshairs. The Milwaukee company's All American brand identity and swing state location make it a natural target for retaliation, he said.

"In terms of getting off the list, I think they're stuck," Lincicome said. "The economics are a distant second to the politics."

President Trump's aggressive approach to trade has caused foreign leaders to single out the company as never before.

"We will now impose tariffs on motorcycles, Harley-Davidson, on bluejeans, Levi's, on

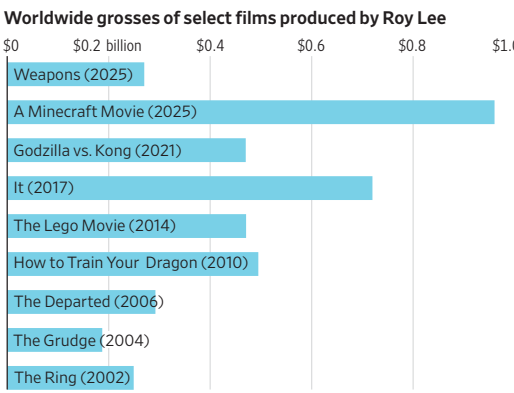
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Movie Producer's Hit Radar Is Dead-On



Roy Lee at his Hollywood office, with a collection of Lego cars he and his son built in the background.



By Ben Fritz

Among moviegoers, Roy Lee is far from a brand name. In Hollywood, he's known as the man behind the brands.

For a quarter-century, Lee has been the producer who secures material before studios know they want it. When Japanese horror was virtually unknown in the 2000s, he produced hit remakes of "The Ring" and "The Grudge." In the 2010s, he saw the potential for plastic bricks to become "The Lego Movie" and for adapting Stephen King's "It" with a focus on the book's children.

Now, the 57-year-old's obsession is videogames, which have become red hot in Hollywood after decades of disrespect.

Lee produced last year's \$960 million grossing "A Minecraft Movie" and has success this weekend with "Resident Evil," based on the Japanese horror game about a virus that causes people to transform into monsters.

The well-reviewed reboot, directed by "Weapons" filmmaker Zach Cregger, opened to an estimated \$108.3 million worldwide, according to distributor Sony Pictures, including \$60 million in the U.S. and Canada.

Lee has around 20 movies and television shows based on games in development or production, including the fantasy epic "God of War," action franchise "Battlefield," and Japanese horror classic "Silent Hill."

"When people have [intellectual property] now, they take it to him, because there's no one better at turning it around into something new," said Ben Ross, chief executive of entertainment company Image Nation and a longtime friend and business partner of Lee's.

Film producing has become a difficult career over the past 20 years, as studios rely more on franchises they own and less on projects outsiders bring them. Lee, who has 104 producing credits according to IMDb, has thrived by identifying new sources for franchises and latching onto them early.

"Roy is really good about knowing what the market is looking for, how to sell it and how to protect it," Cregger said.

While he was producing Cregger's breakout horror hit "Barbarian," Lee asked him if there were any videogames he was interested in adapting. When the director mentioned "Resident Evil," Lee promptly

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INSIDE



TECHNOLOGY

The next frontier for autonomous vehicles is burying your garbage. **B5**



HEARD ON THE STREET

In nuclear-power bet, one company holds a strong hand. **B11**

The Magnificent Seven Tech Stocks Roar Back

By David Uberti

The Magnificent Seven is back. You can thank **Meta**.

Investors piled into shares of Facebook's parent company on Monday after its new artificial-intelligence agent jumped to the top of Apple's App Store, boosting shares 11% and extending a tech rally that left the recent freakout over AI safety in the dust.

Meta's surge marked its largest one-day percentage

gain in more than a year and added \$192 billion to the company's market value. It also pushed an exchange-traded fund linked to the Magnificent Seven group of tech giants to its first record since May.

Wall Street has at times seen Meta as a potential weak spot in the AI trade, with analysts struggling to square how the company's massive capital investments would yield returns. But the buzzy launch of

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The layoffs are the third round of job cuts in less than a year as the nation's largest used-car dealer battles slowing sales.

CarMax Eliminates More Jobs

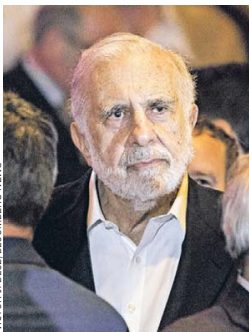
Continued from page B1
company announced a quarterly sales record.

At CarMax, Barr's strategy

revolves around improving CarMax's digital capabilities, growing its in-house financing arm and reducing its costs to recondition used cars for sale.
Friday's move represents the first layoff action under Barr, but it was CarMax's third round of job cuts in less than a year. The company cut 350 jobs in October 2025 and another 230 in January 2026, the spokeswoman said.

Silver Lake Takes On Carl Icahn

Continued from page B1
because a judge will determine the ultimate price, which could give the investors more or less than the agreed deal. More than 70% of the public shares of Endeavor have filed for appraisal rights in the biggest such case in Delaware history.
Silver Lake, which continues to defend the price of \$27.50 a share, says most of the shares involved were purchased long after the deal and were only bought to wage an appraisal fight, which it argues isn't the intent of the law.
"The appraisal statute never was intended to allow opportunistic funds, like Defendants here, to acquire shares after a merger was announced and pursue windfall profits," the filing said.
The firm also alleges the actions of Icahn and two of his allies, Troluce Capital Advisors and Pentwater Capital, which all hold significant stakes, amounts to illegal collusion. The firm alleged the three investors failed to file proper disclosure forms, allowing them to acquire even more shares, and partner together in a legal strategy. Troluce's co-founder, Jonathan Christodoro, was a top deputy at Icahn's firm until leaving in 2017.
Icahn's firm isn't part of the appraisal case but is leading a separate suit arguing the management failed its duty to shareholders.
"These arbitrageurs are not



Activist investor Icahn opposed the Endeavor deal.

aggravied minority shareholders," Endeavor said in a statement. "Endeavor today seeks to end this illegal attempt to manufacture litigation returns detached from market reality. We are confident that Delaware will not reward abuse of its legal system by lawbreakers."
Representatives of Icahn, Pentwater and Troluce didn't immediately comment on Monday.
Silver Lake and Icahn already have a tortured history. In 2013, Silver Lake teamed up with Michael Dell to take his computer company private for \$25 billion. Icahn jumped into that deal with other big investors and waged one of the most-heated deal fights in history, arguing the price was undervalued. After the buyers bumped the price, the shareholders approved the deal over Icahn's objections.
Three years later, a Delaware judge in an appraisal case like the one at issue in Endeavor sided with several investors and ruled Silver Lake and Dell underpaid. But that decision was later overturned by the Delaware Supreme Court.

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Ethan Allen Seeks a New Chief



CEO Farooq Kathwari, 82, is the company's top shareholder.

By COLIN KELLAHER

Ethan Allen Interiors has launched a search for a new chief executive to succeed Farooq Kathwari at the helm of the furniture maker.
Ethan Allen on Monday said it has hired an executive search firm that is identifying and evaluating internal and external candidates, adding that its board has committed to announcing a new CEO by June 30, 2027, the date on which Kathwari's current contract is scheduled to end.
The move comes shortly after investor Doug Bergeron, who owns a stake of more than 5% in Ethan Allen and has launched a proxy battle for control of the Danbury, Conn., company's board, said he had

launched his own search for a potential new CEO.
Bergeron cited the Ethan Allen board's "apparent unwillingness to address the need for a CEO succession," and referenced Kathwari's statement in an August television interview that the board has never raised the issue.
Kathwari, 82 years old, is Ethan Allen's largest shareholder and has been chairman and CEO since 1988.
Ethan Allen, which usually holds its annual shareholder meeting in early November, hasn't yet set a date for this year's gathering. The company said Kathwari would remain as a nonexecutive member of the board after June 30, and that he would step down from that role at the 2027 annual meeting.

Harley Takes Tariff Hit

Continued from page B1
bourbon," then-European Commission President Jean-Claude Juncker said in 2018 after Trump threatened steel and aluminum tariffs. "We can also do stupid."

In response, the company shifted some of its Europe-bound production to the Thailand factory, which eventually brought the rate down to 6%.
Harley's trade headaches continued when Trump returned to office with an even more combative agenda. Last year, after Trump imposed duties on steel and aluminum imports, the EU said it would respond with a 50% tariff on a range of goods—including the motorcycles made by Harley—though the measure never went into effect.
Canada also became a battleground. When the U.S. imposed a 25% tariff on Canadian imports last year, the country struck back with the same rate on Harleys and other products. The duty remained in place for six months and cost Harley \$8 million.
This summer, tensions flared again. The Trump administration took exception to Canadian tariffs on American cars and trucks and placed a 50% duty on large motorcycles, along with many other products.
Canada doesn't have a sizable motorcycle manufacturing industry, but two models made by Quebec-based BRP were affected: the Can-Am Spyder and Can-Am Canyon, both three-wheelers. The com-

pany declined to say how many of the bikes it exports to the U.S.
On Sept. 8, Canada imposed a 50% tariff on large motorcycles and many other goods. The same day, the U.S. announced an outright ban on the importation of large bikes from Canada starting Sept. 29.
Raymond James analyst Joe Altobello said Harley might be better equipped than BRP to withstand an extended show-down, given that Canada represents a relatively small portion of Harley's overall business. "It's not a good thing, but it's not existential," he said.
Canada's motorcycle lobby has appealed for a truce, noting that dealerships employ thousands of people.

"We just want everyone to get back to the table and start talking about a deal that will work for the U.S., Canada and Mexico, too," said Landon French, chief executive of Moto Canada. "What's been built over the decades has worked very well for all three countries."
Other U.S. manufacturers, including Indian Motorcycle and Buell, have been collateral damage in the dispute. Indian, which lists 25 Canadian dealerships on its website, didn't respond to requests for comment. Buell CEO Bill Melvin said his Michigan-based company sells only a few bikes in Canada.
Producing Canadian bikes in Thailand could be an option for Harley if the conflict drags

into next year. Canada's Department of Finance said goods that don't originate in the U.S. aren't subject to the tariff.
Some Canadian dealerships are presenting the trade battle as a buying opportunity, noting that their current inventory is tariff-free. But some Harley loyalists say the national mood isn't conducive to big-ticket spending.
"In Canada, people are struggling from paycheck to paycheck now," said Garrett Broenner, 60 years old, who has hit pause on his plan to upgrade his 2003 Harley V-Rod. "If you have to pay another \$15,000 on a bike, you're just not going to do it, no matter how much you might like the brand."



A convoy of 800 Harley-Davidson motorcycles and other brands in Prague this month.

Producer Knows How To Level Up

Continued from page B1
secured the rights, attached Cregger to write and direct, and generated interest from multiple studios before selling it to Sony. The film cost about \$75 million to make.
Lee grew up in Maryland, where his mother took him to horror movies like "The Exorcist" to try scaring him into religion.
After practicing law for about six months and finding the work boring, he moved to Los Angeles in 1996 to find a

job in the music industry.
He ended up at a film-production company, where he made a name for himself by building an online spreadsheet to track projects being developed at every studio.
Determined to build his own producing career with data, Lee concluded that only about 5% of film ideas sold to studios actually got made. So he set a goal of selling 25 projects in 25 months, figuring at least one would become a movie. For material, he focused on an untapped market: remakes of Asian movies.
"Early on, I realized original ideas were a dead end, because the amount that get made compared to the amount that get developed are so low," he said with a casual bluntness that has become his trademark.

Most Asian films weren't available in English, so Lee bought VHS tapes and added subtitles. Sometimes he asked a friend's mother who spoke the language to give him an idea of what the characters were saying. "We would make up a lot of the story," he said.
Lee's strategy bore numerous hits. But wary of becoming the "Asian remake guy," he started searching for other material. One of his favorite tactics was searching cinema message boards for terms like "would make a great movie" or "somebody should remake that."
Lee has seven employees at his company Vertigo Entertainment, which he runs out of a central Los Angeles building. His office has little decoration save for elaborate Legos he and his son like to

build from kits.
His share of the profits from "Weapons," "Minecraft" and "Lego" have made Lee wealthy, causing colleagues and competitors to speculate that he could try to build Vertigo into a mini-studio. Lee said he's not interested in the responsibility: "I try to live stress free."
What motivates him instead is finding what's hot before everyone else, whether it's film ideas or food. "He's always taking me to a restaurant that's been open for three days," Lee's wife, Eva Lee, said while waiting for the "Resident Evil" premiere to begin in Los Angeles Tuesday.
During the pandemic, Lee looked for movies he could make with small crews. Together with Ross and producer Steven Schneider he launched a company called Spooky Pictures that focuses on low-budget horror.
Lee's record and connections make it easy for him to find up to a few million dollars for the company's films. "If you have something cool and he loves it, it's going to get made," said Greg Gilreath, a horror producer who has worked with Spooky.
Once he sets a movie up with a studio or financier, Lee is largely hands-off. The few notes he gives, according to people who have worked with him, are about logical holes that bother his analytical mind.
The producer is already planning the end of his tenure as Hollywood's videogame guy and thinking about his next chapter, which he expects will involve filmmakers using artificial intelligence. "I just want to be there early," he said.



Roy Lee produced last year's \$960 million grossing 'A Minecraft Movie.'

BUSINESS NEWS

Qatar, JPMorgan Team Up To Invest \$20 Billion

By Connor Hart

The Qatar Investment Authority is teaming up with JPMorgan Chase, planning to invest \$20 billion across both public and private markets. The strategic partnership will see \$15 billion invested across public equities, with JPMorgan Asset Management overseeing a customized portfolio aligned with Qatar Investment Authority’s long-term investment objectives, the organizations said Monday. The two will additionally invest \$5 million across private markets, providing financing to middle-market companies in the U.S., primarily across the industrials, services, healthcare and technology sectors.

The partnership will bring together Qatar Investment Authority’s institutional perspective and JPMorgan’s investment capabilities, positioning both organizations to capitalize on global investment opportunities and deliver long-term value, they said.

The deal underscores the Qatar Investment Authority’s deepening ties with Wall Street.

The fund, established in 2005, has historically invested in real estate, with stakes in New York City’s Empire State Building, as well as The Shard, the Canary Wharf district and high-end department store Harrods in London.

More recently, though, Qatar Investment Authority has shifted into “new economy sectors,” having made a major investment in Anthropic and signed a \$25 billion tech partnership with Goldman Sachs.

Nvidia Helps Robotruck Effort

The chip company will support Swedish autonomous-truck maker’s production

By Joshua Kirby

Nvidia is teaming up with Einride as the Swedish autonomous-truck maker looks to boost its production to meet rising demand for driverless vehicles.

The chip giant will provide the underlying platform and artificial-intelligence tools to Einride’s autonomous-driving systems, Einride said Monday. The company said it currently operates hundreds of electric trucks for major shipping clients across the U.S., Europe and the Middle East, and expects demand to increase to between 1,500 and 2,000 vehicles by 2028. Some 80% of that demand is suitable for automation in the medium term, Einride said.

That will add to the driver-



Einride operates hundreds of electric trucks for clients. It went public on the Nasdaq in June.

less trucks it already has in operation, the company said.

Autonomous trucking—which uses self-driving vehicles that require minimal hu-

man intervention—represents an opportunity to improve safety and efficiency in global freight, said Rishi Dhall, vice president of automotive at

Nvidia.

Einride, founded in Stockholm in 2016, began trading on the Nasdaq this summer after completing a merger

with blank-check firm Legato Merger Corp. III in a transaction that valued Einride’s equity at \$1.35 billion before proceeds from the deal.

The company develops electric self-driving freight vehicles and software platforms for companies from PepsiCo and to European brewers Carlsberg and Heineken.

“We have the customers, the operational experience and the technology,” said Henrik Green, Einride’s chief technology officer. “Building the next generation of the Einride Driver on the Nvidia Hyperion platform, will enable us to scale autonomous deployment across a freight network that’s already serving customers today.”

The partnership with Nvidia marks the latest step in the push toward greater use of autonomous or driverless trucks, following the spread across U.S. cities of self-driving passenger taxis like Alphabet’s Waymo vehicles and Tesla’s robotaxis.

Stablecoin Issuer Bastion Gets Banking License

By Jasmine Li

Stablecoin issuer Bastion received conditional approval for a national trust bank charter on Friday, opening the door to the traditional financial system.

The license from the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency enables Bastion, pitched as a stablecoin partner for large enterprises and financial institutions, to work closer with many of those institutions.

“If you are a bank, you cannot rely on simple fintech unless they are federally regulated,” Chief Executive Nassim Eddequiouaq said in an inter-

view. “We can now be that regulated partner for all of the largest financial institutions in and outside of the U.S., who want to launch products here.”

Bastion issues white-label stablecoins for other businesses, and manages the custody of holding reserves and customer wallets behind the scenes.

Stablecoins, or digital tokens pegged to the U.S. dollar or other currencies, are gaining mainstream attention.

Proponents have praised them for offering faster transactions with lower fees compared with wire transfers.

“There’s going to be this expectation that banks can actu-

ally transact 24/7 for a fraction of a cent,” Eddequiouaq said.

Founded in 2023 by two former a16z crypto executives, Bastion’s backers include Coinbase Ventures, Sony Innovation Fund and Samsung Next. It raised \$14.6 million in its latest funding round last year.

Bastion was named the stablecoin partner of Japan’s Sony Bank last year. Sony uses Bastion for stablecoin custody, payments infrastructure and issuance, and has plans to introduce stablecoin payments into its gaming and entertainment ecosystem.

As part of the Trump ad-



Bastion CEO Nassim Eddequiouaq, with chief operations officer Caroline Friedman and chief technology officer Jameel Al-Aziz.

ministration’s crypto-friendly agenda, the OCC under Comptroller Jonathan Gould has approved the launch of several crypto-focused trust banks this year.

A consortium of more than a dozen financial institutions including Bank of America,

Wells Fargo and Santander, has been moving forward on a stablecoin venture, The Wall Street Journal reported last month. Visa, BlackRock, Google and DoorDash are among the nonbank companies that have moved to enter the stablecoin market.



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TECHNOLOGY

Filing Details OpenAI Book Use

Documents show employees weighed cost of buying titles to train ChatGPT

By MELISSA KORN AND ALEXANDRA BRUELL

Authors including John Grisham, David Baldacci, Jodi Picoult and Jonathan Franzen sued OpenAI and Microsoft three years ago for copyright infringement.

A court filing unsealed on Thursday details internal messages and testimony laying out how OpenAI employees—including executives—talked about the company’s use of pirated books to train an early ChatGPT model. The filing was made in support of the authors’ request that a federal judge rule in their favor ahead of a trial.

The tech companies argued their actions constituted “fair use,” which allows for some copyright material to be used without explicit permission, and that their use of the material was transformative.

Starting in 2019, OpenAI began using books from file-sharing site Library Genesis—LibGen for short—to help train its large language model. The site, which provides free access to books and scholarly articles, faced accusations of pirating copyright material.



McGrew, then vice president of research, wrote in a June 2022 Slack channel, “now is the right time to excise Libgen from our systems and storage,” given how much OpenAI was in the news.

Removing LibGen would prevent researchers from being able to reproduce earlier GPT-3 or GPT-3.5 results, he said, adding, “but would be very valuable for legal reasons.” OpenAI removed the data sets from its library.

The company priced out the potential cost of buying large quantities of books on multiple occasions. Greg Brockman, OpenAI president, wrote to OpenAI co-founder Ilya Sutskever in late 2022 that they could purchase lots of books, “but they are expensive per token so we haven’t prioritized.” (Tokens are the basic measurement unit for AI use.)

Varun Shetty, OpenAI vice president of media partnerships, testified in the lawsuit that he wasn’t aware of the company purchasing books at scale and scanning them for training purposes, according to the filing.

Safe Superintelligence, Sutskever’s current AI lab, didn’t respond to a request for comment.

Wall Street Journal parent News Corp has a content deal with OpenAI.

Tech companies have argued that their using books to train AI models constituted ‘fair use.’

OpenAI’s then-general counsel David Lansky was among those who recommended free book downloads from LibGen as a possible data source, according to the filing. Tom Brown, then a top GPT-3 engineer, and Ben Mann, another member of the technical staff, described LibGen as “sketchy AF,” according to messages and testimony cited in the filing. A federal court ordered LibGen to shut down in 2015 and academic publisher Elsevier received a \$15 million judgment against the site in 2017.

OpenAI staffers discussed removing references to LibGen from papers that could later be public, according to the filing. In one instance, Dario Amodei, then a senior researcher at OpenAI who is now chief executive of Anthropic, asked in Slack whether it was “sketchy to call our corpuses ‘Books1’ and ‘Books2’ and not say what they are, particularly when in fact they are Libgen (which is a slightly sketchy source).” Separately, Mann wrote that a description of the data sets was “deliberately vague

since it’s libgen.” A number of those involved in OpenAI’s early model training now work at Anthropic. OpenAI said employees who used LibGen to create the earlier ChatGPT models are no longer at the company, and the LibGen data set wasn’t used to power the current ChatGPT models. An Anthropic spokeswoman declined to comment. Convergent Research, where Lansky now works, didn’t respond to a request for comment. OpenAI eventually deleted the pirated data sets. Bob

Novo’s Plan to Find Next Hit Drug Draws Skeptics

By ALEX JANIN AND DOMINIC CHOPPING

Novo Nordisk Chief Executive Mike Doustdar, who took over in 2025 promising to find a sustainable growth path, said the company will launch several new blockbusters over the next few years, but investors aren’t yet convinced the Danish drugmaker is close to finding its next Ozempic.

Novo’s shares fell nearly 8% on Monday during the company’s investor day in London.

Doustdar said Novo’s revenue was expected to grow roughly in line with other large drugmakers through the end of this decade. Investors were looking for guidance into 2032, when Ozempic and Wegovy, which made up two-thirds of sales last year, are expected to lose U.S. patent protection.

“When you compare it with Glaxo or with Astra or with Novartis, they gave guidance through the big patent expiration cycle,” said Markus Manns, a portfolio manager at Union Investment, which holds shares in both Novo and its rival Eli Lilly. “But we are still up in the air about how we should feel.”

Novo’s management outlined a plan to develop new drugs in their core areas of obesity and diabetes as well as in newer areas like sickle-cell disease and a heart condition known as ATTR-cardiomyopathy. In addition to at least five new “multi-blockbusters,” the company is aiming to have at least five new obesity and diabetes drugs and a similar number of drugs in other therapeutic areas in late-stage trials by 2030.

At the event, Doustdar referred to the patent cliff as the “elephant in the room” and said the company doesn’t underestimate the price pressure that comes with it. But, he said, lower prices are driving higher



Drugmaker plans at least five new ‘multi-blockbusters.’

demand in some markets. Semaglutide, the main ingredient in Ozempic and Wegovy, is already off patent in Canada, India, Brazil and Turkey, and is losing exclusivity in China this year. “It’s not that one loses it to the generics fully,” Doustdar said. “Yes, the price might go down by 50%, but there is much higher volume.” That didn’t give investors much confidence. Novo’s shares are down roughly 22% year-to-date and 73% from its all-time high in June 2024.

With Ozempic and Wegovy, Novo is competing with Eli Lilly to dominate the multibillion-dollar weight-loss market. Lilly has established dominance in the space with its Mounjaro and Zepbound products, though Novo’s newer Wegovy pill has had a strong start.

Seamus Fernandez, an analyst at Guggenheim Securities, said in a note to investors that the pipeline showed limited differentiation and few genuinely new assets, adding that with the exception of weight-loss pills, Novo’s portfolio looks to be several years behind Lilly.

The company’s plan also targets the delivery of over 150 billion Danish kroner—equiva-

lent to roughly \$23 billion—in sales from its pipeline drugs in 2035. The company’s 2025 total sales were 309.06 billion kroner.

The target was “conservative and a bit disappointing,” relative to existing expectations, Fernandez wrote.

Evan Seigerman, BMO Capital Markets analyst, said the share price decrease was likely attributable to the fact that today’s projections weren’t a surprise. “The burden of proof remains,” he wrote.

Novo has ceded its lead in the injectable weight-loss market to its U.S. rival, but its recently launched weight-loss pills are proving popular and have given Novo an early lead in the new market. Doustdar has previously said that the early signs give him hope that the Wegovy pill could help the company regain some of its lost market share.

Novo expects generic drugs to hit sales this year and has said that a deal struck with the Trump administration to lower prices in the U.S. will hurt results. Its most recent guidance points to an adjusted sales decline of up to 6% at constant exchange rates this year.

Google Fined \$463 Million By Ireland Data Watchdog

By EDITH HANCOCK

Ireland’s data protection watchdog fined Alphabet’s Google 403 million euros (\$462.9 million), saying the company breached European Union privacy rules over its handling of users’ location data.

Ireland’s Data Protection Commission said Monday that Google infringed the EU’s General Data Protection Regulation following a 2020 investigation into the company.

“As a result of Google’s failures in this regard, individuals

could have been unaware that their location was being used to, for example, influence them with ads or to infer their interests, and could lose control over their personal data,” Graham Doyle, the DPC’s deputy commissioner, said in a statement.

The regulator said that the rulebook requires companies to process personal data in a lawful, fair and transparent manner, and that its inquiry focused on location data the search giant processed in three of its features.

A Google spokesperson said

the case focuses on historical policies.

“From 2019 onwards, we’ve significantly evolved our practices and launched robust tools that make managing location data simple,” they said.

The inquiry came after complaints from European consumer groups including BEUC, whose director general Agustín Reyna said on Monday that the decision holds Google accountable over the way it obtained consent to use location data, but that consumers’ rights need to be upheld faster.

Investors Buy Book Publisher Podium

By ALEXANDRA BRUELL

Private-equity firms Shamrock Capital and Flexpoint Ford acquired Podium Entertainment, a book publisher focused on independent authors and audiobooks. They bought the publisher for north of \$400 million, according to people familiar with the matter.

Podium is known for publishing and introducing additional formats for romantasy and science fiction titles from writers who originally self-published their work, including “Quicksilver” author Callie Hart and Shirtaloon, who is behind the series “He Who Fights With Monsters.”

Shamrock and Flexpoint Ford bought Podium from private-equity firm Presidio, which had acquired the publisher in 2019. As part of the deal, music rights company GoldState Music also has made a minority investment in Podium.

David Kaefner, previously head of audiobooks and music at Spotify, will join a new Podium board, and Podium’s existing management team will remain in place.

Podium started in 2013, as authors were increasingly publishing their own works through Amazon.com’s Kindle Direct service. The company initially licensed the audio rights to self-published ebooks, and has since expanded into other aspects of publishing, including helping independent authors distribute ebooks on Amazon and printed books in bricks-and-mortar shops. Presidio invested in technology to identify trending books ripe for acquisition, and Podium now has a catalog of 15,000 titles.

Shamrock’s media holdings include investments in content catalogs with songs by Beyoncé, Coldplay and Rihanna, as well as films and videogames. It previously owned Taylor Swift’s master recordings but sold the catalog back to the pop star in 2025.

Flexpoint Ford has an investment in GoldState Music, which acquires and manages copyrights for songs by artists including Sheryl Crow and Florida Georgia Line, as well as Create Music Group, which provides services to independent artists.

Bayer Inks Deal to Sell Treatment For Cancer

By ADRIÀ CALATAYUD

Bayer agreed to sell rights to its cancer drug Stivarga to Gruenenthal Group for up to €375 million, or \$430.7 million, the acquirer said Monday.

The drug, due to lose patent protection in the European Union in 2029 and in the U.S. a year later, is approved to treat advanced forms of metastatic colorectal cancer, hepatocellular carcinoma and gastrointestinal stromal tumors, German drugmaker Gruenenthal said.

For Bayer, the deal comes after the German agricultural-and-pharmaceutical group completed the sale of a minority stake in its long-acting reversible contraceptives business to Apollo for around €3 billion earlier this month.

Gruenenthal said the acquisition marks the latest step in its strategy to acquire established drugs that serve continuing medical needs. The company said it expects the acquisition to lift its 2027 earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization by up to around €100 million.

The deal is expected to close by the end of 2026 or early 2027, subject to customary closing conditions, Gruenenthal said.

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COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE

NOTICE OF SALE OF REAL PROPERTY - MANHATTAN

UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT SOUTHERN DISTRICT OF NEW YORK.

WELLS FARGO BANK, NATIONAL ASSOCIATION, AS TRUSTEE, FOR THE BENEFIT OF THE HOLDERS OF CD 2018-CD7, MORTGAGE TRUST COMMERCIAL MORTGAGE PASS-THROUGH CERTIFICATES, SERIES 2018-CD7, acting by and through its special servicer, Rialto Capital Advisors, LLC, as Special Servicer under the Pooling and Servicing Agreement dated as of August 1, 2018, Plaintiff against PRINCE 26, LLC, 29 PRINCE STREET ASSOCIATES LLC, et al Defendants(s). Pursuant to that certain ORDER & JUDGMENT entered herein and dated August 5, 2026 ("Judgment"), I, the undersigned Referee will sell at public auction, at the front steps of 26 Prince Street, New York, New York 10012 on October 21st, 2026, at 3:00 p.m., prevailing Eastern Time, the following Premises (to be sold as a single lot), as that term is defined below, and more particularly described and bounded as follows: **PARCEL A:** ALL THAT CERTAIN plot, piece or parcel of land, situate, lying and being in the Borough of Manhattan, County of New York, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the northerly side of Prince Street, distant 27 feet 11 1/4 inches (deed), 27.94 feet (actual), easterly from the corner formed by the intersection of the northerly side of Prince Street with the easterly side of Mott Street; RUNNING THENCE northerly parallel or nearly so with the easterly side of Mott Street and part of the way through party walls, 83 feet 11 inches (deed), 82.54 feet (actual); THENCE easterly 26 feet 9 and 6/10 inches (deed), 24.40 feet (actual), to a point on a line distant 86 feet and 1 inch (deed), 86.08 feet (actual), northerly from the northerly side of Prince Street which line is parallel or nearly so with the easterly side of Mott Street and intersects the northerly side of Prince Street at a point 54 feet 7 1/4 inches (deed), 55.61 feet (actual), when measured in an easterly direction from the corner formed by the intersection of the northerly side of Prince Street with the easterly side of Mott Street; THENCE southerly and along said line drawn parallel or nearly so with Mott Street and part of the way through a party wall, 86 feet 1 inch (deed), 86.08 feet (actual), to the northerly side of Prince Street; THENCE westerly along the northerly side of Prince Street, 26 feet 9 and 6/10 inches (deed) 27.67 feet (actual), to the point or place of BEGINNING. Block: 509 Lot: 52

Said premises to be sold is known as 29 PRINCE STREET, NEW YORK, NEW YORK 10012 ("Parcel A"). **PARCEL B:** ALL THAT CERTAIN plot, piece or parcel of land, situate, lying and being in the Borough of Manhattan, County of New York, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the southerly side of Prince Street, distant 47 feet 6 inches easterly from the corner formed by the intersection of the southerly side of Prince Street and the easterly side of Mott Street; RUNNING THENCE southerly and parallel with the easterly side of Mott Street a distance of 114 feet 7 inches to a point; THENCE easterly along the line forming on its northerly side an angle of 88 degrees 04 minutes 30 seconds with the last mentioned course a distance of 23 feet 1 inch to a point; THENCE northerly along a line forming on its westerly side an angle of 91 degrees 55 minutes 30 seconds with the last mentioned course a distance of 109 feet to a point on the southerly side of Prince Street which point is distant 24 feet easterly from the point or place of beginning; THENCE westerly along the southerly side of Prince Street a distance of 24 feet (record), 23 feet 7 inches (survey) to the point or place of BEGINNING. Block: 493 Lot: 15. Said premises to be sold is known as 26 PRINCE STREET, NEW YORK, NEW YORK 10012 ("Parcel C"). (With Parcel A, Parcel B, and Parcel C, collectively, being the "Premises").

Pursuant to Judgment, Premises will be sold a single lot and is not to be divided or sold separately. The approximate amount of the Judgment for Premises, collectively, is \$46,677,820.90 plus interest & costs.

Premises will be sold subject to provisions of filed Judgment and forthcoming terms of sale. Civil Action File No. 22-cv-05586 (PAE) (OTW)

STEPHEN F. ELLMAN, ESQ., Referee

MATTHEW MANNION, from Mannion Auctions, LLC as Auctioneer

Holland & Knight, LLP

Attorney(s) for Plaintiff

787 Seventh Avenue, 31st Floor,

New York, New York 10019

NOTICE OF SALE

NOTICE OF DISPOSITION OF COLLATERAL PUBLIC AUCTION - UCC FORECLOSURE SALE OFFICES OF TROUTMAN PEPPER LODGE LLP 600 PEACHTREE STREET NE, SUITE 3000, ATLANTA, GA 30308

PLEASE TAKE NOTICE THAT pursuant to (i) O.C.G.A. § 11-9-610 and (ii) that certain Pledge Agreement, dated as of June 25, 2024 (as amended, restated, supplemented, or otherwise modified from time to time) (the "Pledge Agreement"), by and between HMM JV LLC, Hawaii limited liability company ("Pledgor") and BP&C INVESTMENT HOLDINGS, LP, a Delaware limited partnership (as assignee of Bay Point Capital Partners, LP), a Delaware limited partnership (as such capacity, "Lender"), the Lender will offer for sale (the "Sale") at public auction the following collateral identified below (the "Specified Collateral"):

All the rights, title and interest of Pledgor in and to, collectively, (a) the Pledged Interests; (b) all other Pledged Property, whether now or hereafter delivered to the Pledgor or any Lender in connection with the Pledge Agreement; (c) all rights relating to the foregoing, including all voting rights; and (d) all proceeds of any of the foregoing, in each case, whether now existing or hereafter arising.

"Pledged Interests" shall mean 100% of the equity interests of HMM PARCEL 1, LLC, a Hawaii limited liability company.

"Pledged Property" shall mean all Pledged Interests and all certificates evidencing the Pledged Interests, and all dividends, distributions, securities, cash, instruments, interest payments and other property and proceeds from time to time received, receivable or otherwise distributed in respect of or in exchange for any or all of the Pledged Interests.

PLEASE TAKE FURTHER NOTICE THAT the Specified Collateral will be offered for sale at a public auction ("Auction") as a single lot. All interested, qualified prospective purchasers are invited to attend at the Auction.

PLEASE TAKE FURTHER NOTICE THAT the Auction will be held on October 5, 2026, at the offices of Troutman Pepper Lodge LLP, 600 Peachtree Street NE, Suite 3000, Atlanta, GA 30308, beginning at 10:00 a.m., prevailing Eastern time; provided, however, that Lender may postpone, pause, cancel or adjourn the Auction at any time without further notice or publication other than by announcement at or prior to the Auction. The Sale may also be attended virtually. If you wish to receive the electronic link to appear at the Auction virtually, or have any other questions regarding appearance at the Auction or Sale, please contact Matthew R. Brooks, Esq., Troutman Pepper Lodge LLP, 875 Third Avenue, New York, New York, 10022, Tel: 212-704-6047; Email: matthew.brooks@troutman.com.

PLEASE TAKE FURTHER NOTICE THAT THE SPECIFIED COLLATERAL WILL BE SOLD PURSUANT TO A SECURED PARTY BILL OF SALE ON AN "AS IS, WHERE IS" BASIS AND WITHOUT RECURSE, REPRESENTATION, OR WARRANTY OF ANY KIND OR NATURE WHATSOEVER, INCLUDING, WITHOUT LIMITATION, ANY REPRESENTATION OR WARRANTY OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR A PARTICULAR PURPOSE. SPECIFICALLY, BUT WITHOUT LIMITATION OF THE FOREGOING, THERE WILL BE NO WARRANTY RELATING TO TITLE, POSSESSION, QUIET ENJOYMENT, OR THE LIKE MADE OR GIVEN IN THIS DISPOSITION.

PLEASE TAKE FURTHER NOTICE THAT the Specified Collateral may be sold pursuant to a secured party bill of sale, at such price and on such other commercially reasonable terms as the Lender may determine. The minimum bidding increments will be \$10,000 or such other amount as the Lender may announce at the Auction. In order for a prospective bidder (other than the Lender or its designee) to be a "qualified bidder" and eligible to bid at an Auction, each such prospective bidder must demonstrate to the Lender's satisfaction, in its sole and absolute discretion, prior to bidding at the Auction, such prospective buyer's financial ability to tender immediate payment in cash for the Specified Collateral. Lender reserves the right to accept or reject any bid and shall not be obligated to conduct any sale pursuant to this notice. Lender, through itself or any designated affiliate, reserves its right to credit bid or otherwise bid at the Auction. Lender reserves all of its rights against Pledgor and any other obligor or guarantor for any and all deficiencies with respect to the obligations remaining after the Sale. Further, Lender reserves all rights, claims, and causes of action with respect to any other collateral securing obligations of Pledgor or any other obligor, to repay indebtedness owing to Lender, including, without limitation, Lender's rights to pursue a foreclosure of any other collateral granted to Lender by Pledgor or any other obligor.

PLEASE TAKE FURTHER NOTICE THAT the Pledgor and the other obligors are entitled to an accounting of the unpaid indebtedness secured by the Specified Collateral. The Pledgor and the other obligors may request such accounting by contacting Mr. Brooks at the phone number or email address set forth herein.

PLEASE TAKE FURTHER NOTICE THAT the Pledgor, if any, of the Specified Collateral will be required to represent that it is an "accredited investor" under Section 2.3 of National Instrument 45-106 Prospectus Exemptions and will acquire the Specified Collateral subject to certain transfer restrictions.

PLEASE TAKE FURTHER NOTICE THAT the Specified Collateral, other than any Specified Collateral acquired by the Lender via credit bid, will be sold only as a block to a single purchaser and will not be split up or broken down. The purchaser, if any, of the Specified Collateral will be required to represent that it is taking the Specified Collateral with investment intent only, that the Specified Collateral is being acquired for the purchaser's own account and not with a view to the sale or redistribution thereof and will not be sold unless pursuant to an effective registration statement under the Securities Act of 1933, as amended, and applicable state securities laws or under a valid exemption from such registration. Certificates for the Pledged Interests, if the Pledged Interests are certificated, will bear an appropriate legend to the effect that the Pledged Interests may not be sold unless pursuant to an effective registration statement under the Securities Act of 1933, as amended, and applicable state securities laws or under a valid exemption from such registration.

PLEASE TAKE FURTHER NOTICE THAT any inquiry regarding the terms of sale, the Pledgor, the other obligors or guarantors, the Pledge Agreement, and/or the Specified Collateral may be directed to counsel for Lender: Matthew R. Brooks, Esq., Troutman Pepper Lodge LLP, 875 Third Avenue, New York, New York, 10022, Tel: 212-704-6047; Email: matthew.brooks@troutman.com.

Autonomous Vehicles Take Out the Trash

Caterpillar’s newest landfill machinery doesn’t need a human in the cab

By Bob Tita

Inside a cool, dimly lighted trailer where the quiet is broken mostly by the crackle of radio traffic, Abrin Vasquez drives a 40-ton bulldozer hundreds of yards away.

Vasquez is remotely piloting a **Caterpillar** dozer spreading trash across the Marana Regional Landfill near Tucson, Ariz. He used to be out in the heat running the machine from the cab, a potentially dangerous job in the landfill’s rough, trash-filled terrain. Now, he is safely away from that in the control trailer, doing the same job from a virtual cab.

“It was challenging at first, but it’s just a matter of getting used to it,” said Vasquez, 25. He spent two years operating the dozer in the landfill, where treading uneven ground can be physically punishing work. “I don’t feel the bumps now,” he said.

What Vasquez and others are doing at the Marana landfill is likely a preview of the future of operating machinery in dusty and hazardous conditions. For Houston-based **WM**, the landfill’s owner, the site has become a proving ground for remote-controlled and autonomous machines aimed at improving safety and reducing operating costs.

Besides the bulldozer, the company plans to deploy an autonomous Caterpillar compactor at the landfill in the coming months. The driverless tractor with spiked steel wheels will run over a programmed course, flattening newly spread trash to create space to bury more garbage.

“The technology frees us from those repetitive tasks, so the employees can focus on higher-value work and the



elimination of potential risk,” said Matt Wagner, WM’s senior director for organization and automation.

Remote-controlled and automated equipment could help ease a shortage of equipment operators at construction sites, landfills and other job sites struggling to fill positions. The government predicts about 42,500 new operators will be needed annually to backfill those leaving the job, and to meet the projected 4% growth in that workforce forecast by 2035.

The potential shortfall provides momentum for Caterpillar’s automation push, as the company faces the challenge of selling equipment to companies that don’t have enough operators.

“If you move an operator to a remote station, they can easily switch from machine to machine,” said Jaime Mineart, Caterpillar’s chief technology officer. “You can run a dozer. You can run an excavator. You



Caterpillar and WM are running a pilot program at Arizona’s Marana Regional Landfill, above. Left, remote operator Abrin Vasquez.

can run a compactor. You have one operator in a more attractive environment doing more productive work.”

Arun Kumar, a co-leader of the industrial products group for consulting firm AlixPartners, said automation is rapidly maturing for equipment at construction and mining sites.

“The transformation comes

when it’s not just one or two machines, but the entire site operates just like one machine,” he said. “More automation makes the work simpler, but also more satisfying and less stressful for people to do.”

Caterpillar’s giant yellow dump trucks have been running autonomously on closed-loop courses in mines and

quarries for several years. The Texas-based company said last week that Virginia quarry operator Luck Stone will expand its use of autonomous haul trucks to two additional quarries following an 18-month autonomous hauling pilot at its Bull Run, Va., operation.

WM and Caterpillar declined to reveal the cost of the Marana pilot program. But WM, formerly known as Waste Management, has already seen operational improvements from automating significant parts of its residential trash collection business.

The company replaced the human work of emptying trash bins with safer, more efficient automated loaders and more fuel-efficient trucks on monitored routes. WM said annual driver turnover is now

below 20%, down from 30% earlier in the decade. Operating costs as a percentage of WM’s revenue have fallen by 2.5 points since 2021.

The company said landfills, where operations are typically predictable and monotonous, are ideal for automated equipment. The 590-acre Marana site opened in 2013. The landfill’s expected life is more than 150 years.

On an average day, nearly 1,800 tons of trash get dumped at Marana.

A bulldozer is crucial to its operations. Dozens of tractor-trailer rigs loaded with trash rumble along Marana’s winding dirt roads daily to the landfill’s face. The trailers are driven onto a machine known as a tipper and detached from their trucks. The hydraulic tipper lifts the front end of an open-roof trailer, spilling more than 20 tons of trash out of the tailgate at once. The dozer then moves in to spread that pile of trash on the ground.

For the remote operation control of the dozer, Caterpillar and WM built a Wi-Fi network at the landfill with portable towers that connect the dozer to the command trailer with the operator. The dozer’s cameras relay 360-degree video back to a large screen in front of the operator’s seat.

The person in that seat uses the same joysticks and pedals found in the dozer’s cab. The camera also transmits the sound of the engine and the tracks, providing clues to the operator when the dozer is straining to move a heavy load or slogging through rough terrain.

Leo Gonzales, Marana’s operations manager, said guiding the machine from screens instead of looking through the cab’s windshield was an adjustment at first, but he appreciates not getting jostled in the actual cab.

“Your body’s saved from getting a beating, and you’re out of the elements,” Gonzales, 43, said.

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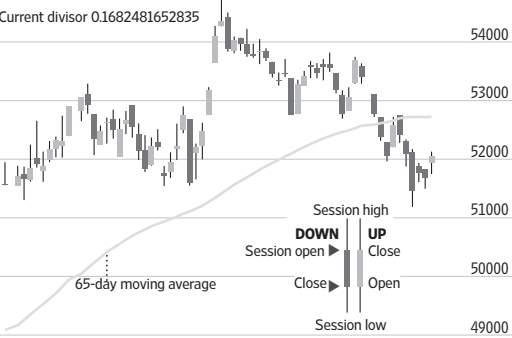
MARKETS DIGEST

EQUITIES

Dow Jones Industrial Average

52048.83 ▲366.19, or 0.71%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.

Last	Year ago
Trailing P/E ratio	21.19 25.40
P/E estimate *	19.63 22.14
Dividend yield	1.52 1.59
All-time high	54349.12, 08/05/26



Bars measure the point change from session's open

Weekly P/E data based on as-reported earnings from Biringi Associates Inc.; *Based on Nasdaq-100 Index

Major U.S. Stock-Market Indexes

	High	Low	Close	Net chg	% chg	High	52-Week Low	% chg	YTD	% chg 3-yr. ann.
Dow Jones										
Industrial Average	52128.58	51747.68	52048.83	366.19	0.71	54349.12	45166.64	12.2	8.3	15.2
Transportation Avg	20175.84	19831.09	19970.90	-108.20	-0.54	23933.14	15067.87	27.9	15.1	9.9
Utility Average	1045.27	1035.17	1035.93	-7.28	-0.70	1190.23	1035.93	-5.4	-3.0	5.8
Total Stock Market	76705.33	75901.07	76564.92	1082.68	1.43	77313.23	62750.36	15.5	13.4	21.1
Barron's 400	1600.13	1592.65	1595.68	3.22	0.20	1685.46	1318.70	13.9	12.9	18.7
Nasdaq Stock Market										
Nasdaq Composite	27183.93	26707.42	27122.09	599.55	2.26	27122.09	20794.64	19.0	16.7	27.1
Nasdaq-100	30557.33	29933.22	30482.35	838.18	2.83	30660.60	22953.38	23.1	20.7	27.5
S&P										
500 Index	7779.22	7691.19	7764.70	114.20	1.49	7798.99	6343.72	16.0	13.4	21.5
MidCap 400	3675.17	3653.60	3664.45	13.72	0.38	3926.98	3109.89	11.7	10.9	13.6
SmallCap 600	1702.98	1692.02	1695.26	4.37	0.26	1828.54	1364.94	16.2	15.5	13.8

Other Indexes										
Russell 2000	2883.46	2870.91	2875.36	14.96	0.52	3068.42	2305.11	16.7	15.9	17.3
NYSE Composite	24144.64	23998.76	24086.66	87.91	0.37	24821.68	20912.89	11.8	9.5	15.6
Value Line	659.92	654.85	658.50	3.650	0.56	702.60	590.50	3.7	4.8	6.7
NYSE Arca Biotech	9437.66	9292.61	9389.31	57.57	0.62	9539.76	6043.49	50.0	31.3	23.1
NYSE Arca Pharma	1256.28	1234.52	1249.52	4.17	0.34	1315.38	925.18	31.0	11.0	11.6
KBW Bank	180.56	179.09	180.17	1.39	0.78	193.91	143.23	17.4	9.7	31.3
PHLX [®] Gold/Silver	395.53	386.69	389.71	-4.79	-1.21	470.37	265.03	33.9	13.9	50.2
PHLX [®] Oil Service	98.38	96.29	97.58	-0.74	-0.76	109.24	60.27	53.0	33.1	1.7
PHLX [®] Semiconductor	12491.61	12059.30	12433.17	511.48	4.29	14634.72	6284.67	96.4	75.5	55.0
Cboe Volatility	15.13	14.60	14.87	0.06	0.41	31.05	13.47	-7.6	-0.5	-5.4

^Nasdaq PHLX Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

Percentage Gainers...

Company	Symbol	Close	Net chg	% chg	High	Low	% chg
Greenland Mines	GRML	9.42	6.57	230.53	36.99	2.82	-65.9
Twin Vee PowerCats	VEEE	17.24	8.66	100.93	127.65	4.16	-80.7
21Shares 2x Long Sui ETF	TXKS	38.51	13.45	53.69	307.00	17.75	...
SVRN	SVRN	29.50	9.18	45.18	47.56	3.12	17.1
Critical Metals	CRML	9.33	2.60	38.63	32.15	5.12	29.9
Leverage 2X Lg ARM Dly	ARMG	26.75	6.86	34.49	65.95	4.64	137.5
Grayscale Avalanche Stkg	GAVA	26.99	6.82	33.85	28.19	14.50	...
Priority Technology	PRTH	7.80	1.97	33.79	7.91	4.44	6.8
GRAIL	GRAL	107.97	27.20	33.68	118.84	39.30	159.2
Bitwise Avalanche ETF	BAVA	30.04	7.55	33.56	30.69	16.01	...
VanEck Avalanche ETF	VAVX	23.10	5.80	33.50	25.00	12.54	...
Treasure Global	TGL	2.96	0.71	31.26	58.00	2.02	-87.6
New Era Energy & Digital	NUAI	7.65	1.79	30.55	9.45	0.47	1305.2
Hub Cyber Security	HUBC	6.00	1.40	30.43	877500.00	4.57	-100.0
21Shares Sui Staking ETF	TSUI	20.83	4.57	28.14	26.58	13.00	...

Volume Movers Ranked by change from 65-day average*

Company	Symbol	Volume (000)	% chg from 65-day avg	Latest Session Close	% chg	52-Week High	Low
SP Funds DJ GI Sukuk	SPSK	12,401	5439	17.67	0.17	18.71	17.62
Priority Technology	PRTH	18,686	3601	7.80	33.79	7.91	4.44
Innov Intl Dev Pwr Apr	IAPR	166	2416	33.92	0.58	34.32	29.70
Cue Biopharma	CUE	3,438	1932	28.27	-23.70	45.50	4.97
Columbia LC Growth	REGS	477	1678	11.69	2.16	11.83	9.33
GraniteSh HIPS US HI Incm	HIPS	906	1410	11.35	-0.0003	12.30	11.28
Colombier Acquisition III	CLBR	780	1368	10.22	0.49	10.40	10.01
Invsc BS 2035 Cp Bd	BSCZ	2,232	1346	19.70	0.34	21.16	19.63
Pharming Group ADR	PHAR	217	1322	10.81	2.46	21.34	9.62
Fairlead Tactical Sector	TACK	245	1278	32.05	0.20	33.03	28.97

* Common stocks priced at \$2 a share or more with an average volume over 65 trading days of at least 5,000 shares *Has traded fewer than 65 days

International Stock Indexes

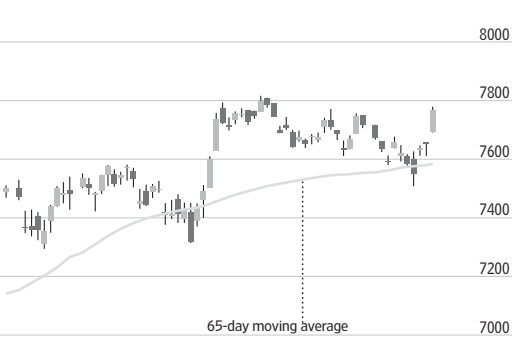
Region/Country	Index	Close	Net chg	Latest % chg	YTD % chg
World					
	MSCI ACWI	1152.41	14.86	1.31	13.6
	MSCI ACWI ex-USA	479.73	4.50	0.95	13.9
	MSCI World	4977.90	63.92	1.30	12.4
	MSCI Emerging Markets	1733.86	23.01	1.34	23.5
Americas					
	MSCI AC Americas	2938.83	42.500	1.47	13.3
Canada	S&P/TSX Comp	36009.40	202.75	0.57	13.5
Latin Amer.	MSCI EM Latin America	3122.15	41.42	1.34	15.2
Brazil	Bovespa	186595.60	1366.43	0.74	15.8
Mexico	S&P/BMV IPC	63536.96	161.03	0.25	-1.2
EMEA					
	STOXX Europe 600	641.93	6.48	1.02	8.4
Eurozone	Euro STOXX	666.84	7.49	1.14	8.9
Belgium	Bel-20	5763.48	50.32	0.88	13.5
Denmark	OMX Copenhagen 20	1547.20	-37.66	-2.38	-3.8
France	CAC 40	8138.94	73.92	0.92	-0.1
Germany	DAX	25575.01	270.95	1.07	4.4
Israel	Tel Aviv	4289.98	...	Closed	16.5
Italy	FTSE MIB	52371.54	826.29	1.60	18.1
Netherlands	AEX	1102.35	7.26	0.66	15.9
Norway	Oslo Bors All-Share	2519.04	-19.67	-0.77	29.8
South Africa	FTSE/JSE All-Share	113111.47	108.99	0.10	-2.3
Spain	IBEX 35	19724.40	210.59	1.08	14.0
Sweden	OMX Stockholm	1138.57	13.73	1.22	8.9
Switzerland	Swiss Market	13956.58	169.86	1.23	5.2
Turkey	BIST 100	13337.69	53.27	0.40	18.4
U.K.	FTSE 100	10739.01	79.88	0.75	8.1
U.K.	FTSE 250	24491.37	285.95	1.18	9.0
Asia-Pacific					
	MSCI AC Asia Pacific	278.48	2.47	0.89	22.3
Australia	S&P/ASX 200	8731.90	0.73	0.01	0.2
China	Shanghai Composite	3949.91	38.04	0.97	-0.5
Hong Kong	Hang Seng	25042.71	291.93	1.18	-2.3
India	BSE Sensex	74858.99	564.03	0.76	-12.2
Indonesia	JSX Composite	6384.73	-56.43	-0.88	-26.2
Japan	NIKKEI 225	65018.95	...	Closed	29.2
Singapore	Straits Times	5675.23	19.12	0.34	22.1
South Korea	KOSPI	7007.72	113.49	1.65	66.3
Taiwan	TAIEX	47718.84	538.09	1.14	64.8
Thailand	SET	1598.03	13.88	0.88	26.9

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

S&P 500 Index

7764.70 ▲114.20, or 1.49%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.

Last	Year ago
Trailing P/E ratio *	23.25 25.30
P/E estimate *	20.10 21.85
Dividend yield *	1.07 1.17
All-time high	7798.99, 08/13/26



65-day moving average

Late Trading

Most-active and biggest movers among NYSE, NYSE Arca, NYSE Amer. and Nasdaq issues from 4 p.m. to 6 p.m. ET as reported by electronic trading services, securities dealers and regional exchanges. Minimum share price of \$2 and minimum after-hours volume of 50,000 shares.

Most-active issues in late trading

Company	Symbol	Volume (000)	Last	Net chg	After Hours % chg	High	Low
PG&E	PCG	23,101.7	12.97	0.03	0.20	13.04	12.94
Cisco Systems	CSCO	7,022.0	111.40	-0.06	-0.05	111.50	111.01
Warner Bros. Discovery A	WB	6,921.5	30.81	0.01	0.03	30.82	30.20
Walmart	WMT	5,672.1	107.43	-0.02	-0.01	107.55	102.19
iShares Core S&P 500 ETF	IVV	5,509.2	776.74	-0.12	-0.02	777.00	775.78
NVIDIA	NVDA	5,440.2	227.00	-0.38	-0.17	229.12	223.18
State Street SPDR S&P 500	SPY	5,257.4	773.36	-0.14	-0.02	773.67	724.23
Intel	INTC	4,603.6	122.08	0.30	0.25	122.18	121.38

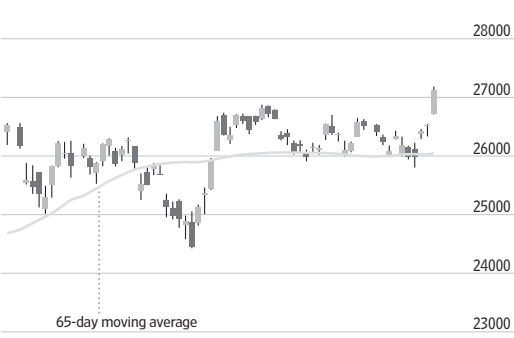
Percentage gainers...

Vicor	VICR	70.0	253.05	29.15	13.02	254.72	223.90
Animated	APMD	151.2	27.19	0.97	3.70	27.22	26.22
GameStop Cl A	GME	1,053.9	23.50	0.74	3.24	23.50	22.75
Agree Realty	ADC	88.8	69.50	1.88	2.78	69.50	67.55
Centuri Holdings	CTRI	578.6	20.90	0.56	2.75	21.79	20.05
...And losers							
Endava ADR	DAVA	50.9	2.40	-0.39	-13.98	2.81	2.31
Quest Diagnostics	DGX	65.1	227.00	-17.88	-7.30	247.11	220.00
SS SPDR Ptf EM	SPEM	486.6	51.78	-1.62	-3.04	53.40	51.78
Pershing Square	PS	238.2	46.80	-1.43	-2.96	48.23	46.59
Darling Ingredients	DAR	83.9	61.80	-1.46	-2.31	63.90	61.80

Nasdaq Composite Index

27122.09 ▲599.55, or 2.26%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.

Last	Year ago
Trailing P/E ratio **	34.15 32.65
P/E estimate **	24.25 26.63
Dividend yield **	0.57 0.64
All-time high	27122.09, 09/21/26



65-day moving average

Trading Diary

Volume, Advancers, Decliners	NYSE	NYSE Amer.
Total volume*	1,234,075,454	18,271,871
Adv. volume*	727,321,160	9,174,434
Decl. volume*	494,304,726	8,895,547
Issues traded	2,845	296
Advances	1,526	145
Declines	1,226	145
Unchanged	93	6
New highs	27	2
New lows	155	17
Closing Arms ¹	0.82	1.28
Block trades*	3,761	215
	Needles	NYSE Amer.

Futures Contracts

Metal & Petroleum Futures							
	Contract					Open interest	
	Open	High	hi lo	Low	Settle	Chg	
Copper-High (CMX)-25,000 lbs.; \$ per lb.							
Sept	6.6605	6.7430		6.6595	6.6865	0.0715	1,118
Dec	6.7220	6.8410		6.7015	6.7625	0.0710	171,878
Gold (CMX)-100 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.							
Sept	4366.70	4368.10		4366.70	4345.80	-40.10	503
Oct	4381.80	4387.80		4326.60	4350.20	-40.50	42,409
Nov	4395.60	4405.20		4348.10	4367.40	-40.90	1,096
Dec	4413.00	4422.10		4360.30	4383.90	-41.00	314,578
Jan'27	4419.80	4419.80		4384.20	4403.90	-41.10	568
Feb	4449.50	4458.40		4397.60	4420.70	-41.40	33,508
Palladium (NYM)-50 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.							
Sept	1295.50	1295.50		1291.50	1302.90	-3.30	2
Dec	1316.50	1342.00		1308.00	1316.40	-3.10	15,693
Platinum (NYM)-50 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.							
Sept	1795.00	1800.00		1795.00	1798.50	-5.00	36
Jan'27	1828.00	1858.00		1816.30	1824.10	-5.20	37,173
Silver (CMX)-5,000 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.							
Sept	66.440	66.665		66.440	65.825	-0.731	327
Dec	66.685	67.555		66.200	66.415	-0.734	84,963
Crude Oil, Light Sweet (NYM)-1,000 bbls.; \$ per bbl.							
Oct	101.00	101.08		94.22	95.78	-4.52	60,372
Nov	96.75	97.22		91.19	92.37	-3.71	313,311
Dec	92.62	92.97		88.18	89.16	-2.89	197,615
Jan'27	89.43	89.50		85.57	86.47	-2.38	104,115
June	78.83	79.00 ▲		77.49	78.28	-0.41	123,769
Dec	73.48	73.73		72.97	73.67	0.16	175,110
NY Harbor ULSD (NYM)-42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.							
Oct	5.1142	5.1866		4.8895	4.8895	~.1683	35,537
Nov	4.9248	4.9615		4.6253	4.7075	~.1369	68,329
Gasoline-NY RBOB (NYM)-42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.							
Oct	3.5400	3.5584 ▲		3.4150	3.4699	~.0577	43,598
Nov	3.2665	3.2812 ▲		3.1553	3.1954	~.0601	112,205
Natural Gas (NYM)-10,000 MMBtu.; \$ per MMBtu.							
Oct	2.902	2.906		2.819	2.836	~.076	103,810
Nov	3.038	3.042		2.976	2.993	~.050	399,106
Dec	3.380	3.390 ▼		3.342	3.366	~.029	197,483
Jan'27	3.736	3.751 ▼		3.702	3.739	~.002	182,668
March	2.803	2.805 ▼		2.772	2.782	~.030	193,813
April	2.701	2.705 ▼		2.674	2.680	~.030	128,316

Agriculture Futures						
Corn (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Dec	527.50	543.50		526.25	543.00	15.50 945,382
March'27	541.25	557.00		540.00	556.75	15.25 397,141
Oats (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Dec	402.25	418.00		382.00	416.25	9.75 3,020
March'27	411.50	426.00		400.50	428.25	9.50 264
Soybeans (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Nov	1304.00	1328.50		1303.50	1328.00	24.50 469,276
Jan'27	1320.25	1344.25		1320.25	1344.00	24.00 208,937
Soybean Meal (CBT)-100 tons; \$ per ton.						
Oct	356.70	367.10		356.00	366.60	12.00 53,076

Dividend Changes

Company	Symbol	Yld %	Amount New/Old	Payable/Record
Increased				
Permian Basin Royalty Tr	PBT	0.9	0.016/0.0187	M Oct15/Sept30
Phillip Morris Intl	PM	3.4	1.60/1.47	Q Oct26/Oct02
W.P. Carey Inc.	WPC	5.7	.95/.94	Q Oct15/Sept30
Reduced				
Cross Timbers Royalty Tr	CRT	5.2	.0643/0.06789	M Oct15/Sept30
PermRock Royalty Trust	PRT	15.1	.0196/0.02178	M Oct15/Sept30
Stocks				
Delixy Holdings	DLXY	1.5		/Sept28

KEY: A: annual; M: monthly; Q: quarterly; revised; SA: semiannual; S21: stock split and ratio; SO: spin-off.

Cash Prices |

These prices reflect buying and selling of a variety of actual or "physical" commodities in the marketplace—separate from the futures price on an exchange, which reflects what the commodity might be worth in future months.

Monday			Monday			Monday		
Energy						Food		
Coal,C,Aplc,12500Btu,1.25O2-r,w		84.000	BMI Lithium Carbonate, EXW China, ~95%+v,w		20700	Beef,carcass equiv. index		
Coal,Pwdr,RvrBsn,8800Btu,0.85O2-r,w		14.650	BMI Lithium Hydroxide, EXW China, ~56%+v,w		19700	choice 1-3,600-900 lbs.-u		347.18
Metals						select 1-3,600-900 lbs.-u		326.46
			Fibers and Textiles			Broilers, National comp wtd avg.-u,w		1.1681
						Butter,AA Chicago-d		1.3600
Gold, per troy oz			Burlap,10-oz,40-inch NY yd-r,w			Cheddar cheese,bbl,Chicago-d		145.25
Engelhard industrial			Cotton,11/16 std lw-mndMplhs-u			Cheddar cheese,bbl,Chicago-d		136.50
Krugerrand,wholesale-e			Cotlook 'A' Index-t			Milk,Nonfat dry,Chicago lb.-d		209.25
Maple Leaf-e			Hides,hvy native steers piece fob-u			Coffee,Brazilian,Comp-y		2.8455
American Eagle-e			Wool,64s,staple,Terr del-u,w			Coffee,Colombian, NY-y		3.5205
Mexican peso-e			Grains and Feeds			Eggs,large white,Chicago-u,w		0.6450
Austria crown-e						Flour,hard winter KC-p		19.95
Austria phil-e						Hams,17-20 lbs,Mid-US fob-u		n.a.
Silver, troy oz.						Hogs,Iowa-So. Minnesota-u		81.54
Engelhard industrial						Pork bellies,12-14 lb MidUS-u		1.1505
Handy & Harman base						Pork loins,13-19 lb MidUS-u		1.0431
Handy & Harman fabricated						Steers,Tex.-Okla. Choice-u		n.a.
Coins,wholesale \$1,000 face-a						Steers,feeder,Okla. City-u,w		382.50
Other metals						Fats and Oils		
Platinum,Engelhard industrial						Degummed corn oil, crude wtd. avg.-u,w		n.a.
Palladium,Engelhard industrial						Grease,choice white,Chicago-h		n.a.
Aluminum, LME, \$ per metric ton						Lard,Chicago-u		n.a.
Copper,Comex spot						Soybean oil,crude,Cent'l IL-u,w		0.7106
Iron Ore, 62% Fe CFR China-S						Tallow,bleach,Chicago-h		n.a.
Steel, HRC USA, FOB Midwest Mills-S						Tallow,edible,Chicago-u		n.a.
Battery/EV metals								

KEY TO CODES: A=ask; B=bid; BP=country elevator bids to producers; C=corrected; D=CME; E=Manfra,Tordella & Brookes; H=American Commodities Brokerage Co; K=bi-weekly; M=monthly; N=nominal; n.a.=not quoted or not available; P=Sosland Publishing; R=SNL Energy; S=Platts-TSI; T=Cotlook Limited; U=USDA; V=Benchmark Mineral Intelligence; W=weekly; Y=International Coffee Organization; Z=not quoted. * Data as of 9/18

Source: Dow Jones Market Data

Borrowing Benchmarks |

Money Rates

Key annual interest rates paid to borrow or lend money in U.S. and international markets. Rates below are a guide to general levels but don't always represent actual transactions.

Inflation				Week				-52-WEEK-						
	Latest	ago	High	Low		Latest	ago	High	Low		Latest	ago	High	Low
Japan														
	2.375	2.375	2.375	1.875	Federal funds									
Effective rate														
High	3.950	3.640	4.100	3.630	Effective rate									
Low	3.950	3.700	4.200	3.700	High									
Bid	3.800	3.550	4.080	3.550	Low									
Offer	3.880	3.630	4.100	3.610	Bid									
	3.890	3.640	4.120	3.630	Offer									
Treasury bill auction														
4 weeks	3.820	3.975	4.080	3.550	4 weeks									
13 weeks	4.015	3.770	4.015	3.550	13 weeks									
26 weeks	4.155	4.060	4.155	3.400	26 weeks									
Other short-term rates														
Prime rates														
U.S.	7.00	6.75	7.25	6.75	U.S.									
Canada	4.45	4.45	4.95	4.45	Canada									

Key Interest Rates

Data are annualized on a 360-day basis. Treasury yields are per annum, on actively traded noninflation and inflation-indexed issues that are adjusted to constant maturities. Data are from weekly Federal Reserve release H.15.

Week Ended — Sep 18					— 52-Week — High				
Low	High	High	Low	Low	High	High	Low	Low	High
Federal funds (effective)									
3.63	3.63	4.33	3.62	3.63	3.63	4.33	3.62	3.63	3.62
Commercial paper									
Nonfinancial									
1-month	3.93	3.76	4.09	3.61	3.93	3.76	4.09	3.61	3.62
2-month	3.98	3.81	4.04	3.58	3.98	3.81	4.04	3.58	3.62
3-month	4.05	3.83	4.05	3.62	4.05	3.83	4.05	3.62	3.62
Financial									
1-month	n.a.	n.a.	4.09	3.60	n.a.	n.a.	4.09	3.60	3.62
2-month	n.a.	3.76	4.10	3.62	n.a.	3.76	4.10	3.62	3.62
3-month	n.a.	3.87	4.06	3.62	n.a.	3.87	4.06	3.62	3.62
Discount window primary credit									
4.00	3.75	4.25	3.75	4.00	3.75	4.25	3.75	4.00	3.75
Treasury yields at constant maturities									
1-month	3.95	3.87	4.21	3.67	3.95	3.87	4.21	3.67	3.67
3-month	4.12	3.99	4.12	3.63	4.12	3.99	4.12	3.63	3.63

Notes on data: Federal-funds rate is an average for the seven days ended Wednesday, weighted according to rates on broker trades; Commercial paper rates are discounted offer rates interpolated from sales by discounted averages of dealer bid rates on nationally traded certificates of deposit; Discount window primary credit rate is charged for discounts made and advances extended under the Federal Reserve's primary credit discount window program; rate is average for seven days ended Wednesday; Inflation-indexed long-term TIPS average is indexed and is based on the unweighted average bid

PRIVATE EQUITY

Exit Drought Is Reshaping the Industry

Junior partners at larger firms set up their own shops as dealmaking slows

By Luis Garcia

A lack of asset sales is causing ripple effects in the private-equity industry, hindering fundraising, boosting the secondary market for fund stakes, and encouraging junior dealmakers at larger firms to strike out on their own, according to partners at advisory firm Monument Group. Private-equity firms have found it harder to sell portfolio companies since interest rates began rising in early 2022. The value of exit deals across the U.S. fell 12% to \$293.7 billion this year through June compared with last year's first half, according to research provider PitchBook. U.S. buyout fund manag-

ers ended June holding a record 13,509 companies, the data show. Fewer exits means fund managers return less capital to the limited partners who invest in their funds than when deal flow is unimpaired, while the general partners see their carried interest, or share of deal profits, dwindle. "We're in this world where LP capital is generally constrained because they haven't been getting [cash] distributions," said Lori Campana, a Monument partner. "The lack of liquidity is hitting the GPs too," added partner John McCormick. "There are these junior partners [who] are waiting for their carry checks. They're not seeing that capital...being monetized." Campana and McCormick spoke during a meeting with reporters that the Boston-based placement agent and secondaries adviser held in New York last week. The dis-

cussion highlighted the changes reshaping the industry as both investors and fund managers adjust to disrupted fundraising cycles, investment flows and capital distributions. Here are some of the main effects described by the executives during the meeting: **Capital concentrates** With less capital sent back to fund investors, they have become more selective in making new commitments, typically favoring established, familiar private-equity managers. That preference makes it harder for younger or less-known buyout shops to raise fresh capital, even some with strong performance records. "They're just backing their top names," McCormick said of private-markets investors. "There's some managers that have done probably pretty well but haven't maybe made

the cut." Chris Webber, a fellow Monument partner, added that investors might disregard firm size to focus on those they see as the best performers in each segment, from shops that pursue lower mid-market deals to managers of large funds that aim for bigger transactions. "The [fundraising] bifurcation is happening up and down the private-equity spectrum," Webber said. "In each market there are winners and losers." **New shops are set up** As many private-equity firms struggled to sell assets and raise new funds in recent years, some dealmakers see fewer opportunities to use their skills and get in line for big payouts from profitable exits. More are departing to form their own shops, hoping they can attract investors based on

their experience. "In a lot of these larger firms, succession is a big issue and there's a ceiling on a lot of younger professionals," Webber said. "If they don't see a way to get their carry or move up to the next level, then they are going to strike out on their own." The trend is fueling a rising number of spinouts from larger firms and the creation of other first-time fund managers, as well as independent sponsors that raise capital deal-by-deal rather than collecting a fund for several investments, the Monument partners said. "More and more investors who've co-invested behind GPs now are comfortable...going further out the risk curve and backing individual deals with certain [independent] sponsors," Webber added. **Continuation vehicles** The dearth of exits is also

driving demand for so-called continuation vehicles that scoop up older assets and enable private-equity firms to extend ownership of valued holdings while giving LPs in mature funds the option of cashing out. Once considered a last resort, continuation deals are becoming more common, and they now represent a critical tool for fund managers to generate liquidity. Asked whether some fund investors are seeking to limit buyout firms' use of continuation funds, Christine Patrinos, a Monument partner who co-leads the firm's secondaries group, said recent fund contracts show "quite the opposite." "GPs are beginning to build in their docs the ability to make sure they can" set up continuation vehicles, she said. *Luis Garcia writes about private equity for WSJ Pro.*

Livingbridge Sheds Staff, Top Earner Gets Pay Cut

By Lars Mucklejohn

Livingbridge shed almost two dozen staff last year as the midmarket private-equity firm's highest-earning partner received an 80% pay cut. The London-based firm employed an average of 47 staff in 2025, compared with 69 during the previous year, according to registry filings for its main corporate entity Livingbridge EP LLP. Livingbridge's best-paid partner received a £1.2 million, or around \$1.6 million, share of its profit last year, which was down from £6.2 million in 2024, the filings show. The filings didn't identify which of Livingbridge's 16

partners was the highest earner. Livingbridge is run by Managing Partner Wol Kolade, who led its spinout from F&C in 2005. He owns between 25% and 50% of Livingbridge EP LLP, according to the U.K.'s corporate register. A representative for Livingbridge declined to comment on whether Kolade was its top earner or if it made job cuts. A 38% year-over-year drop in staff costs, to £7.5 million, helped lift the firm's pretax profit to £18.8 million last year, up from £14.5 million in 2024. Revenue was broadly flat at £35.6 million. The figures come after a challenging period for Living-

bridge, as it has grappled with senior staff departures and a tougher fundraising environment. Earlier this year, Livingbridge sounded out investors about a renewed strategy that would narrow its target sectors to technology and healthcare as it tests appetite for another flagship fund, Dow Jones's Private Equity News reported. Livingbridge closed its last flagship vehicle, Livingbridge 7, with £1.2 billion more than five years ago. The firm last year scrapped its enterprise strategy, which backed small and midsize businesses in the U.K. *Lars Mucklejohn writes about private equity for WSJ Pro.*

Warburg Pincus's Improved Offer For Ingenia Communities Rejected

By Stuart Condie

SYDNEY—**Warburg Pincus** failed with an improved US\$1.47 billion play for Australian retirement village operator **Ingenia Communities**, which signaled that it would be prepared to consider higher offers. Ingenia, which owns retirement villages and holiday parks in Australia, said Monday that the New York-based private-equity group had raised its indicative all-cash offer to 5.05 Australian dollars a share, equivalent to US\$3.60. That was 6.3% higher than Warburg Pincus's previous proposal of A\$4.75 a share, which Ingenia rejected two weeks ago. After consulting an inde-

pendent adviser, Ingenia said its board determined that the revised proposal still substantially undervalued the company and wasn't in the best interests of its shareholders. "The Ingenia board remains open to considering proposals that represent compelling value and are considered to be in the best interests of securityholders," Ingenia said. "This has been communicated to Warburg Pincus and its advisers." Warburg Pincus, which has more than US\$10 billion invested in Asia-Pacific real-es-

tate platforms and ventures, said it was disappointed by Ingenia's lack of engagement on its latest proposal. "We remain open to constructive engagement on our proposal with the Ingenia board and continue to seek a friendly transaction recommended by the Ingenia board," Warburg Pincus said in emailed comments. Warburg Pincus's initial offer, which Ingenia announced Sept. 7, included a condition that Ingenia not proceed with its proposed acquisition of Australia-listed home builder Peet.

Ingenia signals that it would consider higher acquisition offers.

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MARKETS

Magnificent Seven Post Rebound

Continued from page B1

Muse, a free AI assistant that offers paid tiers for heavy users, appeared to offer an avenue for growth.

Muse is Meta’s most consequential consumer product in years, Truist analyst Youssef Squali recently told clients, calling it “the clearest attempt yet to build a non-[advertising] revenue stream.”

On Monday, the six other Mag Seven names also finished in the green.

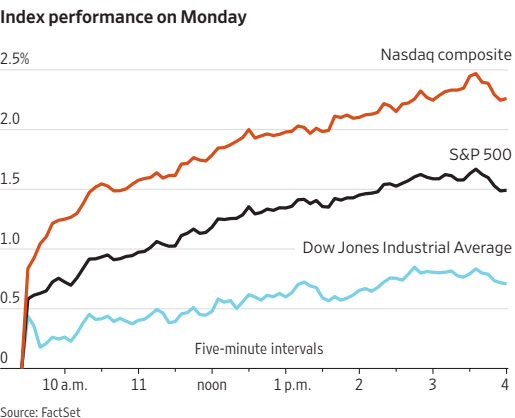
Wall Street’s renewed AI optimism lifted data-center developers and suppliers, propelling **Intel** shares 12% higher and boosting **Advanced Micro Devices** by 10%. AMD notched a \$1 trillion market capitalization for the first time, becoming the 14th U.S. company to do so.

Trafigura Launches Oil-Shipping Business

By ADAM WHITTAKER

Trading house **Trafigura** has launched Volare Shipping and said it plans to sell a roughly \$500 million stake in the oil-shipping business ahead of a potential listing.

Trafigura said Monday that Volare Shipping will initially operate six very large crude carriers with a further eight newbuild vessels to come. It said it plans to raise \$500 million via a private placement of the shares before listing the business on the Euronext Growth Oslo exchange on or around Oct. 5. Trafigura will remain the majority owner of



The Nasdaq composite rose 2.3%, logging its third straight gain to close at a record. The S&P 500 climbed 1.5%, while the Dow Jones Industrial Average ticked 0.7% higher, gaining 366 points.

A slide in oil prices provided some breathing room for tech stocks’ takeoff.

After the temporary shut-down of a Saudi Arabian pipeline helped push prices to some of their highest levels of the year, Brent crude futures on Monday retreated for the

fourth session in a row, falling 3.4% to \$100.34 a barrel, while U.S. benchmark crude futures fell 4.5% to \$95.78.

American officials and outside analysts say tanker traffic through the Strait of Hormuz has picked up somewhat in recent weeks, thanks in part to dark transits in which ships turn off tracking signals.

A gathering of global leaders for the United Nations General Assembly in New York this week has also momentarily rejuvenated hopes for diplomacy

Fertilizer Firms Fall on Potash Deal

In a move to lower fertilizer prices for farmers, President Trump said the U.S. plans to buy potash from Belarus, undercutting Canadian imports.

Stocks of North American fertilizer companies dropped. Potash supplier Nutrien fell 3.3%; CF Industries was 3.5% lower and Mosaic fell 1.7%.

Farmers have been facing rising fertilizer and fuel costs because of the war in

Iran. In a social-media post, Trump said he’s working on a “massive deal” to help by bringing in cheaper fertilizer imports from Belarus, a close Russian ally. The U.S. largely stopped imports of Belarus and Russian potash since Russia’s invasion of Ukraine. Canada supplies about 90% of U.S. potash imports annually, accounting for about \$4 billion in trade.

—Patrick Thomas

Bank Société Générale Lifts Target for Profitability

By MICHAEL HENNESSEY AND ADRIÀ CALATAYUD

Société Générale shares rose after the bank said it is targeting cost cuts and revenue growth to boost profitability through the end of the decade, including widening its use of artificial intelligence.

Shares of Société Générale advanced nearly 2% Monday.

The French bank said it aims to reduce its 2029 costs by about 2% compared with its expected level for this year, and deliver annual growth in group revenue of around 3% on average between 2026 and 2029. Capital distributions to shareholders could top €21 billion, or \$24.12 billion, over the 2026-29 period, it added.

Société Générale Chief Executive Slawomir Krupa said the group aims to accelerate its profitable growth while maintaining cost discipline.

The bank said it is targeting a return on tangible capital—a key profitability metric for banks—of between 13% and 14% in 2029 and more than 15% in 2030 and beyond. For 2025, it reported the metric at 10.2%.

Shares of Société Générale have nearly tripled since Krupa launched an initial three-year plan to improve profitability in 2023. Under that plan, Société Générale targeted a return on tangible capital above 10% for 2026. The bank has seen increased profit in the last two years, boosted by higher interest rates and reduced costs.

In its new strategic plan, the company said it would reduce expenses through a cut in IT spending and procurement costs, while expanding its use of AI. The bank also expects to reduce the number of employees through natural attrition, though it didn’t specify a number.



The trading house plans to sell a roughly \$500 million stake ahead of a potential listing.

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“Think like a builder, not just a steward. Your job is to create the financial capacity for your organization to grow, not just to protect the balance sheet. Early on, I focused on foundational building blocks: outsourcing non-core functions, modernizing infrastructure, and building data discipline. That groundwork is why we moved 2,500 employees remote almost overnight when Covid hit. Don’t operate purely in defense mode because today’s efficiencies fuel tomorrow’s innovation.”



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“Stay close to the data and the people. The job increasingly requires translating complexity into clear priorities, and you cannot do that well from a distance. Financial discipline matters, but so does knowing how to weigh data against human insight. Leaders who develop both tend to navigate uncertainty better than those who optimize for one.”



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HEARD_{ON THE} STREET

FINANCIAL ANALYSIS & COMMENTARY

A Safer Way to Bet on Nuclear Power

There are a lot of wild bets on the sector. One enrichment company holds a strong hand.

Uranium enrichment—a key step in making nuclear fuel—is a unique corner of the energy market. Only two companies, both in Europe, hold enrichment capacity outside Russia and China. American company **Centrus Energy** is hoping to disrupt that world order.

Centrus shares rode an AI wave over the past few years, peaking late last year. Since then, its shares have lost steam alongside other nuclear stocks. It is down 67% from its peak. But it looks less speculative than some nuclear plays.

The decline is partly because there is more nuclear equity available on the public market, according to Vikram Bagri, equity analyst at Citi. More nuclear stocks have made public debuts recently, and existing companies such as **NuScale**, **Oklo** and Centrus have raised additional equity. Plus, rising interest rates lower the present value of nuclear projects, which are capital intensive and have long timelines, he added.

Centrus shares still aren't cheap and trade at roughly 52 times forward earnings. It is all relative, though. Its market cap is less than half that of **X-Energy** and Oklo, both of which are small modular reactor, or SMR, companies that aren't anywhere close to generating profit. Near-term earnings might not be a meaningful metric for a company whose enrichment capacity isn't expected to start for a couple of years.

Once part of the U.S. government, Centrus stopped enriching uranium in 2013 and went bankrupt in 2014 after demand tanked following the Fukushima nuclear accident. Since then, Centrus has been making money primarily as a broker-dealer for enriched uranium. Now it is building out manufacturing capacity to re-enter the enrichment market by 2029.

Russia is the main reason. The U.S. used to source up to one-quarter of its enriched uranium from Russia but has banned those imports. Temporary waivers on that ban will end on Jan. 1, 2028.

Outside Russia and China, there are currently only two other providers with scale: **Urenco**, a consortium between the U.K., Netherlands and Germany, and French company Orano.



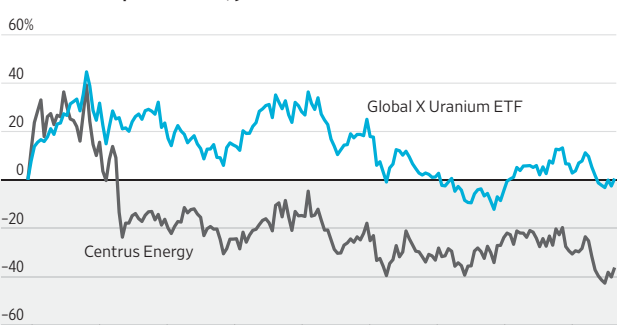
More nuclear stocks have made public debuts recently. The former Three Mile Island in Pennsylvania.

The price of enrichment has soared from \$65 per separative work unit in February 2022—before Russia's invasion of Ukraine—to \$181 per SWU today, according to data from research firm UxC. Part of that reflects tight supply as buyers look for non-Russian sources. It also reflects rising demand as utilities look to restart old nuclear reactors or extend the lives of existing ones, according to Jonathan Hinze, president of UxC.

Industry watchers say demand won't be a problem for Centrus, even though incumbents Urenco and Orano are expanding or adding enrichment capacity in the U.S. Utilities want diversification, Hinze said. "Russian [supply] is going away, China is not supplying the West. Utilities in the U.S., Europe, Japan and Korea want more options," he said. South Korean utility Korea Hydro & Nuclear Power, for example, has signed a long-term supply agreement with Centrus.

Centrus expects the bulk of its future enrichment revenue will come from low-enriched uranium, the type that conventional nuclear reactors use. It is, however, well positioned to benefit if SMR technology takes off. It is the only com-

Share and ETF performance, year to date



Source: FactSet

pany with a Nuclear Regulatory Commission license to produce the highly enriched uranium required by some of these new technologies.

The other potential market is the U.S. government. So far, Centrus is the only enrichment company that relies solely on domestically made components, making it the only player that can meet U.S. national security needs such as naval reactors. Since Centrus's enrichment operations stopped in 2013, the U.S. government has been drawing

down Cold War-era stockpiles. The National Nuclear Security Administration has said that it intends to solely source certain enrichment from Centrus, according to the company.

The bigger risk for Centrus is execution. It has proven that its technology works but hasn't demonstrated that it can produce at commercial scale. Its successful demonstration project with the Energy Department involved 16 centrifuges. Commercial enrichment facil-

ities use thousands of centrifuges, Hinze said.

Funding is the other risk, given that Centrus's factories will be capital intensive. It is setting up an enrichment facility in Piketon, Ohio, and a centrifuge manufacturing facility in Oak Ridge, Tenn. Earlier this year, Centrus received a \$900 million task order from the Energy Department. It also has raised money through equity and debt offerings. Between this and its cash reserve, it should be able to meet near-term requirements.

But the company will need to raise more going forward. One source of additional funding could be prepayment from potential customers. So far, it has signed three such agreements, including with X-Energy. Utilities tend to be conservative, but more of them might be willing to prepay for Centrus's future capacity as it makes progress on manufacturing, said Lawson Winder, equity analyst at BofA Global Research.

Enrichment promises to be profitable. Urenco's margins on an earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization basis have averaged 61% between 2010 and 2023, according to a report from Citi. Enrichment companies have considerable market power, given the limited competition.

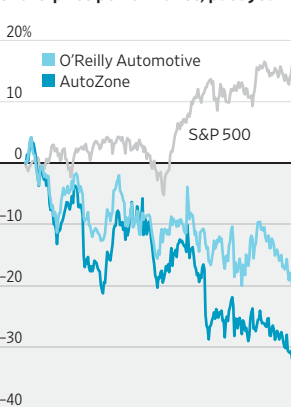
That isn't to say there won't be competition in the future. Other American companies also are eyeing the market, including General Matter, which is backed by Peter Thiel's Founders Fund. Another is Global Laser Enrichment, which is co-owned by Canadian uranium miner **Cameco**. But Centrus has an early-mover advantage: It is one of only two companies—alongside Urenco—that has an NRC license to produce low-enriched uranium and the only NRC-licensed entity for the highly enriched kind.

While Centrus has been lumped together with some more-speculative nuclear stocks, its technology is proven, and future revenues don't depend on new technologies taking off. The U.S. government and potential customers should be highly motivated to see a domestic enrichment provider succeed. Given the company's unique position, it deserves an energy security premium.

—Jinjo Lee

Auto Parts Retailers Can Turn the Corner

Share-price performance, past year



Source: FactSet

If investors were asked a year ago to guess the most successful consumer stock since the global financial crisis, many would have said **Apple**. It had just launched the first iPhone when the recession began in a market still dominated by BlackBerry.

But Apple's return was eclipsed by auto parts retailer **O'Reilly Automotive**, up close to 5,000%. **AutoZone**, which releases results Tuesday, was close behind.

It sounds impossible: Americans don't buy more cars today than they did in 2007, and each one still has the same number of wiper blades and taillights. EVs don't even need motor oil.

The performance of those retailers was driven by smart financial stewardship and the resilience of their business models. But their

Apple-like gains were measured a year ago. Rising interest rates and gasoline prices are enough to foul even the finest engine.

AutoZone is down 31% over the past year and is likely to echo the downbeat message from competitors O'Reilly and **Advance Auto Parts** when it reports. That suggests a hopeful pattern.

Just like during the 2008-09 recession, when oil prices hit their all-time high, deferred maintenance from the retailers' financially pinched lower-income clientele hurts sales at first. By the fall of 2008, the three stocks were down by 30% on average while **Walmart** shares were up for the year.

Food is a necessity. Eventually, though, spark plugs are, too.

And, instead of being tied to new auto sales, that actually has an

inverse correlation with maintenance. AutoZone had great years for same-store sales in 2009, 2011, 2020 and 2021 when car sales were lousy and the vehicle fleet got older. The sweet spot for parts sales is cars between four and 11 years old.

Sinking money into your jalopy has a higher payoff when a new or lightly used car is out of reach financially—maybe not at first, but increasingly so as old cars face wear and tear. That pain point hinges somewhat on weather, with snowy winters boosting customer traffic.

Sales and sentiment turned several months into the 2008-09 recession. Back then, depressed share prices gave these serial buyers of their own stock extra bang for the buck. AutoZone bought back three-

quarters of its shares since the end of the 2007 fiscal year. O'Reilly repurchased more than half of its shares over a similar span.

From the recession's start through the end of 2011, AutoZone and O'Reilly shares beat the S&P 500 by 161 percentage points and 128 percentage points, respectively. Economic conditions then were certainly worse than today—unemployment is half as high as in 2011. The stocks aren't as cheap either.

O'Reilly's and AutoZone's recent slumps leave them at modest premiums to their respective trailing 10-year averages of price to forward sales.

Investors aren't being offered quite the same bargains as in 2008, but it's time to start kicking the tires.

—Spencer Jakab

MONEY & INVESTING

Stock Spotlight

Intel, Super Micro Computer, Advanced Micro Devices

The AI trade continues to find strength after a rally that began again last week, sending shares of chip makers, server designers and related companies higher.

Meta Platforms

The social-media company's stock rose 11%

On This Day in Market History

On this day in 1668, the Swedish parliament founded the Riksbank, or Estates of the Realm Bank. Later renamed the

to 741.25 amid enthusiasm for its Muse AI agent.

Paramount Skydance and Warner Bros. Discovery

Paramount executives and a coalition of states that sued to block the company's \$81 billion merger with Warner agreed on a settlement that includes concessions. Warner stock popped 11%; Paramount shares fell 2.9%.

Coinbase Global, Robinhood Markets, Strategy

Sveriges Riksbank, it considers itself the world's oldest central bank—predating other venerable institutions such as the Bank of England.

Bitcoin's surge above \$85,000—its highest level since January—is rewarding stocks tied to cryptocurrencies. Bitcoin-hoarding firm Strategy led the gains, rising 9.5%.

TUESDAY'S EVENTS:

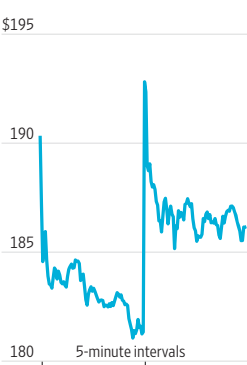
◆ Fed speakers: Vice Chair Philip Jefferson, New York Fed President John Williams, Richmond Fed President Thomas Barkin.

◆ Economic data: Richmond Fed business activity survey, Johnson Redbook retail sales, money stock measures, ADP weekly employment report

EARNINGS EXPECTED: AutoZone, KB Home

Accenture Shares Climb on Anthropic AI Safety Partnership

Accenture shares, past two days



Source: FactSet

Accenture shares climbed 2.7% Monday after the company said late Friday that it would embed a team of evaluators inside **Anthropic** to stress-test its AI models.

The AI company called the partnership an important step toward its commitment to pace development of the technology.

Accenture's shares are down roughly 30% this year on market jitters about corporate IT spending and concern that AI tools could take away business from professional-services firms.

Details on the partnership remain scarce, but it will be led by Faculty, a U.K.-based

AI company Accenture acquired this year.

Accenture and Anthropic said they expected to invest about \$1 billion each over the next five years in the AI safety effort.

Accenture has partnered with Anthropic before, including through an effort to embed AI adoption across clients' operations.

A downgrade from a Guggenheim analyst led to Accenture shares closing down 4.7% on Friday ahead of the announcement. Last quarter, the company lowered its revenue guidance for the fiscal year. It reports those results on Oct. 1.

—Allison Pohle

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That's when you find out your funds aren't quite as available as advertised, or that your account isn't a hundred percent yours. A freeze here. A restriction there. A currency worth less than it was last year. Nobody sends a notice. No one questions the system. And the powers that be control what's rightfully yours.

With bitcoin, your access lives in a twelve-word recovery phrase that only you hold. No financial institution, government, or middlemen can freeze it, dilute it, or take it from you. Ever.

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GETTINGBITCOIN.ORG

A special report by *Barron's* magazine, a Dow Jones publication



ILLUSTRATION BY BLAKE CALE

Billions of dollars of private capital are fueling wealth management mergers, which can lead to improvements for advisors and clients—but not always.

BY STEVE GARMHAUSEN



The wealth management business has become a magnet for private capital, which has driven a wave of consolidation among independent registered investment advisor firms. Echelon Partners, an investment banking and consulting firm, says RIA dealmakers announced 120 transactions from April through June, a second-quarter record. Private-equity-backed buyers accounted for 91, or more than three-quarters, of those deals.

Beneath the radar, private capital is also being used to turn upstart independent firms into formidable businesses, with benefits for advisors and clients alike. “If PE investors’ financial capital is

used to enhance the set of services offered to clients, that is a very good thing,” says Raj Bhattacharyya, CEO of Robertson Stephens Wealth Management in San Francisco, which ranks 92nd on *Barron's* 2026 Top 100 RIA Firms list.

At the same time, private capital can come with strings attached. Outside investors have an interest in containing costs to maximize profits. And PE firms often exit investments after five to seven years, meaning that they and the wealth management firms they own must find new investors, and the firms must adjust to the new ownership. This can dilute RIAs’ focus on supporting their advisors and their end clients.

There is no doubt that PE money has flooded the industry. During the first three quarters of 2025, private-equity investors plowed more than \$32 billion into 212 wealth management transactions, exceeding the nearly \$29 billion across 249 deals during all of 2024, according to PitchBook.

Wealth management firms seek PE backers’ capital to provide liquidity to founders, to hire advisors and subject-matter experts, to buy or build better technology, and more. For their part, PE firms and their investors get access to

strong, highly predictable cash flows. Wealth management firms typically generate revenue by charging clients annual fees that are a percentage of the clients’ assets they manage. Those fees grow as the value of the stock market increases and boosts client portfolios.

The stakes for all of this have become greater as independent wealth management firms, once dwarfed by powerhouse Wall Street brokerages, grow into giants in their own right. For example, Creative Planning, based in Overland Park, Kan., said it managed \$419 billion in client assets as of June 30, 2026.

Our 2026 RIA ranking, which can be a useful resource for investors looking for a financial advisor, illustrates the industry’s growth. The average assets under management of all the firms ranked this year was \$43.3 billion, up from \$34.3 billion in 2025. Mergers and acquisitions played a role, with deals conducted over the 12 months ended on June 30 accounting for 5.8% of firms’ average annual revenue and 7.1% of their average AUM.

Several firms made big leaps in our ranking thanks to their dealmaking. Wealthspire ranks sixth on this year’s list, up 10 spots from 2025, when it ranked 16th. The firm’s acquisition of Fiduciant Advisors in October 2025 added \$97.5 billion to Wealthspire’s AUM. Elsewhere, Waverly Advisors gained 21 spots to rank 27th this year. Since January, Waverly has acquired four RIAs, adding a total of \$65.3 billion to its AUM. And Apollon Wealth Management jumped 13 spots this year to 67th, as its AUM grew 67% year over year thanks to an aggressive M&A strategy.

Ryan Parker, CEO of EP Wealth Advisors—based in Torrance, Calif.,

and ranked ninth on our 2026 RIA list—likens access to capital to “oxygen” that lets wealth managers grow. Backed by PE firms Ares Management and Berkshire Partners, EP Wealth has invested in a range of technology tools to increase productivity and save advisors time so they can focus more on solving clients’ problems and less on paperwork.

Outside capital helps firms like EP Wealth invest in expertise at a time when the industry is competing to serve the growing number of families with complex wealth. “You’ve got to be able to afford the CPAs [certified public accountants] and the JDs [lawyers],” says Parker. With help from its backers, EP Wealth can figure out which technology solutions to invest in and when, Parker adds.

“The private-equity discussion in the boardroom always intersects with the needs of our advisors,” he says. “That includes tangible benefits—real ways to improve their organic growth, their productivity, and the ability to deliver the full value proposition to high-net-worth and ultrahigh-net-worth clients.”

Not all providers of private capital are so enlightened. The cliché of a private-equity firm—it brings you flowers on the first date and is counting paper clips in your office a few months later—isn’t based on nothing, says Leo Kelly, CEO of Verdecence Capital Advisors in Hunt, Md. “I think it’s fair to say that there are situations like that,” he says.

Verdecence announced its latest private-equity capital raise in March: Wealth Partners Capital Group and HGGC acquired a majority stake in the company, while previous PE owner Emigrant Partners exited.

Continued on the following page

A Top Advisor to Dentists, Professors, And Other Niche Clients

Savant Wealth Management sets itself apart by knowing what very specific types of clients need—and then delivering it.

BY PATTI DOMM

Savant Wealth Management CEO Brent Brodeski says merging with other firms has been a powerful strategy that has helped Savant grow faster than he expected, find top talent, and provide one-stop shopping for clients looking for services such as tax and accounting advice.

It has also been a path that allowed Savant to grow in specialty niches. For example, Savant has built expertise in advising clients who teach at universities. It also has a team focused on helping ultrahigh-net-worth women going through divorce. And in 2024, it acquired another firm that specializes in serving the elderly.

Ten years ago, Brodeski set a goal “to improve a million lives,” he says. “I think we’re going to get there in about five years, give or take.” Brodeski estimates that Savant now affects 269,000 people directly or indirectly, meaning clients, employees, and its local communities.

The advisory firm ranks 21st on *Barron’s* 2026 Top 100 RIA Firms and has about \$56 billion in assets under management. *Barron’s* recently spoke with Brodeski, along with Zach Ivey, chief investment and advice officer, and Kevin Hrdlicka, head of wealth, about Savant’s growth strategy, structure, and investment approach. An edited version of the conversation follows.

***Barron’s:* Brent, you’ve been leading this firm since the 1980s, and you’ve seen a tremendous amount of growth through mergers and acquisitions. I’m wondering whether that is a strategy you will continue.**

Brent Brodeski: It is really a strategy to reinforce organic growth. The best way to grow is a client at a time. The challenge with just trying to grow organically is that it’s hard to really expand the footprint. Zach and his team in Birmingham, Ala., joined us two and a half years ago, and I couldn’t have hired them, but I could partner with them. And now Zach is our chief advice and investment officer.

What a great way to get talent. I look around our organization: Whether it’s our top advisors, the top growing advisors, our leadership, our executives, almost all of them have come through M&A.

We started almost 40 years ago in Rockford, Ill. We became the big fish in a little bowl, and when we tried to just open greenfield offices [where there wasn’t an existing office], it was really hard. If you open up a greenfield office somewhere—we did that in Peoria, Ill.; we did it in Madison, Wis.; we did it in the Chicago suburbs—the phone doesn’t start ringing because you don’t know people, you don’t have referral sources, you don’t know the communities. So, we realized we needed to actually go to places like Birmingham—where Zach and his team were very established, knew the community, and had a great client base—and then bring them in, and then grow together faster than they could on their own or we could on our own.

When you get in certain markets—like, we’re in Los Angeles now and New York now—you plant the flag, but you’re a drop in the bucket. But once we have a flag, it’s a lot easier to go and find other partners and to grow. We went from nothing in California; we’ll probably have six or seven firms there. We had nothing in New York; we’re probably going to have four or five within 12 months. Being able to create density allows us to organically grow faster in the markets we’ve chosen.

We’re organically growing over 8% a year, without being in the custodial referral programs in a big way. That’s significant. But there are plays out there we don’t have. Things like niche playbooks. Sometimes when we partner, they might have a better play in their book than we do.

What do you mean by niches?

Brodeski: An example: We are probably the biggest niche provider for tenured university professors in the Big Ten and Ivy Leagues. It’s an interesting niche. These people are wired differently, and they have different needs.

Another one would be C-suite level executives at publicly traded companies. We have a firm that specializes in exit planning for businesses. We have a firm

From left: Zach Ivey, chief investment and advisory officer; Brent R. Brodeski, founder and CEO; and Kevin Hrdlicka, head of wealth at Savant Wealth Management.

OUR ADVISOR RANKING AT A GLANCE

Savant Wealth Management #21



in New York City that works with ultrahigh-net-worth divorced women. We just closed yesterday on an accounting firm, and all they do is physicians and dentists. They’re excited about now being able to introduce financial planning, investments, wealth transfer, and retirement plans because they’ve got these clients who need these things, and they see them getting poorly served by other advisors. Now that creates a medical niche.

We have our accounting firm. We have 175 professionals. That brings us deep experience being able to help business owners not only with their businesses, but with their personal wealth. And then when they sell their business, someday our family office division can help them manage money and take over administrative responsibility.

I want to mention a firm we acquired in Kentucky; they built their entire company around longevity. They’re experts on gerontology and end-of-life issues. Our clients, on average, are old. Our clients often have health issues, or their parents have end-of-life issues. That is expertise that we didn’t have, but our whole organization, all of our advisors, could benefit from that wisdom and that knowledge of how to bring peace of mind and comfort to that last stage of life, whether it’s the parents or the actual clients.

How have these mergers affected your clients?

Kevin Hrdlicka: With all of the M&A, what ends up happening is you have to get really good at training new advisors. In many cases, they’ve been doing this 30 years, and they have a way of doing it. Well, now they join Savant, and we have a team of tax strategists that can do a client’s tax return.

We want to own the whole financial experience for a client. We believe that leads to much better advice. So, we train them that when you onboard a client, let’s get their tax return, let’s give a tax strategy update as part of the traditional financial plan. Embedding tax with in-

“We are probably the biggest niche provider for tenured university professors in the Big Ten and Ivy Leagues. It’s an interesting niche.”

Brent Brodeski, founder and CEO, Savant Wealth Management

vestments is something that our clients want. When we get a new client, that is the top reason they pick Savant.

Zach, why don't you jump in here. Bond yields are rising to levels that we haven't seen in a few years. How is that affecting your investment advice at this point?

Zach Ivey: Well, we espouse an evidence-based approach to investing. We don’t really believe that investors get paid to predict the future, and we shouldn’t be doing that, either. We get paid for bearing risk in a kind of disciplined way, and that simply means very thoughtful diversification.

On the stock side of things, we use a factor-based approach to breaking up the equity markets, and on the bond side, we likewise favor a very diversified portfolio. That protects you for all the different things that could happen. This approach seems really timely today, but we’ve been doing it a long time.

Are you viewing bonds as the ballast in your portfolio, and is this move in interest rates affecting that?

Ivey: Bonds are our liquidity and ballast to the portfolio, although for some investors, we do utilize alternative investments, which are often a risk reducer but without all that interest-rate risk.

What type of alternative investments are you looking at?

Ivey: We often think about alternatives not as one particular thing, but really

as a recipe. So, we use asset classes like real assets, farmland, timberland, infrastructure, some diversified strategies like hedge funds, as well as trend following, private credit, reinsurance. Some of these, if you think of them individually, you would say, “Wow, that is a unique asset.” But when we blend them together, they really can do a lot to accomplish that diversification in the portfolio.

In most cases, when we’re utilizing alternatives—and not all investors have alternatives—we start allocations at around 10% and go up to around 20% in alternatives. A lot of that is coming off the bond side of the portfolio.

Brent, what other niches are you looking at?

Brodeski: We aren’t in the airline pilot niche, and I would love to be. Most of them are coming through the military, and they’ve got a certain sort of persona. They can work with any generic advisor, but an advisor that really understands pilots is going to be able to create better alignment and more comfortable, better advice.

Thank you, all. ■

Savant Wealth Management Rockford, Ill.	
Clients	23,079
Advisors	253
Offices	70
States	28

TOP 100 INDEPENDENT ADVISORS 2026

For Ultrawealthy Clients, a Host Of Services Under One Roof

How the Mather Group, a *Barron's* top-ranked registered investment advisory, uses acquisitions to cater to ultrahigh-net-worth families.

BY CHERYL WINOKUR MUNK

The Mather Group has been an active acquirer of registered investment advisor firms in the past several years, integrating multiple RIAs from across the country. The Chicago-based firm, which ranks 41st on *Barron's* 2026 Top 100 RIA Firms list, has made 25 acquisitions since 2019, often absorbing smaller practices with one or two advisors into a much larger team spread across 14 offices.

“We’re looking for RIA partners who share our commitment to clients, their people, and the long-term success of the firm,” says Ryan Wickert, the Mather Group’s chief financial officer, in a recent *Barron's* interview. “The right partnership should expand what we can deliver to clients while giving advisors and employees the resources, opportunities, and career paths to grow. Our goal is to build something stronger together.”

Jennifer des Groseilliers, the firm’s chief executive, and Kristen Oziemkowski, chief operating officer, joined Wickert to discuss how the Mather Group operates, its acquisition strategy, and the integrated services it offers clients. An edited version of the conversation follows.

From left: Ryan Wickert, chief financial officer; Jennifer des Groseilliers, CEO; and Kristen Oziemkowski, chief operating officer of the Mather Group.



PHOTOGRAPH BY NATE RYAN

planning, and, for those with assets above \$25 million, family office services.

Who are your typical clients?
Oziemkowski: Historically, our core client has been a Fortune 200 executive who is one to two years from retirement or has already retired. That remains an important part of our business, but today we serve a much broader range of clients, including individuals and families, business owners, executives, and ultrahigh-net-worth families.

What is your acquisition strategy?
Ryan Wickert: To date, we’ve done 25 partnerships across the country, starting in 2019. We’re very intentional about our deals so advisors feel like they are partners within TMG, not just someone coming from the outside and operating on an island.
Oziemkowski: Our typical firm at this point has been somewhere from \$200 million to \$600 million in assets. Most of the firms we’ve added have been one- or two-person shops, but it varies. We’ve also partnered with 10- to 12-person shops. The partners we’re looking for are client-focused, and their primary focus is on relationships with their clients. So, like the Mather Group, they want to serve their clients very deeply. We are interested in certain geographies across the country, but primarily it’s about being a planning-focused company.

What’s your stance on giving advisors equity in the firm?
Des Groseilliers: We believe in a total ownership philosophy, which means that every one of our 199 employees either has

equity, or they have a path to equity. We believe that really helps our culture, and it drives the commitment to our growth and serving our clients.

What lessons have you learned through your multiple acquisitions?
Des Groseilliers: Our experience has taught us how important it is to stay disciplined about integration. It requires a lot of work and diligence. We do a lot of work up front to make sure we have a partner that has that same desire.
Wickert: When we’re having preliminary conversations, we have a level of candor such that the partnership starts before the ink is dry, so to speak. By doing that, we feel like we get way better outcomes.
Oziemkowski: We’ve also gotten really good at being a lot more transparent when working through things at the front end to ensure really good alignment.

Can you talk about how you’ve developed family office capabilities to complement the practice?
Wickert: In addition to our Fortune 200-type clients, we have family office clients that we serve effectively. We have a fully dedicated team that supports our family office, which includes our client service and tax team. Most of the time, conversations turn to family education, family values, charitable giving, and the like. It’s a very different type of conversation at those ultra-ultrahigh-net-worth levels. We are able to support these needs with a dedicated team.
Oziemkowski: We’re trying to build relationships with spouses, partners, and children of ultrahigh-net-worth clients. There’s a different level of complexity and

need for clients with \$25 million or more. So, we’re able to provide very deep estate planning and financial planning services to those clients. Being able to have that in-house with the same integrated approach is definitely a differentiator.

What’s keeping clients up at night?
Des Groseilliers: Our clients are thinking about more than what the market or the Federal Reserve might do next. They’re asking whether they can retire when they want, maintain their lifestyle, support their families, and feel confident about the decisions they’re making. Our role is to help them answer those questions. A strong financial plan isn’t built around predicting the next market move. It’s built to help clients make informed decisions and stay focused on what they want their wealth to accomplish.
Wickert: Today’s environment requires a different level of conversation, since many of our clients are contemplating retirement. But that’s where we feel we’re earning our keep—to help them understand what retirement looks like or continuing to work looks like under different scenarios. That’s why we’re here.

Thank you, all. ■

The Mather Group Chicago	
Clients	5,614
Advisors	48
Offices	14
States	9

RWA Wealth Partners’ Plan for Investing Success in a ‘Middling’ Economy

RWA’s leaders explain where they see the next AI investment winners, as well as the firm’s law-firm roots and its private-equity-backed expansion.

BY STEVE GARMHAUSEN

The next differentiator for wealth management firms serving high-net-worth families might not be tax services or concierge perks—it could be helping them live healthier lives.

RWA Wealth Partners, for example, refers clients to a healthcare advisory business in its network that guides families through healthcare and longevity decisions. “Having those types of partners has been powerful for us,” says Michelle Knight, CEO and chief economist of the Boston-based wealth firm, which ranks No. 32 on *Barron's* 2026 Top 100 RIA Firms list. “It has been a gift to be able to offer that to people.”

Knight and Joseph “JP” Powers, the firm’s chief investment officer, spoke with *Barron's* Advisor about the investment opportunities in artificial intelligence, RWA’s origins inside law firm Ropes & Gray, and how the advisory’s structure facilitates its goal of serving clients through the stages of their financial life. An edited version of the conversation follows.

Barron’s: Let’s start with investing. What’s the bond market telling us with its rising long-term yields?
Joseph Powers: As we talk today, the U.S. has crossed \$40 trillion of debt. I would characterize economic growth as

solid but not impressive, and inflation is still running well above target. It isn’t a sustainable trend. And it has been compounded recently by the high issuance of debt by companies tied to the artificial-intelligence buildup. The sheer scale of that issuance has pulled yields higher. We’ve had some Treasury interventions this month aimed at trying to keep a cap on yields. But we’ve felt that it’s also going to take action from the Federal Reserve to move the needle, just because of the sheer size of their balance sheet.

I think the issue the market has had is that this new regime has been reluctant to provide any forward guidance. There were some signs from Fed Chairman Kevin Warsh’s [recent] speech that he’s leaning in that direction. I think he does want to be hawkish on inflation; that’s his track record. But he also has to navigate a relationship with the White House. I think we’re still going through this adjustment period and feeling out how he’s going to communicate, but the market’s starting to figure out what those signals will be.

Where are you seeing the best opportunities in the stock market?
Powers: I would call this a middling economy right now, if we were just looking at pure economic growth and the strength of the labor market. I wouldn’t characterize it as overly impressive by historical standards, certainly when adjusted for inflation. But the strength of the equity markets and of corporate

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RWA Wealth
Partners
#32

earnings has been impressive, and that’s where we operate for most clients.

While there is a lot to be concerned about geopolitically or even economically, if we look at how businesses are doing, it is hard to argue with the results. A lot of that is, of course, tied to the buildup of AI infrastructure, which has added a tremendous amount of capital investment globally. It has given equity investors something to stay excited about.

As far as opportunities to invest new dollars from here, I think it will be the services that will run on these AI platforms that can add real value for businesses and consumers for years to come. Those are the types of opportunities we’re most interested in right now. They could do well even if the global macro environment isn’t firing on all cylinders for the next several quarters or even couple of years.

Is it too soon to bet on specific companies?
Powers: It’s hard to pick the eventual winners and losers. But I might use the software space as an example. That market has been steamrolled this year, with the incumbent software companies left for dead, largely feeling like they’re going to be replaced by AI. It was nice to get some early results from firms like Salesforce, which were able to say, “Look, we’re going to be able to use these AI tools to our own benefit, and don’t forget about us.” And all of a sudden, that stock is being rewarded.

Let’s turn to your firm. How did RWA Wealth Partners come together?
Michelle Knight: RWA Wealth Partners came from the combination of Adviser

Investments and Ropes Wealth Advisors in mid-2023. I was the leader of Ropes Wealth Advisors, which had been wholly owned by law firm Ropes & Gray; we rebranded later that year. We are employee owned, with private-equity backing from Summit Partners, which is also Boston-based.

Who are your target clients, and what do you do for them?
Knight: One of the things we talked about before putting the two companies together that was so exciting was this idea that we could have a firm where clients could be served at every stage of their financial life. So, whether a client was accumulating wealth—working hard and saving money, taking care of their family, and thinking about retirement in the future—or having significant liquidity events like inheritance or the sale of a business, all the way through to legacy and wealth-transfer planning, the idea was to provide a team with a lot of experience and skills serving clients at those different stages.

So, we built two divisions within the company, one for private wealth and one for family office, and we have recruited and enhanced our team to have the skills to meet clients where they are.

Why did Ropes & Gray part with its wealth management business?
Knight: I was part of the team that set up the registered investment advisor for Ropes & Gray back in 2014. We opened our doors in 2015, formalizing what had been a trust and estates offering that dated to the founding of Ropes & Gray in 1865.

We grew into one of the top 10 RIA firms in New England, and we had big

BARRON'S SPECIAL REPORT

plans for our future. We wanted employee ownership. We wanted to think about a national service model. So we decided, together with Ropes & Gray, to spin out. We joined forces with another firm, Adviser Investments, which was right in our backyard, in Newton, Mass. I actually learned to drive in the parking lot of their offices, so it felt very familiar to me. I knew a lot of the advisors who worked there, and it felt like the two firms were thinking through how we wanted to grow.

Do you continue to have a client-referral relationship with Ropes & Gray?
Knight: We sure do, and as you can imagine, we've expanded our relationships with other law firms around the country that might have been reluctant to work with us when we were wholly owned by Ropes & Gray. We uniquely understand the needs of law firm partners themselves as successful professionals, and often their clients who are experiencing transactions and successful careers.

What's it like to be an RWA advisor? I would imagine the culture is somewhat buttoned-up, having sprouted out of a law firm.
Powers: That's a fair assessment. As well as being CIO, I'm also an advisor. I think Michelle has created a great team-oriented environment here, and led from the top. I think that approach resonates with clients. When we get together with them, they're typically in front of a full team rather than working with a single individual who's supposed to have all the answers to every question that comes up. We think this approach works better for clients, but also contributes to why we've been able to attract and retain such great people over the years.

One of the services you provide is connecting clients with healthcare advisors. Can you describe that?
Knight: We care about our clients and want to think about how we can help them marshal resources in times of great stress. So, we have developed a business relationship with a healthcare advisory firm. We might refer clients to them in an emergency moment or if it's more of just thinking through changes in memory or living in a supported community. Having those types of partners



From left: Michelle Knight, CEO and chief economist, and Joseph "JP" Powers, chief investment officer at RWA Wealth Partners in Boston.

has been powerful for us. It has been a gift to be able to offer that to people.

I've definitely seen more advisory firms venturing into the healthcare space, usually through partnerships.
Knight: Yes, and it's authentic to us. Some firms focus more on concierge services like aviation. We're probably more focused on health and longevity. And our clientele is multigenerational, so we like to help people within families take care of one another. That's more on brand for us.

Advisory fee models are evolving. What's your approach when you provide a range of services?
Knight: We really do want to offer comprehensive wealth management, and we want our clients to feel like they get a lot of value. Every client receives financial planning, investment management, tax planning, and estate planning strategies. That's all part of our standard fee structure. When we take a step further and are doing things like tax compliance, we typically charge flat fees. There can be situations where we will consider an

hourly rate. But we typically charge flat annual fees for services like tax compliance, estate settlement, certain types of consulting services or engagements, and project-based work.

How much of your growth strategy is adding one client at a time versus buying other firms?
Knight: We're primarily focused on organic growth. We have had some successful mergers and acquisitions and lift-outs in the past 18 months, which we're proud of. But when you do a great job for clients, they tell their friends, they tell their family, they tell their neighbors. That's our best sales strategy, and we've been fortunate to be able to grow in that way.

What is RWA's Wealth With Intention initiative?
Knight: That is like my beating heart. Jennifer Votano and Evelyn Pepe joined RWA last year to spearhead this initiative about educating, engaging, and empowering women and rising generations. We are doing this through education, with events, tools, and resources. It's about having a community and great conversations.

With every event we have, every dinner we host, every speaker we bring to the table, I feel so much pride that I'm running a firm that prioritizes and invests in this. Clients and the team love it. It takes a lot of work and a lot of resources to make those things happen and to build that community, but it just lights up and energizes a culture.

How do you walk the line between supporting your advisors and clients and keeping your private-equity partner happy?
Knight: What's exciting about having a partner like Summit Partners is they're a growth-oriented PE firm. Their focus is to support us in our growth plans and trajectory. Think about an athlete: How do you make them run faster and have more endurance?
Since I took leadership of the company, my dialogue with them and our full board has been relentlessly about our service and sales culture. It has been about how recruitment and retention of talent is the best growth strategy. It has been about how we can be in places where we can serve. How do we invest in things like Wealth With Intention that may not have an immediate return on investment but have an enormous spiritual ROI that comes from creating a community, not only for clients but also for employees?

In addition, I'm an advisor, as is JP, and that brings a unique perspective. When our leadership team speaks to our board, we're thinking about the strategy of the business and their interests, but we also have boots on the ground. On a personal note, I'm one of the only women leaders of a large wealth management firm in the country, and I have never felt a moment where I haven't felt full support. I have the incredible privilege of being in this position at a time when wealth is transferring in vast amounts to women stakeholders.

Thanks, Michelle and JP. 🙏

RWA Wealth Partners Boston			
Clients	5,976		
Advisors	43		
Offices	6		
States	4		

Top 100 RIA Firms 2026

Our 11th annual ranking of independent advisory companies is based on assets managed by the firms, growth, technology spending, succession planning, and other metrics.

MEDIAN CLIENT SIZE KEY:			
Under \$500K	\$500K-\$999K	\$1 mil-\$10 mil	Over \$10 mil

RANK	SIZE	FIRM	LOCATION	TOPEXECUTIVES	CLIENTS	ADVISORS	OFFICES	STATES
1		Mercer Advisors	Denver	Dave Welling, Daniel Gourvitch, Gün Keresteci	40,848	453	121	42
2		NewEdge Capital Group	Pittsburgh	James Jesse, Rob Sechan, Alex Goss	23,600	275	218	40
3		Cresset	Chicago	Susie Cranston, Avy Stein, Eric Becker	4,833	154	24	18
4		Pathstone	Englewood, N.J.	Matthew Fleissig, Kelly Maregni	2,364	197	20	14
5		Private Advisor Group	Morristown, N.J.	Frank Smith, Adam Schorr, James Perhacs	74,718	954	586	43
6		Wealthspire	New York	Mike LaMena, Carl Nelson, Eric Sontag	11,530	180	25	13
7		Beacon Pointe Advisors	Newport Beach, Calif.	Matthew Cooper, Commie Stevens, Shannon Eusey	28,000	207	93	26
8		CIBC Private Wealth	Atlanta	John S. "Jack" Markwalter Jr., Bruce D. Katz, Diana Vasquez	7,241	164	17	13
9		EP Wealth Advisors	Torrance, Calif.	Ryan Parker, Jorge Bernal	24,318	250	67	24
10		Steward Partners Investment Advisory	Stamford, Conn.	Jim Gold, Hy Saporta, Jeff Gonyo	59,326	318	81	31
11		Moneta	St. Louis	Eric Kittner, Keith Bowles	8,837	204	10	6
12		IEQ Capital	Foster City, Calif.	Robert Skinner, Alan Zafran, Eric Harrison	2,273	42	9	5
13		Carson Group	Omaha, Neb.	Burt White	62,840	545	147	45
14		Lido Advisors	Los Angeles	Jason Ozur, Ken Stern, Brian Haloossim	14,670	143	44	26
15		Allworth Financial	Folsom, Calif.	John Bunch, Pete Engelken, Darla Sipolt	28,574	198	42	20
16		SCS Financial	Boston	Tony Abbiati, Adrienne Penta, Lane MacDonald	536	82	11	10
17		First Manhattan	New York	Robert W. Gottesman, Zachary Wydra, Alvaro Spinola	3,600	31	5	5
18		Signature Estate & Investment Advisors	Los Angeles	Brian D. Holmes, Matthew Matrisian, Eric Rosen	20,346	164	33	21
19		MAI Capital Management	Cleveland	Rick Buoncore, Amy Brady, Jim Kacic	17,411	243	42	17
20		Sequoia Financial Group	Akron, Ohio	Thomas A. Haught, Annie McCauley, Kevin Tichnell	12,322	147	30	17
21		Savant Wealth Management	Rockford, Ill.	Brent Brodeski, Zach Ivey, Kevin Hrdlicka	23,079	253	70	28
22		HB Wealth	Atlanta	Thomas Carroll, Jamie Hennessy, Michael Woocher	5,242	162	12	6
23		Stratos Wealth Partners	Beachwood, Ohio	Jeff Concepcion, Kathy Louttit, Nancy Andrefsky	25,393	307	137	29
24		Integrated Partners	Waltham, Mass.	Paul Saganey, Andree Mohr, Ann Swartz	35,829	271	74	38
25		BBR Partners	New York	Brett Barth, Evan Roth, Michael Anson	205	32	6	6
26		Silvercrest Asset Management Group	New York	Richard Hough III, Scott Gerard, David Campbell	720	31	9	7
27		Waverly Advisors	Birmingham, Ala.	Justin T. Russell, Wayne LeSage, Justin Snell	17,509	166	53	22
28		Prime Capital Financial	Overland Park, Kan.	Glenn Spencer, Scott Colangelo, Tim Hakes	20,956	218	79	30
29		Brighton Jones	Seattle	Jon Jones, April Kyrkos, Bob Ho	4,393	162	26	19
30		Plante Moran Financial Advisors	Southfield, Mich.	John Lesser	4,012	106	14	5
31		ALTI Tiedemann Global	New York	Nancy Curtin	412	58	10	10
32		RWA Wealth Partners	Boston	Michelle Knight, Kristin Fazio, Joseph Powers	5,976	43	6	4
33		1919 Investment Counsel	Baltimore	Harry O'Mealia, Faith Mutunga, Nell Kelleher	3,501	45	7	7
34		Merit Financial Advisors	Alpharetta, Ga.	Rick Kent, Kay Lynn Mayhue, Chrissy Lee	25,173	175	71	21
35		Choreo	Rockford, Ill.	Jason Van de Loo, Molly McMillin, Matt Gottlin	7,965	164	42	33
36		Clearstead	Cleveland	Bradley D. Knapp, Aneet Deshpande, Mike Shebak	5,354	82	14	15
37		Modera Wealth Management	Westwood, N.J.	Tom Orecchio, Jim Kipp, Shelly Kapoor	5,918	71	19	9
38		Johnson Investment Counsel	Cincinnati	Jason O. Jackman, Bret H. Parrish, Fred A. Brink	5,380	48	6	2
39		Aspiriant	Los Angeles	Rob Francais, Lynne Born, Sandi Bragar	2,414	73	10	6
40		Evercore Wealth Management	New York	Chris Zander, Jeff Maurer	794	42	6	5
41		The Mather Group	Chicago	Jennifer des Groseilliers, Ryan Wickert, Kristen Oziemkowski	5,614	48	14	9
42		OnePoint BFG Wealth Partners	Parsippany, N.J.	Sam Cari, Vincent Nauheimer, Peter Boockvar	8,728	60	20	14
43		Coldstream Wealth Management	Bellevue, Wash.	Kevin Fitzwilson, Matt Sonnen, Josh Harris	4,192	63	9	4

TOP 100 INDEPENDENT ADVISORS 2026

Top 100 RIA Firms 2026

MEDIAN CLIENT SIZE KEY:

Under \$500K

\$500K-\$999K

\$1 mil-\$10 mil

Over \$10 mil

RANK	SIZE	FIRM	LOCATION	TOP EXECUTIVES	CLIENTS	ADVISORS	OFFICES	STATES
44		Mission Wealth Management	Santa Barbara, Calif.	Matthew Adams, Dannell Stuart, David Lee	5,302	86	48	24
45		Mesirow Financial Investment Management	Chicago	Richard S. Price, Brian D. Price, Darren Feld	5,075	37	22	13
46		Chevy Chase Trust	Bethesda, Md.	Jeff Whitaker, Amy Raskin, Marc Wishkoff	1,257	37	2	2
47		Baker Street Advisors	San Francisco	Christopher Wilkens, Wendy Umphrey, Jim Milligan	540	38	1	1
48		CLA Wealth Advisors	Minneapolis	Clayton Bland	7,400	84	45	22
49		Pure Financial Advisors	San Diego	Joseph Anderson, Jason Carver, Alan Clopine	8,038	74	13	7
50		Farther	New York	Taylor Matthews, Brad Genser, David Kilin	14,965	276	38	50
51		Ballentine Partners	Waltham, Mass.	Drew McMorrow, Jennifer Christian Murtie, Jayson DeAngelis	364	24	5	3
52		Valeo Financial Advisors	Carmel, Ind.	John T. Wortman, Justin M. Padgett, John C. Trott	3,084	100	7	6
53		SageSpring Wealth Partners	Franklin, Tenn.	Jeffrey Dobyns, Mark Deering, Brian Harding	11,547	85	9	6
54		Snowden Lane Partners	New York	Rob Mooney, Lyle Lamothe, Greg Franks	7,590	83	16	8
55		Curi Capital	Chicago	Dimitri P. Eliopoulos, Donald A. Bechter, Christopher M. Graff	3,192	50	11	9
56		Williams Jones Wealth Management	New York	William P. Jones Jr., John Eager, Barbara A. Tarmy	1,750	14	2	2
57		Wealthcare	Richmond, Va.	Matthew Regan, Justin DuBrueler, Ronald Madey	12,586	249	31	27
58		Gresham Partners	Chicago	Ted Neild, David Salsburg, Leisa Storbeck	199	12	1	1
59		Laird Norton Wetherby	San Francisco	Kristen Bauer, Ron Albahary	1,149	70	5	4
60		SignatureFD	Atlanta	Heather Fortner, David Fisher, Doug Liptak	1,966	40	2	2
61		Sapient Capital	Indianapolis	James Rooney	815	14	5	5
62		The Wealth Consulting Group	Las Vegas	Jimmy Lee, Andy Kalbaugh, Jason Ehrlich	12,940	132	56	15
63		Caprock	Boise, Idaho	William Gilbert, Jr., Greg Brown, Jefferson Jewell	467	31	11	9
64		NorthRock Partners	Minneapolis	Rob Nelson, Todd Moser, Jared Lorts	7,423	65	19	5
65		CW Advisors	Boston	Scott Dell’Orfano, Richard Villiotte, Ken Zannoni	6,426	55	23	11
66		Parallel Advisors	San Francisco	C.J. Rendic, Diane Gabianelli, Jake Schutt	4,182	59	14	50
67		Apollon Wealth Management	Mt. Pleasant, S.C.	Michael J. Dolberg, Robert H. Gorman, Michael Herman	9,894	103	43	21
68		Empirical Wealth Management	Seattle	Kenneth Smith, Lorne Enquist, Michael Kelly	2,415	28	18	8
69		Summit Financial	Parsippany, N.J.	Stan Gregor, Steven Weinman, Michael D’Amico	17,969	193	66	28
70		Composition Wealth	Los Angeles	Nate Angelo, Matthew Granski, Joe Salcido	5,150	48	9	6
71		Modern Wealth Management	Laguna Beach, Calif.	Gary Roth, Mike Capelle, Jason Gordo	14,284	114	24	17
72		Cary Street Partners	Richmond, Va.	Joseph R. Schmuckler, Walter D. Bayne, Wesley H. Gallup	7,111	78	21	7
73		U.S. Capital Wealth Advisors	Houston	David King, Pat Mendenhall, Jim Fortescue	6,745	65	8	4
74		Capital Investment Advisors	Atlanta	Mitch Reiner, Wes Moss, Matt Reiner	6,181	47	5	5
75		Bartlett Wealth Management	Cincinnati	James Hagerty, Holly Mazzocca, Chad Kolde	2,268	30	3	3
76		CV Advisors	Aventura, Fla.	Elliot Dornbusch, Matthew J. Storm, Alex Mann	156	5	1	1
77		Perigon Wealth Management	San Francisco	Arthur Ambarik, Jon Hoy, Rafia Hasan	5,849	74	20	14
78		Arax Advisory Partners	New York	Haig Ariyan, Diego Galan, Mike Riordan	15,662	230	38	13
79		HBKS Wealth Advisors	Erie, Pa.	Christopher M. Allegretti, Scott Cross, Brian Sommers	7,492	34	12	5
80		Crestwood Advisors	Boston	Michael Eckton, Leah Scibarrasi, John Morris	1,142	34	4	4
81		Forum Financial Management	Lombard, Ill.	Jonathan Rogers, Nirav Batavia	6,278	89	54	17
82		Welch & Forbes	Boston	Kurt Walter, Benjamin Williams Jr., Adrienne Silbermann	641	11	1	1
83		Ferguson Wellman Capital Management	Portland, Ore.	Steve Holwerda, George Hosfield, Ralph Cole	1,013	24	3	2
84		AlphaCore Wealth Advisory	La Jolla, Calif.	Richard Pfister, Brian Habas, Eric Gerster	3,000	38	11	9
85		Ashton Thomas Private Wealth	Scottsdale, Ariz.	Aaron Brodt, Haig Ariyan, Drinan Gorney	5,457	68	21	12
86		Ingalls & Snyder	New York	Robert A. Case, Keith Lane-Zucker, James Thatcher	4,500	34	3	3
87		Simon Quick Advisors	Morristown, N.J.	Christopher B. Moore, Joseph A. Belfatto, Thomas P. Morr	634	25	6	5
88		Bradley, Foster & Sargent	Hartford, Conn.	Galan G. Daukas, Robert H. Bradley, Thomas D. Sargent	1,947	21	9	6
89		F.L.Putnam Investment Management Co.	Lynnfield, Mass.	Tom Manning, Ellen Flaherty, Chris Parker	3,175	62	14	8
90		HUB Investment Partners	Austin, Texas	Scott Hauptmann, Dennis Bielik, Melissa Kirk	6,000	103	50	35
91		Joel Isaacson & Co.	New York	David Peltz, Robert Paul, Joshua Peltz	1,382	15	1	1
92		Robertson Stephens Wealth Management	San Francisco	Raj Bhattacharyya, Stuart Katz, Louis Calabrese	2,326	37	25	14
93		Chicago Partners Wealth Advisors	Chicago	Jim Hagedorn, Anthony Halpin, Nicholas Guido	3,009	37	3	3
94		Ritholtz Wealth Management	New York	Josh Brown, Kris Venne, Michael Batnick	4,261	35	14	11
95		Confluence Financial Partners	McMurray, Pa.	Greg Weimer, Gregory J. Weimer II	4,944	28	5	2
96		Evergreen Gavekal	Bellevue, Wash.	Tyler Hay, Michelle Watson, Jeff Dicks	1,157	15	5	3
97		WE Family Offices	Coral Gables, Fla.	Mel Lagomasino, Santiago Ulloa, Michael Zeuner	112	17	2	2
98		Mason Investment Advisory Services	Reston, Va.	Scott George, Chris Schreiner, Allison Gormier	875	21	1	1
99		Americana Partners	Houston	Jason Fertitta, Robert Wellington, Michael Mitchell	1,910	28	6	3
100		Truepoint Wealth Counsel	Cincinnati	Steve Condon, Katrina Hartsel, Courtney Weber	918	23	1	1

Top 100 Independent Advisors 2026

The 20th edition of our Top 100 ranking of independent financial advisors is based on quantitative and qualitative measures, including advisors’ assets under management, their revenue, their regulatory records, and more. For more on the methodology, go to [barrons.com/AdvisorRanks](#).

1. Charles C. Zhang

Zhang Financial

Portage, Mich.

2025 Rank: 1
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$11
Typical Account (mil): \$5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$8

2. Jon Goldstein

Cresset

Menlo Park, Calif.

2025 Rank: 3
Client Type: UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$24.9
Team Assets (bil): \$200
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$350

3. Spuds Powell

Kayne Anderson

Rudnick Investment Management

Los Angeles

2025 Rank: 4
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$48.1
Typical Account (mil): \$15
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

4. Richard Saperstein

Treasury Partners

New York

2025 Rank: 2
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$22.9
Typical Account (mil): \$15
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$30

5. Jonathan Kuttin

Ameriprise Financial

Hauppauge, N.Y.

2025 Rank: 5
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$18.7
Typical Account (mil): \$1.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$6

6. Erik Morgan

Freestone Capital

Management

Seattle

2025 Rank: 6
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$15.3
Typical Account (mil): \$35.2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$45.8

7. David Karp

Cresset

Reston, Va.

2025 Rank: 7
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$16.1
Typical Account (mil): \$60
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$65

8. Thomas Moran

Moran Wealth

Management

Naples, Fla.

2025 Rank: 9
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5.6
Typical Account (mil): \$5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

9. Erin Scannell

Ameriprise Financial

Mercer Island, Wash.

2025 Rank: 16
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$16.1
Typical Account (mil): \$4
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$8

10. David Kudla

Mainstay Capital

Management

Grand Blanc, Mich.

2025 Rank: 10
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5.3
Typical Account (mil): \$3
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$8

11. David Mabie

Chicago Capital

Chicago

2025 Rank: 8
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$24.9
Typical Account (mil): \$5.9
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$10

12. Paul Tramontano

Cresset

Greenwich, Conn.

2025 Rank: 15
Client Type: UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$24.9
Typical Account (mil): \$50
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$100

13. David Bahnsen

The Bahnsen Group

Newport Beach, Calif.

2025 Rank: 22
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$9.8
Typical Account (mil): \$12.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$20

14. Randy Carver

Carver Financial

Services

Mentor, Ohio

2025 Rank: 17
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Foundations
Team Assets (bil): \$3.9
Typical Account (mil): \$1.2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$2

15. Stephan Cassaday

Cassaday & Co.

McLean, Va.

2025 Rank: 19
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$8.2
Typical Account (mil): \$2.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$2

16. David Hou

Evoko, A Division of MAI

Los Angeles

2025 Rank: 20
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$7.2
Typical Account (mil): \$30
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$50

17. Kevin Grimes

Grimes & Company

Wealth Management

Westborough, Mass.

2025 Rank: 24
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$6.9
Typical Account (mil): \$7.1
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$14.2

18. Frank Marzano

Wealthspire Advisors

Boca Raton, Fla.

2025 Rank: 12
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$14.4
Typical Account (mil): \$5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$50

19. Thomas Salvino

Performance Wealth

Hinsdale, Ill.

2025 Rank: 11
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Foundations
Team Assets (bil): \$4.5
Typical Account (mil): \$15
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$30

20. Susan Kaplan

Kaplan Financial

Services

Newton, Mass.

2025 Rank: 23
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.9
Typical Account (mil): \$8
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$30

21. Edward Cronin

Manchester Capital

Management

Montecito, Calif.

2025 Rank: 21
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.3
Typical Account (mil): \$27
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$60

22. Daniel Wilson

Ameriprise Financial

Auburndale, Mass.

2025 Rank: 14
Client Types: Retail, HNW
Team Assets (bil): \$7.5
Typical Account (mil): \$1
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$5

23. Dagny Maidman

Cresset

Bozeman, Mont.

2025 Rank: 25
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Foundations
Team Assets (bil): \$6.5
Typical Account (mil): \$76
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$100

24. Ed Moldaver

Rockefeller Capital

Management

New York

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: UHNW, Foundations, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$3.5
Typical Account (mil): \$10
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$50

N=not ranked, HNW=high net worth, UHNW=ultrahigh net worth

BARRON'S SPECIAL REPORT

Top 100 Independent Advisors 2026

25. Thomas Bartholomew Bartholomew & Co.
Worcester, Mass.

2025 Rank: 13
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$6
Typical Account (mil): \$4.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$14.5

26. Terry Cook Parcion Private Wealth
Bellevue, Wash.

2025 Rank: 31
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.1
Typical Account (mil): \$21.2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$65

27. Dane Burkholder Ameriprise Financial
Lancaster, Pa.

2025 Rank: 27
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5.5
Typical Account (mil): \$1.4
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$5

28. Ryan Swartz Creative Planning
Omaha, Neb.

2025 Rank: 32
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5.9
Typical Account (mil): \$4.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$15

29. Richard S. Brown JNBA Financial Advisors
Bloomington, Minn.

2025 Rank: 35
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.2
Typical Account (mil): \$2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$3.5

30. Patti Brennan Key Financial
West Chester, Pa.

2025 Rank: 37
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3
Typical Account (mil): \$2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$4

31. Ash Chopra Syon Capital
San Francisco

2025 Rank: 60
Client Type: UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5.4
Typical Account (mil): \$60
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$100

32. Gerard Klingman Klingman & Associates
New York

2025 Rank: 30
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5.6
Typical Account (mil): \$15
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$18

33. Andrew Jugan Ameriprise Financial
Pittsburgh

2025 Rank: 28
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$7
Typical Account (mil): \$1.7
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$4.8

34. Jim Berliner Westmount Partners
Los Angeles

2025 Rank: 40
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Foundations
Team Assets (bil): \$7.1
Typical Account (mil): \$7.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$15

35. Andy Schwartz OnePoint BFG Wealth Partners
Parsippany, N.J.

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$3.1
Typical Account (mil): \$5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$15

36. Tony Smith Stonegate Investment Group
Birmingham, Ala.

2025 Rank: 38
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$7.2
Typical Account (mil): \$2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$50

37. Charlie Maxwell Cresset
Scottsdale, Ariz.

2025 Rank: 39
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Foundations
Team Assets (bil): \$11.2
Typical Account (mil): \$25
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$50

38. James Robbins Cresset
Minnetonka, Minn.

2025 Rank: 46
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Foundations
Team Assets (bil): \$11.2
Typical Account (mil): \$25
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$50

39. Matthew Somberg Gottfried & Somberg Wealth Management
Glastonbury, Conn.

2025 Rank: 42
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3
Typical Account (mil): \$8
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$10

40. Steven Check Check Capital Management
Costa Mesa, Calif.

2025 Rank: 26
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.4
Typical Account (mil): \$1
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$4

41. Trevor Wilde Wilde Wealth Management Group
Scottsdale, Ariz.

2025 Rank: 44
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$6
Typical Account (mil): \$0.8
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$3

42. Jay Beebe Creative Planning
Overland Park, Kan.

2025 Rank: 33
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.2
Typical Account (mil): \$5.7
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$15

43. Laila Pence Pence Wealth Management
Newport Beach, Calif.

2025 Rank: 41
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$4.8
Typical Account (mil): \$2.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$5

44. James Bogart Bogart Wealth
McLean, Va.

2025 Rank: 45
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.6
Typical Account (mil): \$2.4
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$3.3

45. Brenna Saunders Creative Planning
Overland Park, Kan.

2025 Rank: 29
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$4.2
Typical Account (mil): \$42.2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$100

46. Christopher Hall Hall Financial Advisors
Parkersburg, W.Va.

2025 Rank: 56
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.3
Typical Account (mil): \$1
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$1.7

47. Joel Bird Ameriprise Financial
Bismarck, N.D.

2025 Rank: 47
Client Types: Retail, HNW
Team Assets (bil): \$11.4
Typical Account (mil): \$3
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$4.5

48. Jessica Culpepper Creative Planning
Overland Park, Kan.

2025 Rank: 34
Client Type: UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$4.6
Typical Account (mil): \$48.7
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$100

49. Kimberlee Orth Ameriprise Financial
Wilmington, Del.

2025 Rank: 48
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$4.3
Typical Account (mil): \$9
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$21.4

50. David Arizini Cresset
Menlo Park, Calif.

2025 Rank: N
Client Type: UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$4
Typical Account (mil): \$60
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$100

51. Alex Shahidi Evoke, A Division of MAI
Los Angeles

2025 Rank: 53
Client Types: UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$18.2
Typical Account (mil): \$20
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

52. Robert Paolucci Principle Wealth Partners
Madison, Conn.

2025 Rank: 69
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.7
Typical Account (mil): \$10
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$20

53. Michael Caplan Invictus Private Wealth
Denver

2025 Rank: 64
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2
Typical Account (mil): \$5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$10

54. Molly Rothove Creative Planning
Overland Park, Kan.

2025 Rank: 36
Client Type: UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5.3
Typical Account (mil): \$66.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$100

55. Jeffery Chaddock Ameriprise Financial
Columbus, Ohio

2025 Rank: 50
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Foundations, Endowments
Team Assets (bil): \$7.5
Typical Account (mil): \$2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$3.6

56. Grant Rawdin Wescott Financial Advisory Group
Philadelphia

2025 Rank: 88
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$4.6
Typical Account (mil): \$6
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

57. Neil McPeak McPeak Wealth Mgmt | Wells Fargo Advisors
FiNet
Linwood, N.J.

2025 Rank: 58
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Foundations, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$2.8
Typical Account (mil): \$2.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$7.5

58. Jeremy Paul Perigon Wealth Management
Boca Raton, Fla.

2025 Rank: 70
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$11.6
Typical Account (mil): \$10
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

59. Stephen Thomas Linden Thomas & Co.
Charlotte, N.C.

2025 Rank: 54
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$3.4
Typical Account (mil): \$4.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$8

60. Robert Feighan Ameriprise Financial
Valhalla, N.Y.

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.9
Typical Account (mil): \$3.8
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$18

61. Diane Compardo Moneta Group
Clayton, Mo.

2025 Rank: 61
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$4.1
Typical Account (mil): \$15
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

62. Richard Miller Ameriprise Financial
Wellesley, Mass.

2025 Rank: 72
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.7
Typical Account (mil): \$0.9
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$1.8

63. Matthew Young Richard C. Young & Co.
Newport, R.I.

2025 Rank: 68
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$1.9
Typical Account (mil): \$2.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$5

64. Lewis Altfest Altfest Personal Wealth Management
New York

2025 Rank: 73
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.2
Typical Account (mil): \$2.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$5.5

65. Tim Werth Werth Wealth Management
Hays, Kan.

2025 Rank: 66
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Foundations, Endowments, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$2.3
Typical Account (mil): \$3
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$7

66. Jennifer Marcontell Ameriprise Financial
Mont Belvieu, Texas

2025 Rank: 86
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.4
Typical Account (mil): \$3.7
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$4.5

67. Darrell Pennington Ameriprise Financial
Houston

2025 Rank: 67
Client Types: Retail, HNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.2
Typical Account (mil): \$1.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$2.5

68. Michael Chasnoff Truepoint Wealth Counsel
Cincinnati

2025 Rank: 78
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$7.1
Typical Account (mil): \$5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$7

69. Barry Glassman Glassman Wealth Services
Vienna, Va.

2025 Rank: 77
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.9
Typical Account (mil): \$6.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$8

70. Patrick Fruzzetti Rose Advisors | Hightower
New York

2025 Rank: 65
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2
Typical Account (mil): \$7
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

71. Randy Garcia The Investment Counsel Company of Nevada
Las Vegas

2025 Rank: 76
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$2.4
Typical Account (mil): \$5.9
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

72. Thomas Lee Lee, Sipe & Associates
Rockville, Md.

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2
Typical Account (mil): \$3.2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$4.5

73. Joseph McLean MAI Capital Management
San Ramon, Calif.

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5.2
Typical Account (mil): \$4.2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$7.2

74. Lawrence Hood Waverly Advisors
Seattle

2025 Rank: 75
Client Types: HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$5.6
Typical Account (mil): \$10
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$15

75. George Papadoyannis Ameriprise Financial
San Mateo, Calif.

2025 Rank: 62
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.2
Typical Account (mil): \$3.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$12

76. Tom Freeman FCS Private Wealth Management & Family Office
Leawood, Kan.

2025 Rank: 83
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.6
Typical Account (mil): \$28
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$50

77. Timothy Sutton Creative Planning
Overland Park, Kan.

2025 Rank: 49
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.3
Typical Account (mil): \$3.7
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$15

78. Mike Delgass Wealthspire Advisors
New York

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$7.8
Typical Account (mil): \$29.1
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$184.1

79. Michael Moeller Moeller Investment Group
Chesterfield, Mo.

2025 Rank: 82
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$3.2
Typical Account (mil): \$2
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$7

80. Wen Nottebohm Cresset
Atlanta

2025 Rank: 71
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$10.8
Typical Account (mil): \$50
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$75

81. John J. Parker Sr. Parker Private Wealth Mgmt | Wells Fargo Advisors
FiNet
Wayne, Pa.

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Institutional
Team Assets (bil): \$2.3
Typical Account (mil): \$7.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$15

82. Jerrod Pearce Creative Planning
Overland Park, Kan.

2025 Rank: 57
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.9
Typical Account (mil): \$11
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$50

83. Michael Slaggie Slaggie Capital Group
Winona, Minn.

2025 Rank: 81
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW, Foundations, Endowments
Team Assets (bil): \$2.9
Typical Account (mil): \$1
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$0.3

84. Malcolm Makin Professional Planning Group
Westerly, R.I.

2025 Rank: 74
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2
Typical Account (mil): \$1.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$3

85. Charles Jones Ameriprise Financial
Dallas

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.2
Typical Account (mil): \$3.6
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$9.2

86. Brent Kiley Ameriprise Financial
Bedford, N.H.

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$8.5
Typical Account (mil): \$1.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$3

87. Andrew Fuller Creative Planning
Irvine, Calif.

2025 Rank: 96
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$5
Typical Account (mil): \$2.9
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$10

88. Carolyn Frager Creative Planning
Overland Park, Kan.

2025 Rank: 93
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.6
Typical Account (mil): \$8.9
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

89. James B. Stack Stack Financial Management
Whitefish, Mont.

2025 Rank: 63
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.1
Typical Account (mil): \$2.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$5

90. Jason Cerniglia Ameriprise Financial
Mystic, Conn.

2025 Rank: 85
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.1
Typical Account (mil): \$2.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$4.6

91. Jason Klein Ameriprise Financial
Portage, Mich.

2025 Rank: 59
Client Types: Retail, HNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.4
Typical Account (mil): \$0.6
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$1

92. Charla McIntyre Fields Ameriprise Financial
Hurst, Texas

2025 Rank: 79
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$3.4
Typical Account (mil): \$2.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$4.5

93. Michelle Young Ameriprise Financial
Edina, Minn.

2025 Rank: 84
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.1
Typical Account (mil): \$2.8
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$5.5

94. Gil Baumgarten Segment Wealth Management
Houston

2025 Rank: 89
Client Types: HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.4
Typical Account (mil): \$15
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$25

95. Virgil Kahl Spring Ridge Financial Group
Wyomissing, Pa.

2025 Rank: 91
Client Types: Retail, HNW
Team Assets (bil): \$1.9
Typical Account (mil): \$1.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$2.5

96. Joseph Chornyak Chornyak & Associates
Columbus, Ohio

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2
Typical Account (mil): \$5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$8

97. Aaron Tuttle Gatewood Wealth Solutions
St. Louis

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$1.7
Typical Account (mil): \$0.5
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$3

98. Ken Steeves Creative Planning
Milford, Conn.

2025 Rank: 80
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.7
Typical Account (mil): \$8
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$35

99. Andrew Meyer MAI Capital Management
Newport Beach, Calif.

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$2.9
Typical Account (mil): \$5.1
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$7.1

100. Travis Bezella Creative Planning
Bloomington, Minn.

2025 Rank: N
Client Types: Retail, HNW, UHNW
Team Assets (bil): \$6.5
Typical Account (mil): \$2.8
Typical Net Worth (mil): \$7

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